LINVUU COLLECTION VOLUME 1



Olá

Portuguese

Practical grammar, from zero to A2

Volume 1 · Level A1 – A2

Linvuu

PRACTICAL GRAMMAR

Contents

START HERE **How to use this book** 6

0.1 How to study with this book 6
0.2 Brazilian and European Portuguese 6
0.3 What A1 and A2 mean 7
0.4 How to read the pronunciation guides 7
0.5 What you will find in each lesson 7
0.6 The map of the book 8
0.7 Before you start 8

LESSON 1 **Sounds and spelling: how to read Portuguese out loud** 9

1.1 A scene you will live 9
1.2 The good news: you already know more than you think 9
1.3 How to read the pronunciation guides in this book 10
1.4 The alphabet and the letter names 10
1.5 The oral vowels 11
1.6 Nasal vowels: the sound English does not have 12
1.7 Diphthongs: two vowels in one syllable 13
1.8 The consonants 14
1.9 The Portuguese R 15
1.10 Stress: which syllable is strong 15
1.11 What each mark does 16
1.12 The survival phrases 16
1.13 Read a real text 17
1.14 The mistakes English speakers make 17
1.15 Practice 18
1.16 Pocket summary: Lesson 1 20
1.17 What comes next 20

LESSON 2 **Ser, pronouns and adjectives: who you are** 22

2.1 A scene you will live 22
2.2 The trap: three habits to leave at the door 23
2.3 The subject pronouns 23
2.4 The verb ser 24
2.5 The subject can disappear 25
2.6 Saying who you are: name, origin, profession 25
2.7 Adjectives: they agree with the person 27
2.8 Nationalities and countries 29
2.9 Describing people with ser 30
2.10 Age: ser is the wrong verb 30
2.11 Read a real text 30
2.12 The mistakes English speakers make 31
2.13 Practice 31
2.14 Return 34
2.15 Pocket summary: Lesson 2 35
2.16 What comes next 35

LESSON 3 **Nouns, articles, gender and number: the shape of a noun phrase** 36

3.1 A scene you will live 36
3.2 The trap: everything has a gender 37
3.3 Gender: how to guess 37

3.4 The definite article: o, a, os, as 39
3.5 The indefinite article: um, uma, uns, umas 40
3.6 Plurals: one rule for vowels, four for consonants 40
3.7 Contractions: em, de, por and the article 42
3.8 Say it all together 43
3.9 The mistakes English speakers make 44
3.10 Practice 44
3.11 Return 47
3.12 Pocket summary: Lesson 3 48
3.13 What comes next 48

LESSON 4 The present tense, negation and questions: say what you do 49

4.1 A scene you will live 49
4.2 The trap: English hides the person, Portuguese shows it 50
4.3 How a verb is built 50
4.4 Twenty-five regular verbs to start with 51
4.5 Using the present tense 52
4.6 Making a negative: não 52
4.7 Asking questions 53
4.8 The irregular verbs you already need 54
4.9 A mini-interview: ask, answer, return the question 55
4.10 Read a real text 55
4.11 The mistakes English speakers make 56
4.12 Practice 56
4.13 Return 59
4.14 Pocket summary: Lesson 4 60
4.15 What comes next 60

LESSON 5 Estar, ter, haver: ser or estar, and “there is” 61

5.1 A scene you will live 61
5.2 The trap: one “to be” in English, two in Portuguese 62
5.3 Estar: how you are, where you are 62
5.4 Saying where things are 63
5.5 Ter: to have, and much more 64
5.6 “There is”: tem, há and existir 65
5.7 Ser × estar: the great contrast 65
5.8 The contractions of place: ao, à, daqui, pra and pro 66
5.9 Tem or está? Introducing a thing, and locating a known thing 67
5.10 Read a real text 68
5.11 The mistakes English speakers make 68
5.12 Practice 68
5.13 Return 71
5.14 Pocket summary: Lesson 5 72
5.15 What comes next 72

LESSON 6 Numbers, time, dates and prices: the practical lesson 73

6.1 A scene you will live 73
6.2 The trap: plural hours, genders in numbers, and decimal commas 74
6.3 Numbers from zero to twenty 74
6.4 From twenty-one to ninety-nine 75
6.5 Hundreds, thousands and millions 75
6.6 Ordinal numbers 76
6.7 What time is it? 77
6.8 Days, months and dates 78
6.9 Prices and money 79
6.10 Numbers in real situations: quantities, amounts and bargains 80

6.11 Read a real text 80
6.12 The mistakes English speakers make 81
6.13 Practice 81
6.14 Return 84
6.15 Pocket summary: Lesson 6 85
6.16 What comes next 85
LESSON 7 Irregular essentials and modals: go, do, can, want, know 86
7.1 A scene you will live 86
7.2 The trap: irregular, but in a pattern 87
7.3 Ir: to go 87
7.4 Fazer: to do, to make 88
7.5 Vir: to come 88
7.6 More verbs with an irregular eu form 88
7.7 The modal verbs: poder, querer, saber, dever, precisar 89
7.8 Saber × conhecer 91
7.9 Asking, offering, inviting: the language of daily life 91
7.10 One event, five attitudes 92
7.11 Read a real text 93
7.12 The mistakes English speakers make 93
7.13 Practice 93
7.14 Return 96
7.15 Pocket summary: Lesson 7 97
7.16 What comes next 97
LESSON 8 Possessives, demonstratives, liking and preferring 98
8.1 A scene you will live 98
8.2 The trap: English counts owners, Portuguese counts things 99
8.3 The possessives of the speaker, of the listener and of “us” 99
8.4 The big ambiguity: seu, sua, dele, dela 100
8.5 This, that, that over there: the demonstratives 101
8.6 Aqui, aí, ali, lá: the place words that go with them 103
8.7 Gostar: you always need “de” 103
8.8 Preferir: choosing between two things 104
8.9 Muito and pouco: sometimes they agree and sometimes they do not 105
8.10 Putting it all together 106
8.11 The mistakes English speakers make 107
8.12 Practice 107
8.13 Return 109
8.14 Pocket summary: Lesson 8 110
8.15 What comes next 110
LESSON 9 Reflexives, routines, ir + infinitive and estar + gerund 111
9.1 A scene you will live 111
9.2 The trap: why does Portuguese say “I raise myself”? 112
9.3 The reflexive pronouns 112
9.4 Which verbs are reflexive in Brazil? 113
9.5 Your day, in order 114
9.6 Ir + infinitive: the everyday future 115
9.7 Estar + gerund: what is happening now 116
9.8 Putting it together 118
9.9 The mistakes English speakers make 118
9.10 Practice 119
9.11 Return 121
9.12 Pocket summary: Lesson 9 122
9.13 What comes next 122

LESSON 10 The simple past: what happened 123
10.1 A scene you will live 123
10.2 The trap: English has a past with one form, Portuguese has one for each person 124
10.3 The regular endings 124
10.4 The irregular verbs you cannot avoid 125
10.5 When to use the simple past 127
10.6 Questions, negatives and short answers 128
10.7 A few verbs worth meeting in the past 129
10.8 What about “tenho comido”? 129
10.9 Putting it together 129
10.10 The mistakes English speakers make 130
10.11 Practice 130
10.12 Return 132
10.13 Pocket summary: Lesson 10 133
10.14 What comes next 133
LESSON 11 The imperfect, and choosing between the two pasts 134
11.1 A scene you will live 134
11.2 The trap: English has three ways to say it, Portuguese has one tense and a choice 135
11.3 The forms: easy, and almost without exceptions 135
11.4 What the imperfect does 136
11.5 Choosing between the two pasts 138
11.6 For recognition: the past before the past 139
11.7 Telling a story: a model 140
11.8 The mistakes English speakers make 140
11.9 Practice 141
11.10 Return 143
11.11 Pocket summary: Lesson 11 144
11.12 What comes next 144
LESSON 12 Object pronouns and where Brazilians put them 145
12.1 A scene you will live 145
12.2 The trap: English puts “it” and “him” after the verb, Portuguese puts “me” and “you” before it 146
12.3 The pronouns: direct and indirect objects 146
12.4 Where the pronoun goes in Brazilian speech 147
12.5 Him, her, them: “vi ele” and “eu o vi” 148
12.6 To him, to her, to them: “dei pra ele” 149
12.7 After a preposition: mim and eu 150
12.8 What to say when you ask for something 151
12.9 Putting it together 151
12.10 The mistakes English speakers make 152
12.11 Practice 152
12.12 Return 154
12.13 Pocket summary: Lesson 12 155
12.14 What comes next 155
LESSON 13 Comparing, giving instructions, asking politely, por and para, and que 156
13.1 A scene you will live 156
13.2 Comparing 157
13.3 Giving instructions: the imperative 158
13.4 Asking politely 160
13.5 Por and para 162
13.6 Joining ideas: que 163
13.7 Putting it together 164
13.8 The mistakes English speakers make 164
13.9 Practice 165

13.10 Return 167
13.11 Pocket summary: Lesson 13 168
13.12 A2 checkpoint 168
13.13 What comes next 169

START HERE

How to use this book

This book teaches you the Portuguese that Brazilians speak, from your first greeting to telling a story about last weekend. It is built for adults who speak English, who have little or no Portuguese, and who want to be understood in real situations: a café, a hostel, a job interview, a dinner with a Brazilian family. It is not a phrasebook. It explains why Portuguese works the way it does, using the habits of English as the starting point, so that you can build your own sentences instead of repeating someone else's.

0.1 How to study with this book

Read one lesson in three or four sittings, not one. A lesson has about 4,000 to 6,000 words, and your memory will not absorb that in an hour. A good rhythm is twenty or thirty minutes a day:

1. **Day 1.** Read the opening scene aloud and the first explanations. Do not try to memorize anything.
2. **Day 2.** Finish the lesson. Say every example out loud, not in your head. Portuguese lives in the mouth.
3. **Day 3.** Do the practice, check the answer key, and write down the mistakes you made. Those mistakes are your real syllabus.
4. **Day 4 and after.** Answer the three questions in the **Return** section, which bring back earlier lessons just when you are about to forget them.

Four habits make the biggest difference:

- **Speak from the first day.** Say the sentences, answer the questions in the practice aloud, and talk to yourself in the shower. A sentence you have said ten times is a sentence you own.
- **Learn blocks, not single words.** Learn Moro em Londres ("I live in London") as one piece, then change the city. The book gives you many such blocks.
- **Use the audio.** Every example has audio in the Linvuu course at linvuu.com.br. Listen first, repeat second.
- **Welcome your mistakes.** Brazilians are generous with learners, and each correction teaches you more than a page of rules.

0.2 Brazilian and European Portuguese

Portuguese is the official language of nine countries, and roughly 200 million of its speakers live in Brazil. This book teaches **Brazilian Portuguese**, the variety you will hear in Brazilian cities, films, music, podcasts and business meetings.

The two main standards are the same language, in the way American and British English are the same language. A Brazilian and a Portuguese person understand each other without trouble in writing and, with a little patience, in speech. The differences you should know about:

	BRAZIL	PORTUGAL
Sound	open, clear vowels; final *e* sounds like *ee*; *t* and *d* before *i* become *tch* and *dj*	many unstressed vowels almost disappear; *s* at the end of a syllable sounds like *sh*
Words	ônibus, trem, café da manhã, celular, banheiro	autocarro, comboio, pequeno-almoço, telemóvel, casa de banho

	BRAZIL	PORTUGAL
"You"	**você** for almost everyone	**você** is used less; **tu** and the person's name or title are more common
Progressive	**Estou trabalhando**	**Estou a trabalhar**
Pronouns	**Me ajuda**, **Eu vi ele** in speech	**Ajuda-me**, **Vi-o**

Since the 2009 spelling reform, the two spellings are almost identical, with a few words that still differ (**fato** in Brazil, **facto** in Portugal). When the European form matters, the book gives it in a short note, and that is all. If you later move to Lisbon, you will need a few weeks to adjust your ear, not a new course.

Brazil itself has many accents: the *sh*-like *s* of Rio, the open vowels of the Northeast, the clear *r* of the South. The pronunciation guides in this book describe the standard you hear in São Paulo and on national television, which is understood everywhere.

0.3 What A1 and A2 mean

Language levels follow the Common European Framework of Reference, known as the CEFR. You will see two of its levels here.

A1, the beginner. You can introduce yourself and others, ask and answer simple questions about where you live and what you have, use numbers, times and prices, and take part in a slow, friendly conversation. Lessons 1 to 8 give you this base.

A2, the elementary user. You can describe your routine, talk about past events, shop, ask for directions, make polite requests and write short messages about familiar things. Lessons 9 to 13 take you there.

These levels are modest, and that is the point. A1 and A2 are where learners most often stall, because the verbs, the pronouns and the two past tenses all arrive at once. This book slows down exactly there. When you finish, you will not speak like a native, but you will be able to live a normal day in Portuguese and keep learning on your own.

0.4 How to read the pronunciation guides

Next to new Portuguese words you will see a guide in backticks, like `bah-NAH-nah`. It is written with English sounds, so you do not need a special alphabet. Capital letters mark the stressed syllable. A tilde (`~`) marks a nasal vowel. The letters `tch` and `dj` stand for the sounds in *church* and *judge*, `zh` for the *s* in *measure*, `ly` and `ny` for the Portuguese *lh* and *nh*, and a plain `h` at the start of a word for the Brazilian *r*.

Lesson 1 explains the whole system in section 1.3 and teaches the sounds behind it. If a guide ever looks strange, go back to that table. After a few weeks you will stop needing the guides, and the book gradually gives them only for new words.

For **o**, the guide writes the open sound as `aw` and the closed sound as `oh`. One honest limit: a guide cannot show the melody of a sentence or the difference between an open and a closed **e** (both are written `eh`). Use the audio for those.

0.5 What you will find in each lesson

Every lesson has the same shape, so you always know where you are:

- an opening **scene**, a short situation you could really live, so that the grammar has a purpose
- numbered sections (2.1, 2.2, and so on) that build the idea step by step
- **Tip** boxes for shortcuts and **Watch out** boxes for traps
- **Typical mistakes** tables in three columns: *Wrong*, *Right*, *Why*. The wrong sentences are what English speakers really say; the *Why* column names the habit behind each one
- **Practice** in five parts, A to E, going from recognizing to producing
- an **Answer key** that explains the tricky items, not only the answers
- a **Return** section with three questions from earlier lessons
- a **Pocket summary** you can photograph and keep on your phone

0.6 The map of the book

LESSON	TOPIC	LEVEL
1	Sounds and spelling: how to read Portuguese out loud	A1
2	**Ser**, pronouns and adjectives: who you are	A1
3	Nouns, articles, gender and number	A1
4	The present tense, negation and questions	A1
5	**Estar**, **ter**, **haver**: where, how, what there is	A1
6	Numbers, time, dates and prices	A1
7	Irregular essentials and modals: **ir**, **fazer**, **poder**, **querer**, **saber**	A1
8	Possessives, demonstratives, **gostar**, **preferir**	A1
9	Routines, reflexive verbs, the near future and the progressive	A1–A2
10	The simple past: **pretérito perfeito**	A2
11	The imperfect, and choosing between the two pasts	A2
12	Object pronouns and how Brazilians place them	A2
13	Comparing, giving orders, polite requests, **por** and **para**	A2

Begin with Lesson 1, even if you think you can read Portuguese. The sounds are the foundation, and an hour spent there will pay back in every other lesson.

0.7 Before you start

Decide three things now. When in the day will you study? A fixed time beats a good intention. Where can you speak aloud without feeling shy? And who can you greet in Portuguese this week? The sooner someone hears your first **Bom dia**, the sooner this book becomes real. Turn the page, and let us start with the sounds.

LESSON 1

Sounds and spelling: how to read Portuguese out loud

By the end of this lesson you can read any Portuguese word aloud and be understood, spell your name with the Portuguese letter names, put the stress on the right syllable, and say the polite phrases you will use every day in Brazil.

1.1 A scene you will live

You walk into a padaria in São Paulo at 7 a.m. The woman behind the counter says, very fast: **Bom dia! Tudo bem? O que vai ser?** You understand almost nothing, and you panic. Then she points at the coffee machine, and you hear yourself say **Um café, por favor**. She smiles. **Pra viagem?** You nod. You have just had your first conversation in Portuguese.

Everything in this lesson exists to make that moment calm instead of frightening. Not grammar yet, not vocabulary yet: **sound**. If your mouth knows the sounds, every word you learn afterwards arrives already pronounceable. If it does not, every word is a small struggle.

1.2 The good news: you already know more than you think

Look at these words. You can already read most of them, and Brazilians use them every day:

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE	HOW IT SOUNDS
chocolate	**chocolate**	shoh-koh-LAH-tchee
hotel	**hotel**	oh-TEH-oo
banana	**banana**	bah-NAH-nah
family	**família**	fah-MEE-lyah
important	**importante**	ee~-por-TAH~-tchee
restaurant	**restaurante**	heh-stow-RAH~-tchee
animal	**animal**	ah-nee-MAH-oo
nation	**nação**	nah-SOW~

Thousands of English words come from Latin, and so does Portuguese, so you start with a huge vocabulary. The words look familiar; the **sounds** are different. That is exactly what this lesson fixes.

The second piece of good news is that Portuguese spelling is far more regular than English. English has “though”, “through”, “tough” and “cough”. Portuguese has rules, and they nearly always work. Learn the rules once and you can read new words with confidence.

> TIP
>
> **The only secret of pronunciation:** listen first, then repeat out loud. Reading silently teaches your eyes, not your mouth. Every example in this book has audio in the Linvuu course at linvuu.com.br. Use it.

1.3 How to read the pronunciation guides in this book

Next to many Portuguese words you will see a guide like `bah-NAH-nah`. It is an approximation written with English sounds, so you can read it without learning a new alphabet. The rules are few:

IN THE GUIDE	MEANS	EXAMPLE
CAPITAL LETTERS	the stressed syllable (say it stronger and longer)	obrigado `oh-bree-GAH-doo`
`~` after a vowel	nasal vowel: air goes through the nose (Lesson 1.6)	não `NOW~`
`tch` and `dj`	as in *church* and *judge*	noite `NOY-tchee`, dia `DJEE-ah`
`zh`	as the *s* in *measure*	hoje `OH-zhee`
`sh`	as in *ship*	xícara `SHEE-kah-rah`
`ly`, `ny`	the Portuguese *lh* and *nh*	filho `FEE-lyoo`, amanhã `ah-mah-NYAH~`
`h`	the Brazilian *r* at the start of a word: like English *h* in *hot*	rua `HOO-ah`
`oo` at the end	the Portuguese final *l* or *-o*: like *oo* in *zoo*	Brasil `brah-ZEE-oo`

The guide is a bridge, not the destination. After a few weeks you will stop needing it. For **o**, the guide writes the open sound as `aw` (avó `ah-VAW`, hora `AW-rah`) and the closed sound as `oh` (avô `ah-VOH`, bolo `BOH-loo`). Its limits are honest ones: it cannot show the difference between the open and the closed *e*, which are both written `eh` (the accent marks help, see 1.5), and it cannot show the melody of a sentence. For those, listen.

1.4 The alphabet and the letter names

Portuguese uses the same 26 letters as English. The letters **k**, **w** and **y** are used mostly in foreign words and abbreviations (the 2009 spelling reform made them official). What changes is the **name** of each letter, and you need the names whenever someone asks you to spell something: your name at a hotel, your e-mail at a bank, your street for a delivery.

LETTER	NAME	GUIDE	EXAMPLE
A a	á	`ah`	amigo (friend)
B b	bê	`beh`	bom (good)
C c	cê	`seh`	casa (house)
D d	dê	`deh`	dia (day)
E e	é	`eh`	escola (school)
F f	efe	`EH-fee`	família (family)
G g	gê	`zheh`	gato (cat)
H h	agá	`ah-GAH`	hotel (hotel)
I i	i	`ee`	ilha (island)
J j	jota	`ZHAW-tah`	janeiro (January)

LETTER	NAME	GUIDE	EXAMPLE
K k	**cá**	kah	**kiwi** (kiwi)
L l	**ele**	EH-lee	**livro** (book)
M m	**eme**	EH-mee	**mãe** (mother)
N n	**ene**	EH-nee	**nome** (name)
O o	**ó**	aw	**obrigado** (thank you)
P p	**pê**	peh	**pão** (bread)
Q q	**quê**	keh	**queijo** (cheese)
R r	**erre**	EH-hee	**rua** (street)
S s	**esse**	EH-see	**sol** (sun)
T t	**tê**	teh	**tarde** (afternoon)
U u	**u**	oo	**uva** (grape)
V v	**vê**	veh	**vinho** (wine)
W w	**dáblio**	DAH-blee-oo	**web** (web)
X x	**xis**	sheess	**xícara** (cup)
Y y	**ípsilon**	EEP-see-loh~	**yoga** (yoga)
Z z	**zê**	zeh	**zero** (zero)

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Four names trip up English speakers every time. **G** is not *gee*: it is **gê**. **J** is not *jay*: it is **jota**. **E** is not *ee*: it is **é**. **I** is not *eye*: it is **i**, like the *ee* in *see*. Say them out loud ten times; people will hear them constantly.

The letter H is silent. **Hotel** oh-TEH-oo, **hoje** OH-zhee, **homem** OH-meh~ee. It only does something inside three digraphs: **ch** sh and **lh** ly, and **nh** ny (see 1.8).

To spell an e-mail, say **arroba** for @ and **ponto** for the dot: **ana ponto silva arroba exemplo ponto com ponto bê erre** is ana.silva@exemplo.com.br.

1.5 The oral vowels

Portuguese writes five vowel letters (a, e, i, o, u), but you hear more than five sounds, because **e** and **o** each have an open and a closed version. The vowels are **pure**: unlike English, you do not glide. English speakers say *day* as "day-ee" and *go* as "go-oo". In Portuguese, stop the sound before the glide starts.

1 Learn the five clean vowels

Keep your tongue and lips still while the sound lasts. Do not let it slide.

LETTER	SOUND	LIKE ENGLISH…	EXAMPLE
a (stressed)	open *ah*	*father*	**casa** KAH-zah, **pá** pah
e (stressed, é)	open *eh*	*bed*	**café** kah-FEH, **pé** peh
e (stressed, ê)	closed *eh*	*say*, but cut off before the glide	**você** voh-SEH, **mesa** MEH-zah
i	*ee*	*see*	**aqui** ah-KEE, **vida** VEE-dah
o (stressed, ó)	open *aw*	*thought* (US: *dog*)	**avó** ah-VAW, **pó** paw
o (stressed, ô)	closed *oh*	*go*, but cut off before the glide	**avô** ah-VOH, **povo** POH-voo

LETTER	SOUND	LIKE ENGLISH...	EXAMPLE
u	*oo*	*food*	uva OO-vah, tudo TOO-doo

2 **Know that the accent marks tell you open or closed**

The acute accent (´) marks a stressed vowel that is **open**: café, avó, pé. The circumflex (^) marks a stressed vowel that is **closed**: você, avô, bebê. Without a mark, you will learn the sound word by word. The difference matters because it can change the meaning: avó is *grandmother* and avô is *grandfather*.

3 **Weaken the vowels at the end of a word**

When a vowel is **unstressed and at the end of a word**, it becomes weak and short:

- final **-e** sounds like a short *ee*: noite NOY-tchee, grande GRAH~-djee, desculpe djees-KOOL-pee
- final **-o** sounds like a short *oo*: tudo TOO-doo, obrigado oh-bree-GAH-doo, livro LEE-vroo
- final **-a** is a relaxed *ah*, close to the last vowel of *sofa*: casa, pessoa peh-SOH-ah

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~oh-bree-GAH-doh~~	oh-bree-GAH-doo	in obrigado the final -o is a weak *oo*
~~NOY-teh~~	NOY-tchee	in noite the final -e is a weak *ee*, and *t* before *i* becomes *tch*
~~voh-SAY-ee~~	voh-SEH	in você there is no glide: stop the vowel cleanly
~~kah-FAY~~	kah-FEH	in café, é is an open *eh*, as in *bed*

1.6 Nasal vowels: the sound English does not have

This is the single biggest surprise for English speakers, and mastering it changes how your whole Portuguese sounds. A **nasal vowel** is a vowel pronounced with air flowing through the nose as well as the mouth. You make it by saying the vowel while thinking of the *ng* of *sing*, **without** closing your mouth on a final *n* or *m*.

English has nasal vowels only as a side effect (the vowel in *sing* or *can't* is slightly nasal), never as a sound of its own. Portuguese uses them to tell words apart, and they are among the most frequent sounds in the language.

1 **Spot the nasal signs**

Portuguese marks nasal vowels in three ways:

- a **tilde** (~) over **ã** and **õ**: mãe, pão, limões
- a vowel followed by **m** or **n** before another consonant: tempo, onde, campo, quinto, um
- a final **-m** after a vowel: bom, sim, bem, tem, um

2 **Say the vowel through the nose, and stop**

The *m* or *n* is not a separate consonant sound. It is only the sign that the vowel is nasal. Do not close your lips on bom: say BOH~ and stop.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
sim	SEE~	yes
bem	BEH~ee	well, fine
bom	BOH~	good
um	OO~	one, a

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
não	NOW~	no
pão	POW~	bread
mão	MOW~	hand
mãe	MAH~ee	mother
muito	MOO~ee-too	very, a lot
limão	lee-MOW~	lemon, lime
coração	koh-rah-SOW~	heart
pensar	peh~-SAR	to think

Three endings need special attention because you will use them all the time:

- **-ão** (stressed): **pão**, **não**, **coração**. A nasal *ow*, one syllable.
- **-am** and **-em** (unstressed endings of third-person plural verbs): **falam** FAH-lah~oo ends in a short nasal *ow*; **comem** KAW-meh~ee ends in a nasal *ay*.
- **-ões** and **-ães**: the plural of words in **-ão**: **limões** lee-MOH~eess, **pães** PAH~eess.

HOW IT COMPARES

IN ENGLISH	IN PORTUGUESE
"song", "sing": the *ng* is a consonant you close with the tongue	**bom**, **sim**: no consonant at all, only a nasal vowel
nasal sound is accidental and changes no meaning	**pão** (bread) ≠ **pau** (stick); **mão** (hand) ≠ **mau** (bad); **lã** (wool) ≠ **lá** (there)

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~NOWN~~	NOW~	in **não**, do not add a clear *n* at the end
~~BOHM, with closed lips~~	BOH~	in **bom**, close with the nose, not with the lips
~~PAH-oh (two syllables)~~	POW~	**pão** is a single syllable
~~SIM, as in *simple*~~	SEE~	in **sim** the vowel is *ee*, nasal

1.7 Diphthongs: two vowels in one syllable

A **diphthong** is two vowels pronounced in a single syllable, the second one weak.
In Portuguese they are written with **i** or **u** as the second element.

WRITTEN	SOUNDS LIKE	EXAMPLE
ai	*eye*	**pai** pie (father), **mais** mice (more)
ei	*ay* (as in *day*)	**feito** FAY-too (done), **beijo** BAY-zhoo (kiss)
oi	*oy*	**oi** oy (hi), **noite** NOY-tchee
ui	*oo-ee*	**muito** MOO~ee-too, **fui** FOO-ee
au	*ow* (as in *cow*)	**causa** KOW-zah (cause), **pausa** POW-zah
eu	*eh-oo*	**meu** MEH-oo (my), **europeu** eh-oo-roh-PEH-oo
ou	usually a short *oh*	**ou** oh (or), **pouco** POH-koo (little)
iu	*ee-oo*	**viu** VEE-oo (saw)

TIP

Ou is written with **u**, but in everyday Brazilian speech it is nearly a plain *oh*. Do not say *ow*: **pouco** is `POH-koo`, never "POW-koo".

1.8 The consonants

Good news first: **b, d, f, k, m, n, p, t, v, z** sound much like English. Aim for a softer *t* and *d*, with the tongue touching the back of the upper teeth rather than the ridge behind them; do not puff air after *p*, *t* and *k*. Now the ones that need your attention.

Seven consonants that work differently

LETTER(S)	WHERE	SOUND	EXAMPLE
c	before a, o, u	hard *k*	**casa** `KAH-zah`, **cor** `kor`, **cuidado** `kwee-DAH-doo`
c	before e, i	*s*	**cedo** `SEH-doo` (early), **cinco** `SEE~-koo` (five)
ç	before a, o, u	*s*	**coração**, **açúcar** `ah-SOO-kar` (sugar)
g	before a, o, u	hard *g*	**gato** `GAH-too`, **gosto** `GOHS-too`
g	before e, i	*zh* (as in *measure*)	**gente** `ZHEH~-tchee` (people), **gelo** `ZHEH-loo` (ice)
gu, **qu**	before e, i	*g*, *k* (the **u** is silent)	**guerra** `GEH-hah` (war), **queijo** `KAY-zhoo`, **aqui** `ah-KEE`
qu, **gu**	before a, o	*kw*, *gw* (the **u** is pronounced)	**quatro** `KWAH-troo` (four), **água** `AH-gwah` (water)
j	always	*zh*	**janeiro** `zhah-NAY-roo`, **hoje** `OH-zhee`, **jogo** `ZHOH-goo`
s	at the start, or **ss**	*s*	**sol** `SAW-oo`, **passo** `PAH-soo` (step)
s	between vowels	*z*	**casa** `KAH-zah`, **mesa** `MEH-zah` (table), **rosa** `HAW-zah`
z	always	*z*	**zero** `ZEH-roo`, **feliz** `feh-LEES` (final **z** often sounds like *s*)
x	most words	*sh*	**xícara** `SHEE-kah-rah`, **peixe** `PAY-shee` (fish)
x	some words	*ks*	**táxi** `TAHK-see`, **tóxico** `TAWK-see-koo`
x	some words	*z*	**exemplo** `eh-ZEH~-ploo`, **exame** `eh-ZAH-mee`
ch	always	*sh*	**chá** `shah` (tea), **chuva** `SHOO-vah` (rain)

TIP

The x has four sounds: *sh* (**caixa**), *ks* (**táxi**), *z* (**exemplo**), *s* (**próximo** `PRAW-see-moo`). There is no rule you can apply from the spelling; learn each new word with its sound. The good news: the *sh* sound is by far the most common.

Three digraphs you will see in every sentence

WRITTEN	SOUND	EXAMPLE
lh	`ly`, like the *lli* in *million*	**filho** `FEE-lyoo` (son), **trabalho** `trah-BAH-lyoo` (work)
nh	`ny`, like the *ni* in *onion*	**amanhã** `ah-mah-NYAH~` (tomorrow), **vinho** `VEE-nyoo` (wine)
ch	`sh`	**chave** `SHAH-vee` (key), **chocolate**

Two consonants that change at the end of a syllable

Final L sounds like *oo*. At the end of a word or before a consonant, the Portuguese **l** is no longer the English *l*. It becomes a short *oo*: **Brasil** `brah-ZEE-oo`, **hotel** `oh-TEH-oo`, **total** `toh-TAH-oo`, **alto** `AH-oo-too` (tall), **sol**

SAW-oo. At the start of a syllable, the **l** stays a normal *l*: livro, leite LAY-tchee (milk).

T and D before *i* become *tch* and *dj*. In most of Brazil (São Paulo, Rio, Belo Horizonte, Brasília, Salvador and many other places), the letters **t** and **d** change when they come before an **i** sound. That includes the **-i** you hear in a weak final **-e**:

WRITTEN	SOUND	EXAMPLE
ti	tchee	tio TCHEE-oo (uncle), partir par-TCHEER (to leave)
di	djee	dia DJEE-ah (day), cidade see-DAH-djee (city)
-te (final)	-tchee	noite NOY-tchee, parte PAR-tchee
-de (final)	-djee	grande GRAH~-djee, verdade ver-DAH-djee (truth)

This happens in dia, in tarde TAR-djee (afternoon) and in boa noite BOH-ah NOY-tchee, three phrases you will say today. In some regions of the Northeast and the South, people still say a plain *t* and *d*, and everyone understands both. Learn the *tch* and *dj* version; it is what most Brazilians say.

1.9 The Portuguese R

The letter **r** has several sounds, and English speakers usually make the wrong one everywhere. Forget the English *r* completely (the one with the tongue curled back). Portuguese has two main sounds:

1. **The "h" R: at the start of a word, after n, l, s, and in rr**
   This sound is a breath from the back of the throat, close to the English *h* in *hot*. In Rio it is a little rougher, in São Paulo it is softer, and all of them are understood.

   rua HOO-ah (street), rio HEE-oo (river), carro KAH-hoo (car), Israel ees-hah-EH-oo, honra OH~-hah (honor)

2. **The tap R: between vowels, and after a consonant inside a word**
   This is a quick flick of the tongue tip against the ridge behind the upper teeth. English makes the same sound in American *butter*, *ladder* and *better*.

   caro KAH-roo (expensive), hora AW-rah (hour), para PAH-rah, obrigado, três trehss, livro

At the **end of a word** (**falar**, **comer**, **amor**), the r varies a lot: a soft tap, an *h*, a retroflex sound close to the English *r* (in the countryside of São Paulo and in parts of Minas), or almost nothing in fast speech. In this book, the guide writes it as a plain r and you can use any of the three. Remember the two examples that show the difference: caro KAH-roo (expensive) and carro KAH-hoo (car). One extra *r* changes the sound **and** the meaning.

1.10 Stress: which syllable is strong

In English, you must learn the stress of every word. In Portuguese, you can predict it. There are only three steps.

1. **Look for a written accent mark**
   If the word has an accent mark (´, ^, or the tilde ~ in some words), that syllable is the stressed one. The mark overrides every rule: café kah-FEH, você voh-SEH, último OOL-tchee-moo, médico MEH-djee-koo, avô ah-VOH.

2 **With no mark, look at the ending**

If the word ends in **-a, -e, -o, -as, -es, -os, -am, -em, -ens**, the stress falls on the **second-to-last** syllable: casa KAH-zah, amigo ah-MEE-goo, obrigado oh-bree-GAH-doo, tarde TAR-djee, homem OH-meh~ee, falam FAH-lah~oo.

If the word ends in **-i, -is, -u, -us, -l, -r, -z, -im, -um, -ão, -ã**, the stress falls on the **last** syllable: falar fah-LAR, Brasil brah-ZEE-oo, feliz feh-LEES, aqui ah-KEE, jardim zhar-DJEE~ (garden), irmã eer-MAH~ (sister), coração koh-rah-SOW~.

3 **Say it with the stress**

Say the stressed syllable slightly longer and clearer; the others are lighter, and the unstressed vowels at the end of the word weaken, as you saw in 1.5.

ENDS IN	STRESS FALLS ON	EXAMPLES
-a, -e, -o, -as, -es, -os, -am, -em, -ens	the second-to-last syllable	casa, amigo, tarde, homens
-i, -is, -u, -us, -l, -r, -z, -im, -um, -ão, -ã	the last syllable	aqui, falar, papel, feliz, irmão
anything, with a written accent	the accented syllable	café, médico, ônibus, país

WATCH OUT

The accent mark can change the meaning. país pah-EESS (country) is not pais PIESS (parents). Está (is, from *estar*) is not esta (this, feminine). When in doubt, the written accent tells you how to say the word.

1.11 What each mark does

MARK	NAME	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	EXAMPLE
´	acento agudo	stressed syllable; on a, e, o it is also an open vowel (á é í ó ú)	café, avó, último
^	acento circunflexo	stressed syllable, closed (or slightly nasal) vowel (â ê ô)	você, avô, bebê
~	til	nasal vowel (ã õ)	mãe, pão, limões
`	acento grave	only in the contraction **à**, which you will meet in Lesson 5	à (to the)
¸	cedilha	the letter **c** sounds like *s* before a, o, u (ç)	açaí, coração

1.12 The survival phrases

You will use these in your first hour in Brazil. Say each one aloud three times.

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
Oi!	oy	Hi! (the everyday greeting)
Olá!	oh-LAH	Hello! (a little more formal)
Bom dia.	BOH~ DJEE-ah	Good morning.
Boa tarde.	BOH-ah TAR-djee	Good afternoon.
Boa noite.	BOH-ah NOY-tchee	Good evening / Good night.
Tudo bem?	TOO-doo BEH~ee	How are you? (literally: all well?)
Tudo bem, e você?	TOO-doo BEH~ee, ee voh-SEH	Fine, and you?
Obrigado. / Obrigada.	oh-bree-GAH-doo / oh-bree-GAH-dah	Thank you.
De nada.	djee NAH-dah	You're welcome.

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
Por favor.	poor fah-VOR	Please.
Com licença.	koh~ lee-SEH~-sah	Excuse me (to pass or to enter).
Desculpe. / Desculpa.	djees-KOOL-pee / djees-KOOL-pah	Sorry.
Tchau!	tchow	Bye!
Até logo.	ah-TEH LAW-goo	See you soon.

1 **Use bom dia, boa tarde and boa noite by the clock**

Bom dia until about noon, **boa tarde** from noon until it gets dark, **boa noite** after that. Notice that **dia** is masculine and takes **bom**, while **tarde** and **noite** are feminine and take **boa**. Brazilians use **boa noite** both to arrive and to leave, unlike English, which splits *good evening* and *good night*.

2 **Answer "tudo bem?" with "tudo bem"**

Tudo bem? is a greeting, not a medical question. The answer is almost always **tudo bem**, followed by **e você?**. It is the Brazilian equivalent of *how's it going?*, and nobody expects a long answer.

3 **Choose obrigado or obrigada by who is speaking**

The ending follows **you**, the speaker, not the person you are thanking. A man says **obrigado**; a woman says **obrigada**. This is the first time you meet gender agreement in Portuguese, and it will keep coming back.

1.13 Read a real text

Read the text aloud, slowly, then read it again, with the guide covered. The first time, check every stressed syllable.

> Eu sou a Marina. Moro em São Paulo, no Brasil. Hoje é domingo e a minha família vem aqui em casa. A minha mãe faz um bolo de chocolate, o meu pai prepara um café e o meu irmão traz pão. Tudo está pronto e a minha família está muito feliz.

Guide:

EH-oo SOH ah mah-REE-nah. MAW-roo eh~ee sow~ POW-loo, noo brah-ZEE-oo. OH-zhee eh doh-MEE~-goo ee ah MEE-nyah fah-MEE-lyah veh~ee ah-K

Translation: *I am Marina. I live in São Paulo, in Brazil. Today is Sunday and my family comes here to the house. My mother makes a chocolate cake, my father prepares a coffee and my brother brings bread. Everything is ready and my family is very happy.*

Look at what you can already do: you can read this paragraph with the correct sounds, even though you do not yet know the grammar behind it.

1.14 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~ROO-ah, with an English *r*~~	HOO-ah	in **rua** the initial *r* is like English *h*, not a curled *r*
~~FEE-lee-oh~~	FEE-lyoo	in **filho**, **lh** is one sound, *ly*
~~brah-ZEEL~~	brah-ZEE-oo	in **Brasil** the final *l* becomes *oo*

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~DEE-ah~~	DJEE-ah	in **dia**, *d* before *i* becomes *dj*
~~NOY-teh~~	NOY-tchee	in **noite**, *t* before *i* becomes *tch*, and the final *e* is a weak *ee*
~~HOH-jay~~	OH-zhee	in **hoje** the **h** is silent and **j** is *zh*
~~GEN-teh~~	ZHEH~-tchee	in **gente**, **g** before e is *zh*
~~KWAY-zhoo~~	KAY-zhoo	in **queijo** the **u** of **que** is silent
~~PAH-oh~~	POW~	**pão** is one nasal syllable
~~oh-bree-GAY-doh~~	oh-bree-GAH-doo	in **obrigado** the vowel is a pure *ah* with no glide, and the final *-o* is *oo*
~~ZEE-kah-rah~~	SHEE-kah-rah	in **xícara**, **x** is *sh*

1.15 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: SAY THE LETTERS

1. Spell your first name aloud with the Portuguese letter names.

2. Spell **Brasil** aloud: bê, erre, á, esse, i, ele. Then spell **Portugal**.

3. Say your e-mail address aloud, with **arroba** and **ponto**.

4. Which letter name is correct for **g**? (a) *gee* (b) *zheh* (c) *jay*

5. Which letter is silent in **hotel**?

PRACTICE · PART B: CHOOSE THE SOUND

1. **queijo** is read: (a) `KWAY-zhoo` (b) `KAY-zhoo` (c) `KEH-zhoo`

2. **gente** is read: (a) `GEN-tchee` (b) `JEN-tee` (c) `ZHEH~-tchee`

3. **dia** is read: (a) `DEE-ah` (b) `DJEE-ah` (c) `DAY-ah`

4. **filho** is read: (a) `FEE-lyoo` (b) `FEE-yoh` (c) `FEEL-hoo`

5. **Brasil** ends with the sound: (a) *l* (b) *oo* (c) *r*

6. **xícara** starts with: (a) *z* (b) *ks* (c) *sh*

7. **rua** starts with: (a) *r* as in *red* (b) *h* as in *hot* (c) a tap

PRACTICE · PART C: NASAL OR NOT?

1. Which word has a nasal vowel? (a) **pau** (b) **pão**

2. Which word means *bad*? (a) **mão** (b) **mau**

3. Which word means *there*? (a) **lá** (b) **lã**

4. **sim** is read: (a) `SEEM` (b) `SEE~`

5. **bom** is read: (a) `BOHM` (b) `BOH~`

PRACTICE · PART D: WHERE IS THE STRESS?

For each word, choose the stressed syllable.

1. **amigo**: (a) a (b) mi (c) go

2. **falar**: (a) fa (b) lar

3. **café**: (a) ca (b) fé

4. **cidade**: (a) ci (b) da (c) de

5. **médico**: (a) mé (b) di (c) co

6. **feliz**: (a) fe (b) liz

7. **irmão**: (a) ir (b) mão

8. **tarde**: (a) tar (b) de

PRACTICE · PART E: SAY IT

1. Read the five phrases aloud, once with the guide and once without: **Bom dia**, **Boa tarde**, **Boa noite**, **Tudo bem?**, **Obrigada**.

2. Greet an imaginary neighbor three different ways: with **oi**, with **bom dia** and with **boa tarde**. Then thank them and say goodbye.

ANSWER KEY

1. Say each letter; compare with the table in 1.4. Check the letters that differ from English (g, j, e, i, r, x).
2. **bê, erre, á, esse, i, ele**. Portugal: **pê, ó, erre, tê, u, gê, á, ele**.
3. For example **ana ponto silva arroba exemplo ponto com**.
4. (b) **gê**, `zheh`.
5. **h**, which is always silent.
6. (b) `KAY-zhoo`: in **que** the **u** is silent.
7. (c) `ZHEH~-tchee`: **g** before **e** is *zh*, the vowel **e** is nasal, and **te** becomes *tchee*.
8. (b) `DJEE-ah`: **d** before **i** becomes *dj*.
9. (a) `FEE-lyoo`: **lh** is *ly*.
10. (b) *oo*: the final **l** becomes *oo*.
11. (c) *sh*: **x** in this word.
12. (b) *h*: the initial **r** is like English *h*.
13. (b) **pão**.
14. (b) **mau**.
15. (a) **lá**.
16. (b) `SEE~`.
17. (b) `BOH~`.
18. (b) **a-MI-go**: ends in **-o**, so the stress falls on the second-to-last syllable.
19. (b) **fa-LAR**: ends in **-r**, so the last syllable.
20. (b) **ca-FÉ**: the written accent.
21. (b) **ci-DA-de**: ends in **-e**, so the second-to-last syllable.
22. (a) **MÉ-di-co**: the written accent.
23. (b) **fe-LIZ**: ends in **-z**, so the last syllable.
24. (b) **ir-MÃO**: ends in **-ão**, so the last syllable.
25. (a) **TAR-de**: ends in **-e**, so the second-to-last syllable.
26. Check each against 1.12: `BOH~ DJEE-ah`, `BOH-ah TAR-djee`, `BOH-ah NOY-tchee`, `TOO-doo BEH~ee`, `oh-bree-GAH-dah`.
27. A model answer: **Oi, tudo bem? Bom dia! Boa tarde! Obrigado. Tchau, até logo!**

1.16 Pocket summary: Lesson 1

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Alphabet:** 26 letters; names to remember: **g** = **gê**, **j** = **jota**, **e** = **é**, **r** = **erre**, **x** = **xis**, **h** = **agá** (silent).
- **Pure vowels:** no glide. Final **-e** = weak *ee*, final **-o** = weak *oo*, final **-a** = relaxed *ah*.
- **Open and closed:** ´ marks an open vowel (**café**), ^ a closed one (**você**).
- **Nasal vowels:** **ã**, **õ**, **-m**, **-n** before a consonant. Say the vowel through the nose and stop: **bom** `BOH~`.
- **Consonants:** **c** before e, i = *s*; **ç** = *s*; **g** before e, i = **j** = *zh*; **gu/qu** before e, i: silent **u**; **lh** = *ly*; **nh** = *ny*; **ch** = **x** = *sh*; **s** between vowels = *z*.
- **R:** initial and **rr** = *h*; between vowels = tap.
- **T, D before *i*:** *tch*, *dj*: **dia**, **noite**.
- **Final L** = *oo*: **Brasil** `brah-ZEE-oo`.
- **Stress:** accent mark wins; otherwise **-a, -e, -o** (also with **-s**), **-am, -em, -ens** = second-to-last; **-i, -u** (also with **-s**), **-l, -r, -z, -im, -um, -ão, -ã** = last.
- **Politeness:** **bom dia** (masc.), **boa tarde**, **boa noite** (fem.); **obrigado** (man), **obrigada** (woman).

1.17 What comes next

In Lesson 2 you start building real sentences with **ser**, the verb for saying who you are and what things are. You will learn the subject pronouns, including the everyday **você** and **a gente**, and how adjectives agree with the person they

describe.

LESSON 2

Ser, pronouns and adjectives: who you are

By the end of this lesson you can say who you are, where you are from, what you do and how old you are; introduce someone else; describe people with adjectives that agree in gender and number; and understand why Portuguese so often leaves out the word for “I”.

2.1 A scene you will live

It is the first evening of a Portuguese course in Rio de Janeiro. Emma, a teacher from Canada, is holding a plastic cup of juice and trying not to look lost. Camila, a classmate, walks up to her.

DIALOGUE

Camila: Oi! Eu sou a Camila. E você? **Emma:** Oi, Camila! Eu sou a Emma. Sou do Canadá. **Camila:** Que legal! Eu sou de Recife, mas agora moro aqui. Esse é o Pedro. Ele é argentino. **Pedro:** Muito prazer! Sou engenheiro. E você, o que faz? **Emma:** Sou professora. Vocês são amigos? **Camila:** A gente é colega de trabalho. Nós somos muito diferentes, mas a gente se dá bem.

Camila: Hi! I’m Camila. And you? / Emma: Hi, Camila! I’m Emma. I’m from Canada. / Camila: How cool! I’m from Recife, but now I live here. This is Pedro. He’s Argentinian. / Pedro: Nice to meet you! I’m an engineer. And you, what do you do? / Emma: I’m a teacher. Are you two friends? / Camila: We’re colleagues. We’re very different, but we get along well.

Read the scene again and notice three things. First, nobody says **eu sou engenheiro**: Pedro says only **sou engenheiro**. Second, nobody says “a” or “an” before the profession: **sou professora**, not “I am a teacher” word for word. Third, the word for “we” appears in two forms, **nós** and **a gente**, and Camila uses both in a single breath. (Note also **Eu sou a Camila**: Brazilians often put **o** or **a** before a first name in speech. Lesson 3 returns to this.) That is how real Brazilians talk, and this lesson explains all three.

Some words in the scene are ready-made blocks for now. **Moro** (I live) and **faz** (do/does) come back in Lesson 4, and **esse** (this, near you) in Lesson 8. Learn them as phrases and move on.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
legal	leh-GAH-oo	cool, nice, great
Que legal!	kee leh-GAH-oo	How cool!
muito prazer	MOO~ee-too prah-ZEHR	nice to meet you
diferentes	djee-feh-REH~-tcheess	different (plural)

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
colega	koh-LEH-gah	colleague, classmate
agora	ah-GAW-rah	now

2.2 The trap: three habits to leave at the door

English builds every sentence from the same bricks: a subject, a verb, and a form of “to be” that barely changes. Three of those habits cause most of the early mistakes in Portuguese.

1. **“I am” needs the pronoun.** In English you cannot say “am a teacher”. In Portuguese the verb ending already tells you who is speaking, so the pronoun is often missing.
2. **“You” is one word.** English has a single *you*. Portuguese has **você** for one person and **vocês** for several, and the verb changes with them.
3. **Adjectives are not frozen.** *Tall* is *tall* for a man, a woman or ten people. Portuguese adjectives take the gender and number of the person described: **alto**, **alta**, **altos**, **altas**.

There is a fourth trap, and you will meet it in 2.10: English says “I am twenty”, Portuguese says “I have twenty years”.

2.3 The subject pronouns

A **subject pronoun** is the word that says who does the verb: *I, you, he, she, we, they*. Here is the full set you need for Brazilian Portuguese.

MEANING	PORTUGUESE	GUIDE
I	**eu**	EH-oo
you (one person)	**você**	voh-SEH
he	**ele**	EH-lee
she	**ela**	EH-lah
we	**nós**	NAWSS
we (spoken)	**a gente**	ah ZHEH~-tchee
you (several people)	**vocês**	voh-SEHSS
they (men, or mixed)	**eles**	EH-leess
they (women only)	**elas**	EH-lahss

1 **Use "você" for one person and "vocês" for more than one**

Você is the everyday word for *you* in most of Brazil, with friends, colleagues, strangers and bosses. It works at any age and in almost any situation. Its plural is **vocês**, and there is no formal-informal split in the plural.

2 **Remember that "você" takes the same verb as "ele/ela"**

Grammatically, **você** counts as a third person. The verb you use with **você** is the same form you use with **ele** and **ela**. That is the reason Portuguese verb tables look so short: only a few forms are really different. You will see this at once in the next section.

3 **Choose "nós" or "a gente" by register**

Nós is correct everywhere and is typical of writing, speeches and careful speech. **A gente** (literally "the people") is what most Brazilians say when they talk to each other: **A gente vai?** (Shall we go?). It takes the same verb as **ele/ela**, so it is easy: **a gente é**. You can safely use both; learn to understand both from the first day.

4 **Say "eles" for a mixed group**

If even one man is in the group, Portuguese says **eles**. **Elas** is only for groups made up entirely of women. The same rule works for adjectives and nouns: one man and ten women together are still **eles**, **amigos**, **brasileiros**.

Tu, o senhor and a senhora

You will hear three more words.

- **Tu** `too` also means *you* (one person). It is used in the South of Brazil, in much of the North and Northeast, and by some speakers in Rio. Depending on region and speaker, it takes either the **ele** form of the verb (**tu é**, **tu fala**) or its own ending (**tu és**, **tu falas**). In São Paulo, Minas Gerais and most of the Southeast, people say **você** instead. You will not need to say **tu**; you will need to understand it.
- **O senhor** `oo seh-NYOR` and **a senhora** `ah seh-NYAW-rah` are polite forms for an older person or someone you want to treat with respect, such as a customer, a doctor or a grandparent. They take the **ele/ela** verb too.
- **Vós** is the old plural of *you*. You will find it in the Bible and in classical texts. Nobody says it today.

> TIP
>
> **Always safe:** **você** for one person, **vocês** for many. If someone calls you **tu** and you answer with **você**, nobody will notice.

2.4 The verb ser

Ser `SEHR` is one of the two Portuguese verbs for "to be". (The other, **estar**, arrives in Lesson 5. For now, do not worry about it.) **Ser** tells you **who** or **what** someone or something is: identity, origin, profession, nationality, and permanent or defining qualities. Its present tense is irregular, which means you must learn it as it is. Learn it first.

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE	MEANING
eu	**sou**	`SOH`	I am
você / ele / ela / a gente	**é**	`eh`	you are / he is / she is / we are
nós	**somos**	`SOH-mooss`	we are
vocês / eles / elas	**são**	`SOW~`	you are / they are

Notice what the table shows. There are only **four** forms, and the second one, **é**, serves for four different subjects. Learn **sou**, **é**, **somos**, **são** and you can build hundreds of sentences.

The form **é** is also the word *is*, as in **O Brasil é grande** (Brazil is big). And **são** is also *are*: **As aulas são boas**.

HOW IT COMPARES

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE
I am, you are, he is, we are, they are: five forms	**sou**, **é**, **é**, **somos**, **são**: four different forms, one for several subjects
"You are" is the same for one person and for many	**você é** (one person) ≠ **vocês são** (several)

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE
"It is" needs a subject (*it*)	**É difícil** = It is difficult. No subject word at all.

The pronunciation of **sou** gives many English speakers trouble. The **ou** is a plain *oh*, as you saw in Lesson 1: **sou** SOH, not "sow".

2.5 The subject can disappear

In English, the subject is compulsory: *am a student* is not a sentence. In Portuguese, the verb ending already tells you who is acting, so the pronoun is optional. Compare:

WITH THE PRONOUN	WITHOUT THE PRONOUN
Eu sou estudante.	**Sou estudante.**
Nós somos amigos.	**Somos amigos.**
Eles são brasileiros.	**São brasileiros.**

In everyday conversation, speakers drop the pronoun when the context makes the person clear, and keep it when they want emphasis or contrast: **Eu sou de Recife, e você?**

There is one important limit. With **é**, the verb alone could mean you, he, she or we-with-a-gente, so Brazilians usually keep the pronoun or the name:

- **É professor.** Who? You cannot tell.
- **Ele é professor.** / **Você é professor?** / **O Pedro é professor.** Now it is clear.

> WATCH OUT
>
> Dropping the subject is a feature of **all** verbs, but it is much safer to drop **eu** and **nós** than **ele/ela/você**. When **é** appears alone, listeners will not know who you mean. As a beginner, use the pronoun with **é** and drop it where you feel comfortable: **Sou**, **Somos**, **São**.

And what about "it"?

Portuguese has no word for *it* as a subject. English "It is cold" or "It is late" becomes **Está frio** and **É tarde**, with no subject at all. When you want to talk about an object, you use **ele** or **ela** (the object's grammatical gender decides): **Gosto do carro. Ele é novo.** Many learners are surprised to hear Brazilians say **ele** and **ela** for things, but it is normal.

2.6 Saying who you are: name, origin, profession

With **ser** you can already say most of what you need in a first meeting. Here are the patterns, with the exact questions Brazilians ask.

YOU WANT TO SAY	PATTERN	EXAMPLE
your name	**Meu nome é…**	**Meu nome é Daniel.**
your name (another way)	**Eu me chamo…**	**Eu me chamo Daniel.**
your name (short)	**Eu sou o/a…**	**Eu sou o Daniel.**
where you are from	**Sou de + city**	**Sou de Manchester.**

YOU WANT TO SAY	PATTERN	EXAMPLE
where you are from (country)	Sou do / da + country	Sou do Canadá. Sou da Irlanda.
your profession	Sou + profession	Sou designer.
your nationality	Sou + nationality	Sou irlandês.

Here are the matching questions. Memorize them as blocks:

QUESTION	GUIDE	MEANING
Como você se chama?	KOH-moo voh-SEH see SHAH-mah	What is your name?
Qual é o seu nome?	KWAH-oo eh oo SEH-oo NOH-mee	What is your name?
De onde você é?	djee OH~-djee voh-SEH eh	Where are you from?
Você é de onde?	voh-SEH eh djee OH~-djee	Where are you from? (spoken order)
O que você faz?	oo kee voh-SEH fahss	What do you do (for work)?
Quem é ele?	KEH~ee eh EH-lee	Who is he?

1 **Use "de" with a city and "do/da" with a country**

Cities take plain **de**: **Sou de São Paulo**, **Sou de Londres**. Most country names take an article, and **de** fuses with it: **de + o = do**, **de + a = da**. So **Sou do Brasil**, **Sou do Canadá**, **Sou da Alemanha**, **Sou da França**. Portugal and a few others take no article: **Sou de Portugal**. Lesson 3 explains these fusions, called contractions. For now learn the countries in the table in 2.8 together with their **do/da**.

2 **Say your profession with no article**

In English you say "I am **a** teacher". In Portuguese you say **Sou professor** (or **professora**), with no **um/uma**. The profession works like an adjective: it says what category you belong to. The same goes for nationality and religion: **Ele é católico**, **Elas são brasileiras**. You add **um/uma** only when you describe the person in a more detailed way: **Ele é um professor muito bom** (He is a very good teacher).

3 **Match the ending to the person**

Professions and nationalities have a masculine and a feminine form: **professor / professora**, **médico / médica**, **brasileiro / brasileira**. A man says **Sou advogado**; a woman says **Sou advogada**. The pattern is the same as **obrigado / obrigada** from Lesson 1.

Professions

MASCULINE	FEMININE	GUIDE	MEANING
professor	professora	proh-feh-SOR / proh-feh-SOH-rah	teacher
médico	médica	MEH-djee-koo / MEH-djee-kah	doctor
engenheiro	engenheira	eh~-zheh-NYAY-roo / eh~-zheh-NYAY-rah	engineer
advogado	advogada	ah-djee-voh-GAH-doo / ah-djee-voh-GAH-dah	lawyer
enfermeiro	enfermeira	eh~-fehr-MAY-roo / eh~-fehr-MAY-rah	nurse
cozinheiro	cozinheira	koh-zee-NYAY-roo / koh-zee-NYAY-rah	cook
programador	programadora	proh-grah-mah-DOR / proh-grah-mah-DOH-rah	programmer
vendedor	vendedora	veh~-deh-DOR / veh~-deh-DOH-rah	salesperson
arquiteto	arquiteta	ar-kee-TEH-too / ar-kee-TEH-tah	architect

MASCULINE	FEMININE	GUIDE	MEANING
garçom	garçonete	gar-SOH~ / gar-soh-NEH-tchee	waiter / waitress

Some professions have **one form for both**: estudante ehs-too-DAH~-tchee, dentista deh~-TCHEES-tah, jornalista zhor-nah-LEES-tah, motorista moh-toh-REES-tah (driver), artista ar-TCHEES-tah. In those cases only the article shows the gender: o dentista (a man), a dentista (a woman). Words in **-or** usually add **-a** for the feminine (professor, professora), with the well-known exception ator / atriz (actor / actress).

> TIP
>
> Your profession is not on the list? Ask a Brazilian: Como se diz "accountant" em português? (How do you say "accountant" in Portuguese?). The answer is contador or contadora.

2.7 Adjectives: they agree with the person

An **adjective** describes a noun: *tall*, *nice*, *Brazilian*. In Portuguese, the adjective must **agree** with the noun: it takes the same gender (masculine or feminine) and the same number (singular or plural). In English this does not exist, so it feels strange at first, but the rules are few and very regular.

1 Look at the ending

Most adjectives belong to one of three groups.

GROUP	MASCULINE	FEMININE	GUIDE (MASC. / FEM.)
ends in **-o**	alto, bonito, simpático	change **-o** to **-a**: alta, bonita, simpática	AH-oo-too / AH-oo-tah
ends in **-e**, **-l**, **-z**, **-ista**	inteligente, legal, feliz	the **same** form for both: inteligente, legal, feliz	ee~-teh-lee-ZHEH~-tchee, leh-GAH-oo, feh-LEES
ends in **-or**, **-ês**, and nationalities in **-ão**	trabalhador, inglês, alemão	add **-a**, drop the accent: trabalhadora, inglesa, alemã	trah-bah-lyah-DOR / trah-bah-lyah-DOH-rah

Look at the last row. Adjectives in **-ês** lose the circumflex when they become feminine (francês → francesa) because the accent is no longer needed. The nationality alemão becomes alemã.

There are some adjectives that behave in slightly different ways. Bom becomes boa (BOH-ah) and mau becomes má, but you will normally say ruim (hoo-EE~ , bad) which is the same for both genders. Most adjectives in **-l** do not change, but nationalities in **-ol** add **-a**: espanhol becomes espanhola.

2 Add the number

Number is much simpler. For the plural, you add **-s** to a word that ends in a vowel; you add **-es** to words that end in **-r**, **-z**; and **-l** changes to **-is**. Lesson 3 gives the complete plural rules. One detail worth knowing now: an adjective in **-il** with the stress on the first syllable, like **fácil**, changes to **-eis**. For the adjectives you need now:

SINGULAR	PLURAL	GUIDE
alto / alta	altos / altas	AH-oo-tooss / AH-oo-tahss
inteligente	inteligentes	ee~-teh-lee-ZHEH~-tcheess
legal	legais	leh-GIESS
fácil (easy)	fáceis	FAH-see-oo / FAH-sayss
feliz	felizes	feh-LEE-zeess
trabalhador	trabalhadores	trah-bah-lyah-DOH-reess
alemão	alemães	ah-leh-MAH~eess
inglês	ingleses	ee~-GLEH-zeess

3 Check the whole group

When an adjective describes several nouns, it goes in the plural, and one masculine noun is enough to make it masculine: **O Pedro e a Camila são simpáticos**. A mixed group is masculine, just like **eles**.

A few high-frequency adjectives, with their opposites:

ADJECTIVE	GUIDE	MEANING
simpático / simpática	see~-PAH-tchee-koo	nice, friendly (of a person)
legal	leh-GAH-oo	nice, cool
inteligente	ee~-teh-lee-ZHEH~-tchee	smart
divertido / divertida	djee-ver-TCHEE-doo	fun
tímido / tímida	TCHEE-mee-doo	shy
alto / alta	AH-oo-too	tall
baixo / baixa	BIE-shoo	short
novo / nova	NOH-voo	new, young
velho / velha	VEH-lyoo	old
bonito / bonita	boh-NEE-too	pretty, nice-looking
grande	GRAH~-djee	big
pequeno / pequena	peh-KEH-noo	small
jovem	ZHAW-veh~ee	young
difícil	djee-FEE-see-oo	difficult
caro / cara	KAH-roo	expensive
barato / barata	bah-RAH-too	cheap

Jovem (plural **jovens**) has one form for both genders. **Novo** usually means *new* for objects and *young* in a general way; for people you can say **jovem**.

Intensifiers and position

The usual intensifiers are **muito** `MOO~ee-too` (very) and **bem** `BEH~ee` (quite, really), and they do not change: **Ela é muito simpática**, **Eles são muito simpáticos**. Also useful are **um pouco** `oo~ POH-koo` (a little) and **bastante** `bahs-TAH~-tchee` (quite).

The adjective normally goes **after** the noun: **um amigo simpático**, **uma cidade grande**. A few very common adjectives can go before the noun with a change in meaning: **um grande amigo** (a great friend) versus **um amigo grande** (a physically big friend). In this lesson, put the adjective after the noun and you will be correct.

2.8 Nationalities and countries

Nationalities are adjectives, so they agree. They are written with a **small letter** in Portuguese: **brasileiro**, **americano**. (Languages and nationalities are not capitalized, unlike English.) Countries are capitalized.

COUNTRY	GUIDE	NATIONALITY (M. / F.)	GUIDE
o Brasil	brah-ZEE-oo	brasileiro / brasileira	brah-zee-LAY-roo
os Estados Unidos	ehs-TAH-dooss oo-NEE-dooss	americano / americana	ah-meh-ree-KAH-noo
o Canadá	kah-nah-DAH	canadense	kah-nah-DEH~-see
a Inglaterra	ee~-glah-TEH-hah	inglês / inglesa	ee~-GLEHSS
a Irlanda	eer-LAH~-dah	irlandês / irlandesa	eer-lah~-DEHSS
a Austrália	ow-STRAH-lee-ah	australiano / australiana	ow-strah-lee-AH-noo
a Alemanha	ah-leh-MAH-nyah	alemão / alemã	ah-leh-MOW~
a França	FRAH~-sah	francês / francesa	frah~-SEHSS
a Itália	ee-TAH-lee-ah	italiano / italiana	ee-tah-lee-AH-noo
a Espanha	ehs-PAH-nyah	espanhol / espanhola	ehs-pah-NYAW-oo
Portugal	por-too-GAH-oo	português / portuguesa	por-too-GEHSS
a Argentina	ar-zheh~-TCHEE-nah	argentino / argentina	ar-zheh~-TCHEE-noo
o México	MEH-shee-koo	mexicano / mexicana	meh-shee-KAH-noo
o Japão	zhah-POW~	japonês / japonesa	zhah-poh-NEHSS
a China	SHEE-nah	chinês / chinesa	shee-NEHSS
a Índia	EE~-djee-ah	indiano / indiana	ee~-djee-AH-noo

Each country's article returns in the sentence: **Sou do Brasil**, **Sou dos Estados Unidos**, **Sou da Alemanha**, **Sou do Japão**, but **Sou de Portugal**. When you do not know whether a country takes an article, check it once and memorize it with the name: **o Brasil**, **a França**. And when you want a plain, simple answer, use the nationality instead: **Sou francesa**, which needs no article.

> WATCH OUT
>
> As in English, one word names both the language and the people, but Portuguese changes the article: **o inglês** is the English language (**Falo inglês**, I speak English), and **um inglês** is an Englishman. Languages are never capitalized.

2.9 Describing people with ser

You can now put the pieces together. With **ser** you describe what someone is like, in a lasting way: character, appearance, origin, profession. Say these sentences aloud.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
O Pedro é argentino e é muito divertido.	Pedro is Argentinian and very funny.
A Camila é de Recife e é muito simpática.	Camila is from Recife and is very friendly.
Eu sou tímida, mas a Emma é muito divertida.	I'm shy, but Emma is very fun.
Nós somos professores e eles são engenheiros.	We're teachers and they're engineers.
Vocês são jovens e inteligentes.	You're young and smart.
O inglês é difícil, mas o português é bonito.	English is difficult, but Portuguese is beautiful.

The last sentence shows something you will study in Lesson 3: when a language is the **subject** of the sentence, Portuguese puts the article **o** before it (**O português é bonito**). After **falar**, the article usually disappears: **Falo português**.

Now compare **ser** questions and answers, which follow the same words:

QUESTION	SHORT ANSWER
Você é brasileiro?	Sou, sim. / Não, não sou.
A Camila é professora?	É, sim. / Não, não é.
Vocês são casados?	Somos, sim. / Não, não somos.

In Portuguese a yes-no question has the same word order as a statement: you only raise the pitch of your voice at the end. Lesson 4 explains this. To answer "yes" you repeat the verb (**Sou**), and often add **sim** for warmth. To answer "no", you say **não** twice: first as the answer, then in front of the verb.

2.10 Age: ser is the wrong verb

English says *I am twenty-five*. Portuguese says **I have twenty-five years**. The verb is **ter**, not **ser**.

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE	GUIDE
I am thirty.	Tenho trinta anos.	TEH-nyoo TREE~-tah AH-nooss
How old are you?	Quantos anos você tem?	KWAH~-tooss AH-nooss voh-SEH TEH~ee
She is twenty-five.	Ela tem vinte e cinco anos.	EH-lah TEH~ee VEE~-tchee ee SEE~-koo AH-nooss

You will learn **ter** properly in Lessons 4 and 5, and the numbers in Lesson 6. For now, keep the block **Tenho ___ anos** and the question **Quantos anos você tem?** Do not forget the word **anos**: it is the normal way to say your age.

2.11 Read a real text

Read the text aloud, first with the guide, then without it.

> Oi, eu sou a Carla. Sou brasileira, de Porto Alegre. Tenho vinte e oito anos e sou arquiteta. O Marco é meu marido. Ele é italiano e é muito simpático.

Guide:

oy, EH-oo SOH ah KAR-lah. SOH brah-zee-LAY-rah, djee POR-too ah-LEH-gree. TEH-nyoo VEE~-tchee ee OY-too AH-nooss ee SOH ar-kee-TEH-tah. oo MA

Translation: *Hi, I'm Carla. I'm Brazilian, from Porto Alegre. I'm twenty-eight and I'm an architect. Marco is my husband. He's Italian and very friendly.*

Notice what you can do already. You know that **sou** has no **eu** in front of it, that the profession (**arquiteta**) takes no article, that the age uses **tenho**, and that every adjective agrees: Carla is **brasileira** and Marco is **italiano**. The word **meu** (my) belongs to Lesson 8, but you can already use **meu marido**, **meu nome**.

2.12 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu é professor.~~	Eu sou professor.	**é** is for **você**, **ele**, **ela**, **a gente**; with **eu** you need **sou**
~~Eles é brasileiros.~~	Eles são brasileiros.	the plural of **é** is **são**: **eles** and **vocês** take **são**
~~Nós é amigos.~~	Nós somos amigos.	**nós** takes **somos** (while **a gente** takes **é**)
~~Sou um professor.~~	Sou professor.	professions and nationalities take no article
~~Eu sou 25 anos.~~	Eu tenho 25 anos.	in Portuguese you *have* years; you are not years
~~Ela é alto.~~	Ela é alta.	the adjective agrees with *ela*: feminine
~~Eles são brasileiro.~~	Eles são brasileiros.	plural subject, plural adjective
~~Ela é um brasileira.~~	Ela é brasileira.	no article, and the adjective already shows gender
~~Eu sou de o Brasil.~~	Eu sou do Brasil.	**de** + **o** always becomes **do**
~~Eu sou Brasileira.~~	Eu sou brasileira.	nationalities start with a small letter
~~Sou de São Paulo e é muito grande.~~	Sou de São Paulo. A cidade é muito grande.	with **é** alone, nobody knows the subject; name it
~~Eu sou ele.~~ ~~("It's me")~~	Sou eu.	to say "it is I", the verb comes first and agrees with **eu**: **sou eu**, **é ele**, **somos nós**

2.13 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: CHOOSE THE RIGHT FORM OF SER

Complete with **sou**, **é**, **somos** or **são**.

1. Eu ____ de Manchester.

2. Você ____ brasileiro?

3. A Marta e o Tiago ____ médicos.

4. Nós ____ amigos.

5. A gente ____ de Recife.

6. Vocês ____ estudantes?

7. Ele ____ engenheiro.

8. Eu ____ professora.

PRACTICE · PART B: MAKE THE ADJECTIVE AGREE

Choose the correct form.

1. A Camila é muito ____. (a) simpático (b) simpática (c) simpáticos

2. Pedro e Luís são ____. (a) alemão (b) alemães (c) alemãs

3. A Júlia é ____. (a) francês (b) francesa (c) franceses

4. As aulas são ____. (a) fácil (b) fáceis (c) fácils

5. A professora é ____. (a) inteligente (b) inteligenta (c) inteligento

6. Ela é ____. (a) trabalhador (b) trabalhadora (c) trabalhadoras

7. A Ana e o Marcos são ____. (a) brasileiro (b) brasileiros (c) brasileiras

8. Os filmes brasileiros são ____. (a) legal (b) legais (c) legalis

PRACTICE · PART C: WHERE ARE THEY FROM?

Write the nationality in the correct form.

1. Ele é do México. Ele é ____.

2. Ela é da França. Ela é ____.

3. Elas são da Alemanha. Elas são ____.

4. Nós (two men) somos de Portugal. Nós somos ____.

5. Eles são da Inglaterra. Eles são ____.

6. Ela é do Canadá. Ela é ____.

7. Eu (a woman) sou dos Estados Unidos. Eu sou ____.

8. Vocês (a mixed group) são do Japão. Vocês são ____.

PRACTICE · PART D: CORRECT THE MISTAKE

Seven of these sentences have one mistake each. One is already correct. Find the correct one and fix the others.

1. Eu é de Londres.

2. Ela é professor.

3. Eu sou 25 anos.

4. Eles é brasileiros.

5. Vocês é amigos?

6. Ela é alto.

7. A gente é de Curitiba.

8. Nós é de São Paulo.

PRACTICE · PART E: SPEAK AND WRITE

1. Introduce yourself in four sentences: your name, where you are from, your profession and your age.

2. Introduce a friend (real or imagined) in three sentences, using **ele** or **ela** and at least one adjective.

3. Ask a new colleague three questions, using **Como você se chama?**, **De onde você é?** and **O que você faz?**. Then answer them yourself.

4. Describe two people you know with **ser** and a pair of adjectives each, for example **O meu irmão é alto e divertido.** (In this sentence you may use **meu** as a ready-made block.)

ANSWER KEY

1. **sou**: **eu** takes **sou**.
2. **é**: **você** takes the **ele/ela** form.
3. **são**: plural subject, two people.
4. **somos**: **nós**.
5. **é**: **a gente** takes **é**.
6. **são**: **vocês** takes **são**.
7. **é**.
8. **sou**.
9. (b) **simpática**: feminine singular.
10. (b) **alemães**: two men, plural of **alemão**. (c) would mean the two are women.
11. (b) **francesa**.
12. (b) **fáceis**: the plural of **fácil** drops the **-l** and takes **-eis**.
13. (a) **inteligente**: the same form for both genders.
14. (b) **trabalhadora**: feminine singular.
15. (b) **brasileiros**: a mixed group is masculine plural.
16. (b) **legais**: **-l** becomes **-is**.
17. **mexicano**.
18. **francesa**.
19. **alemãs**: feminine plural of **alemã**.
20. **portugueses**.
21. **ingleses**.
22. **canadense**: the same for both genders.
23. **americana**.
24. **japoneses**: a mixed group, masculine plural.
25. **Eu sou de Londres.**
26. **Ela é professora.**
27. **Eu tenho 25 anos.**
28. **Eles são brasileiros.**
29. **Vocês são amigos?**
30. **Ela é alta.**
31. This is the correct sentence: **a gente** takes **é**.
32. **Nós somos de São Paulo.** (or **A gente é de São Paulo.**)
33. A model answer: **Meu nome é Daniel. Sou da Inglaterra. Sou designer. Tenho trinta e dois anos.** Check the verbs: **é**, **sou**, **sou**, **tenho**.
34. A model answer: **Essa é a Sara. Ela é escocesa. Ela é muito simpática.** Check the agreement with **ela**.
35. A model answer: **Como você se chama? De onde você é? O que você faz?** Then: **Eu me chamo Daniel. Sou da Inglaterra. Sou designer.**
36. A model answer: **O meu irmão é alto e divertido. A minha amiga é baixa e muito inteligente.** Check that each adjective agrees with its noun.

2.14 Return

These three questions bring back Lesson 1. Answer each one aloud before you check.

1. How do you pronounce **dia** and **noite**? Which two consonants change, and why?
2. Where does the stress fall in **engenheiro**, **Brasil** and **simpático**? Use the rules from 1.10.
3. A man says **obrigado**. What does a woman say? Say the whole sentence **Muito obrigada, de nada** aloud.

Check: (1) DJEE-ah, NOY-tchee: *d* and *t* before an *i* sound become *dj* and *tch*; (2) **en-ge-NHEI-ro** (second to last, ending in **-o**), **Bra-SIL** (last, ending in **-l**), **sim-PÁ-ti-co** (accent mark); (3) **obrigada**.

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Day 1	Say the four forms of **ser** and one sentence for each.
Day 3	Introduce yourself aloud in four sentences without looking.
Day 7	Describe three people with **ser** and adjectives that agree.
Day 14	Say the nationalities of ten countries in both genders.

2.15 Pocket summary: Lesson 2

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Pronouns:** **eu, você, ele, ela, nós / a gente, vocês, eles, elas**. **Você** and **a gente** take the **ele/ela** verb. **Tu** exists (South, North, Northeast); **o senhor / a senhora** is polite.
- **Ser:** **sou**, **é**, **somos**, **são**. It names identity, origin, nationality, profession and lasting qualities.
- **The subject can disappear:** **Sou estudante.** Keep the pronoun with **é** when it would otherwise be unclear.
- **No article** before profession or nationality: **Sou professora**, not *um/uma professora*.
- **Origin:** **Sou de + city**; **Sou do / da + country** (**de + o = do**, **de + a = da**).
- **Adjectives agree:** -o → -a; -e, -l, -z, -ista stay; -or → -ora; -ês → -esa; **alemão → alemã**. Plural: -s; -l → -is; -r, -z → -es; **alemão → alemães**.
- **A mixed group is masculine:** **eles**, **brasileiros**.
- **Age:** **Tenho trinta anos**, never *sou trinta*.
- **Questions to remember:** **Como você se chama?**, **De onde você é?**, **O que você faz?**, **Quantos anos você tem?**

2.16 What comes next

In Lesson 3 you will finish the picture of the noun phrase. You will see why every Portuguese noun is masculine or feminine, how to spot the gender from the ending, why *the* has four forms, and how **em**, **de** and **por** fuse with **o** and **a** into **no**, **na**, **do**, **da**, **pelo** and **pela**.

LESSON 3

Nouns, articles, gender and number: the shape of a noun phrase

By the end of this lesson you can name everyday objects with the right article, guess the gender of most new nouns from their endings, make plurals correctly (including the tricky ones in -ão and -l), and use the small fused words **no**, **na**, **do**, **da**, **pelo** and **pela** without hesitation.

3.1 A scene you will live

It is Saturday morning at a street market in São Paulo. Tom, a visitor from Leeds, stops at a fruit stall. The woman behind it is already weighing a melon for someone else.

DIALOGUE

Feirante: Bom dia! O que vai ser hoje, moço? **Tom:** Bom dia! Quero um abacaxi e uma melancia, por favor. **Feirante:** O abacaxi é bem doce. A melancia também. E as mangas? As mangas são ótimas hoje. **Tom:** Então quero duas mangas. E os limões? Os limões são grandes? **Feirante:** São, sim. São do interior. **Tom:** Perfeito. Quanto é tudo? **Feirante:** Fica trinta reais.

Vendor: Good morning! What will it be today, young man? / Tom: Good morning! I'd like a pineapple and a watermelon, please. / Vendor: The pineapple is very sweet. So is the watermelon. And the mangoes? The mangoes are great today. / Tom: Then I'll take two mangoes. And the limes? Are the limes big? / Vendor: Yes, they are. They're from the countryside. / Tom: Perfect. How much is everything? / Vendor: It comes to thirty reais.

Count the small words in this scene: **o**, **a**, **as**, **os**, **um**, **uma**, **duas**, **do**. Almost every noun has one in front of it, and the little word is never the same: it depends on whether the noun is masculine or feminine, singular or plural. **Do interior** is also a fusion: **de** + **o** in a single word. This lesson makes all of that automatic.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
o abacaxi	ah-bah-kah-SHEE	the pineapple
a melancia	meh-lah~-SEE-ah	the watermelon
a manga	MAH~-gah	the mango
o limão	lee-MOW~	the lime, the lemon
doce	DOH-see	sweet
ótimo / ótima	AW-tchee-moo	great

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
o interior	ee~-teh-ree-OR	the countryside, inland
moço	MOH-soo	young man (a friendly way to address a man)
Fica trinta reais.	FEE-kah TREE~-tah heh-IESS	It comes to thirty reais.

3.2 The trap: everything has a gender

In English, a table is *it*, a house is *it*, a hotel is *it*. In Portuguese, **every noun is masculine or feminine**, even objects and ideas: o livro (masculine), a mesa (feminine). The gender does not mean the thing is male or female. It is a label that the whole sentence must respect: the article, the adjective, and later the pronouns all take the same label.

Three English habits cause trouble:

1. **"The" is one word.** Portuguese has four: o, a, os, as.
2. **"A" is two words, plus plurals.** Um, uma, and the plurals uns, umas ("some").
3. **Small words fuse.** English keeps *in the* as two words. Portuguese says no (em + o) and na (em + a), and you must do the same.

The good news is that gender is mostly predictable from the **ending**, as you will see in 3.3. And the rule you will use every day is simple: **learn each noun together with its article.** Do not learn mesa; learn a mesa.

3.3 Gender: how to guess

1 Start from the ending

Most nouns ending in **-o** are masculine, and most nouns ending in **-a** are feminine.

MASCULINE	GUIDE	FEMININE	GUIDE
o livro (book)	oo LEE-vroo	a casa (house)	ah KAH-zah
o carro (car)	oo KAH-hoo	a mesa (table)	ah MEH-zah
o preço (price)	oo PREH-soo	a rua (street)	ah HOO-ah
o bairro (neighborhood)	oo BIE-hoo	a loja (shop)	ah LAW-zhah
o mercado (market)	oo mer-KAH-doo	a feira (street market)	ah FAY-rah

2 Learn the endings that signal gender

Some endings are strong signals. Learn these and you can guess hundreds of nouns.

ENDING	GENDER	EXAMPLES
-ção, **-são**	feminine	a lição ah lee-SOW~ (lesson), a nação, a televisão, a canção (song)
-dade, **-tade**	feminine	a cidade ah see-DAH-djee (city), a verdade (truth), a liberdade
-agem	feminine	a viagem ah vee-AH-zheh~ee (trip), a mensagem (message), a garagem
-ice, **-ez**	feminine	a velhice (old age), a timidez (shyness)
-ema, **-oma** (Greek origin)	masculine	o problema oo proh-BLEH-mah, o sistema oo sees-TEH-mah, o idioma oo ee-djee-OH-mah (language), o tema (theme), o diploma
-or, **-ismo**	masculine	o amor oo ah-MOR (love), o computador, o calor (heat), o turismo
-l	mostly masculine	o hotel, o papel oo pah-PEH-oo (paper), o jornal oo zhor-NAH-oo (newspaper), o sal (salt)

WATCH OUT

Every rule has well-known exceptions. The ones you need most are these. **Masculine words ending in -a:** o dia (day), o mapa (map), o planeta (planet), o cinema, o clima (climate), o programa. **Feminine words ending in -o:** a mão (hand), a foto (photo, short for *fotografia*), a moto (motorbike). **Masculine words in -agem:** o personagem (character in a story). **Feminine words in -or:** a flor (flower), a cor (color), a dor (pain). **Feminine words in -ão** other than -ção and -são: a razão (reason), a união (union), a opinião. Words in -ão can be masculine too: o pão, o avião (plane), o limão, o coração, o irmão.

3 Look at people and animals

When a noun names a person or an animal, the gender usually follows the sex of the person. A man is o amigo or o professor; a woman is a amiga or a professora. The same endings you saw in Lesson 2 appear again: **-o** becomes **-a**, **-or** becomes **-ora**.

MASCULINE	FEMININE	MEANING
o amigo	a amiga	friend
o gato	a gata	cat
o irmão	a irmã	brother / sister
o pai	a mãe	father / mother
o homem	a mulher	man / woman
o garçom	a garçonete	waiter / waitress

Some nouns have **one form for both** and only the article changes: o/a estudante, o/a dentista, o/a colega koh-LEH-gah, o/a turista, o/a cliente, o/a jornalista. The ending -a does not make o colega or o turista feminine.

4 **Learn the rest one by one**

Nouns ending in **-e** have no reliable rule. Compare:

MASCULINE	FEMININE
o leite oo LAY-tchee (milk)	a noite ah NOY-tchee (night)
o nome oo NOH-mee (name)	a ponte ah POH~-tchee (bridge)
o dente oo DEH~-tchee (tooth)	a carne ah KAR-nee (meat)
o chocolate	a chave ah SHAH-vee (key)
o café oo kah-FEH (coffee)	a classe ah KLAH-see (class)

This is why the rule from 3.2 matters: when you meet a new noun in -e, learn it with its article from the start.

Two more things. A few words change meaning with gender: **o capital** is money invested, **a capital** is the capital city. And **loanwords** take a gender too, usually following the Portuguese word they replace: **o e-mail**, **o site**, **o shopping**, but **a internet**, **a pizza**.

> TIP
>
> Many Brazilians think about gender less than you do. When they learn English they make the opposite mistake, *the table, he is*. Do not expect to get every gender right in the first months. A wrong article rarely blocks understanding. Choose the ending rules first, then add exceptions only as you meet them.

3.4 The definite article: o, a, os, as

The **definite article** is the English *the*. It has four forms, and it matches the noun in gender and number.

	MASCULINE	FEMININE	GUIDE
singular	o	a	oo / ah
plural	os	as	ooss / ahss

Compare **o carro**, **a casa**, **os carros**, **as casas**. In speech the article is pronounced very lightly, almost glued to the noun: **o carro** sounds like *ookahhoo*.

When Portuguese uses the article and English does not

English drops "the" when we talk about things in general. Portuguese often keeps it. The main cases:

- **Subject of a general statement:** **O café é bom para a saúde.** (Coffee is good for health.) **A vida é curta.** (Life is short.) **Os brasileiros adoram futebol.**
- **Countries and regions:** **o Brasil**, **a Argentina**, **os Estados Unidos**, **o Canadá**. A few countries and nearly all cities take none: **Portugal**, **Cuba**, **Israel**, **São Paulo**, **Londres**. Some cities have an article as part of the name: **o Rio de Janeiro**, so Brazilians say **no Rio**.
- **Languages as subject:** **O português é bonito.**
- **Days of the week with a habit:** **Na segunda eu trabalho em casa.** (On Mondays I work from home.)
- **First names, in speech:** **A Marina é de Recife.** **O João chega amanhã.** This is normal in São Paulo, Rio, Minas and much of Brazil; in some regions, like parts of the Northeast and the North, it is less common. Both are correct. But never use the article when you **address** the person: **Oi, Marina!**, not **Oi, a Marina!**

- **Parts of the body and personal items:** English says *my hands*; Portuguese says **as mãos** when the owner is clear: **Lavo as mãos.** (I wash my hands.)

When Portuguese leaves the article out

- **After a verb of speaking and studying, with a language:** **Falo português**, **Estudo inglês**.
- **After ser, with a profession or nationality:** **Sou professora**, **Somos brasileiros** (Lesson 2).
- **After de in a general sense:** compare **Gosto de café** (I like coffee, in general) and **Gosto do café daqui** (I like the coffee here, a specific one). The first has **de** alone, the second **de + o = do**.
- **With com and sem for states and amounts:** **com fome**, **sem açúcar**.

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Brasil é grande.~~	**O Brasil é grande.**	most country names take the article
~~Sou o professor.~~ ~~(meaning only "I am a teacher")~~	**Sou professor.**	no article with a profession
~~Oi, a Marina!~~	**Oi, Marina!**	no article when you call someone directly
~~Falo o português.~~	**Falo português.**	no article after *falar* + language

3.5 The indefinite article: um, uma, uns, umas

The **indefinite article** is *a/an* and, in the plural, *some*.

	MASCULINE	FEMININE	GUIDE
singular	**um**	**uma**	oo~ / OO-mah
plural	**uns**	**umas**	oo~ss / OO-mahss

Um also means "one": **um café** (a coffee, one coffee), **uma cerveja** (a beer). **Uns** and **umas** mean *some* or *a few*: **uns amigos** (some friends). Before a number, **uns** and **umas** mean "about": **uns vinte reais** (about twenty reais).

Where English uses *a*, Portuguese often uses nothing:

- **Professions and nationalities:** **Sou médica**.
- **After ter, when you only say that you own one:** **Tenho carro** (I have a car), but **Tenho um carro novo** when you describe it.
- **After que in exclamations:** **Que dia lindo!** (What a beautiful day!), **Que legal!**
- **Before cem and mil:** **cem reais**, **mil pessoas**, not "um cem".

3.6 Plurals: one rule for vowels, four for consonants

The plural is easy in the large majority of cases, and the article and the adjective change with it.

1 **Words ending in a vowel: add -s**

O livro → os livros; a casa → as casas; o carro → os carros; a noite → as noites; o café → os cafés oos kah-FEHSS ; o sofá → os sofás.

2 Words ending in -r, -z, -s (stressed): add -es

SINGULAR	PLURAL	GUIDE
a mulher	as mulheres	moo-LYEH-reess
o lugar	os lugares	loo-GAH-reess (places)
a flor	as flores	FLOH-reess
a luz	as luzes	LOO-zeess (lights)
o país	os países	pah-EE-zeess (countries)
o mês	os meses	MEH-zeess (months)
o português	os portugueses	por-too-GEH-zeess

Unstressed -s does not change: o ônibus oo OH-nee-booss → os ônibus; o lápis oo LAH-peess (pencil) → os lápis. Only the article shows the plural.

3 Words ending in -m: change to -ns

O homem → os homens; o jardim zhar-DJEE~ → os jardins zhar-DJEE~ss; bom → bons BOH~ss; um → uns. Notice that the sound stays nasal.

4 Words ending in -l: drop the l and add -is

SINGULAR	PLURAL	GUIDE
o jornal	os jornais	zhor-NIESS
o animal	os animais	ah-nee-MIESS
o hotel	os hotéis	oh-TEH-eess
o papel	os papéis	pah-PEH-eess
o azul	os azuis	ah-ZOO-eess

Notice the accents on hotéis and papéis: the plural of **-el** is **-éis**. And words in -il change differently depending on stress: stressed **-il** gives **-is** (o funil → os funis), unstressed **-il** gives **-eis** (fácil → fáceis).

5 Words ending in -ão: learn the three plurals

This is the one place where you must memorize. Almost all of these words take **-ões**; a small, very frequent group takes **-ães**, and another small group takes **-ãos**.

PLURAL ENDING	SINGULAR	PLURAL	GUIDE
-ões (most words)	a lição	as lições	lee-SOH~eess
	o avião	os aviões	ah-vee-OH~eess
	a nação	as nações	nah-SOH~eess
	o limão	os limões	lee-MOH~eess
	o coração	os corações	koh-rah-SOH~eess
-ães (a few)	o pão	os pães	PAH~eess
	o cão (dog)	os cães	KAH~eess
	o capitão	os capitães	kah-pee-TAH~eess
	o alemão	os alemães	ah-leh-MAH~eess
-ãos (a few)	a mão	as mãos	MOW~ss
	o irmão	os irmãos	eer-MOW~ss
	o cidadão	os cidadãos	see-dah-DOW~ss (citizens)

Use the table as a reference, not as something to memorize in one sitting. The default is **-ões**; when a word is not on the -ães or -ãos list, use -ões.

Agreement in the whole noun phrase

Article, noun and adjective all agree: the noun sets the gender and number, and the others follow.

SINGULAR	PLURAL
o carro novo	os carros novos
a casa nova	as casas novas
o hotel barato	os hotéis baratos
a lição fácil	as lições fáceis
o pão francês	os pães franceses
um livro interessante	uns livros interessantes

Colors follow the same rule. **Branco** BRAH~-koo, **preto** PREH-too, **vermelho** ver-MEH-lyoo, **amarelo** ah-mah-REH-loo have four forms: **branco, branca, brancos, brancas**. **Azul** and **verde** VER-djee have two: **azul / azuis, verde / verdes**. So: **a casa branca, os carros azuis**.

3.7 Contractions: em, de, por and the article

Portuguese has a small set of prepositions that are used constantly: **em** (in, on, at), **de** (of, from), **por** (by, through, for). In front of an article, each one **fuses** with it into a single word. This is not optional. Saying **de o** or **em a** is always wrong.

PREPOSITION	+ O	+ A	+ OS	+ AS	+ UM	+ UMA
em (in, on, at)	no	na	nos	nas	num	numa
de (of, from)	do	da	dos	das	dum	duma

PREPOSITION	+ O	+ A	+ OS	+ AS	+ UM	+ UMA
por (through, by, for)	pelo	pela	pelos	pelas		
a (to)	ao	à	aos	às		

Pronunciation: **no** noo, **na** nah, **do** doo, **da** dah, **pelo** PEH-loo, **pela** PEH-lah. **Num** and **numa** (noo~, NOO-mah) are very common in speech; **dum** and **duma** are rare, and you can skip them.

1 **Use "em" for place and time, with no movement**

Moro no Brasil, **Trabalho num banco**, **Moro na rua das Flores**, **Estou no hotel**, **na segunda**, **no sábado**. With a city that has no article, em stays alone: **Moro em Curitiba**, **Trabalho em Lisboa**.

2 **Use "de" for origin, owner and material**

Origin: **Sou do Brasil**, **Sou da Bahia**, **Sou de Recife**. Owner: Portuguese has no apostrophe-s, so it says "the book **of** the Pedro": **o livro do Pedro**, **a casa da Marta**, **o carro dos meus pais**. Material: **uma mesa de madeira** (a wooden table; **madeira** is mah-DAY-rah).

3 **Use "por" for passing through and for reasons**

Passo pelo parque todo dia (I go through the park every day). **Obrigado pela ajuda** (Thank you for the help). **Pelo menos** (at least).

A word about the fourth line of the table, **a**: it means *to*, and it fuses with the article too: **ao** and **à** (with the grave accent, as Lesson 1 promised). You will use these with **ir** in Lessons 5 and 7. For now, notice that **à** is the only place where the grave accent appears in everyday writing.

Also remember that **de** and **em** fuse with the pronouns that come later: **dele** (of him), **nele** (in him), **desse**, **nesse**. Lesson 8 shows them.

> TIP
>
> **Do not translate "in the" word by word.** Think of **no** and **na** as single words that already include the. When you say **no Brasil**, you do not hear "em + o". Practice the whole phrase until it sounds like one word: **no Brasil**, **na casa**, **do hotel**, **da Maria**.

3.8 Say it all together

You can now build complete phrases. Read each aloud.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Moro numa casa pequena no centro.	I live in a small house downtown.
O hotel fica na rua das Flores.	The hotel is on Flowers Street.
Preciso do passaporte e da passagem.	I need the passport and the ticket.
Os pães da padaria são ótimos.	The bread from the bakery is great.
Tem uns amigos aqui.	There are some friends here.
As crianças gostam do parque.	The children like the park.

Four new things hide in these sentences, all of which you will meet again: **moro** and **preciso** are present-tense verbs (Lesson 4), **fica** and **tem** (Lesson 5) say where things are and what exists. Treat them as blocks for now.

Vocabulary: things you will name every day

Learn every noun with its article.

MASCULINE	GUIDE	FEMININE	GUIDE
o celular	oo seh-loo-LAR	a mala	ah MAH-lah
o passaporte	oo pah-sah-PAWR-tchee	a mesa	ah MEH-zah
o dinheiro	oo djee-NYAY-roo	a cadeira	ah kah-DAY-rah
o cartão	oo kar-TOW~	a janela	ah zhah-NEH-lah
o ônibus	oo OH-nee-booss	a porta	ah PAWR-tah
o banheiro	oo bah-NYAY-roo	a sacola	ah sah-KAW-lah
o café	oo kah-FEH	a conta	ah KOH~-tah
o pão	oo POW~	a água	ah AH-gwah
o suco	oo SOO-koo	a cerveja	ah ser-VAY-zhah
o computador	oo koh~-poo-tah-DOR	a viagem	ah vee-AH-zheh~ee

Água is feminine, even though it starts with an a-sound: **a água**, **a água gelada**, **as águas**.

3.9 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~a problema~~	o problema	words in **-ema** and **-oma** are masculine
~~o cidade~~	a cidade	words in **-dade** are feminine
~~a mapa~~	o mapa	**mapa** is one of the masculine words in -a
~~o mão~~	a mão	**mão** is feminine, in spite of the ending
~~os livro~~	os livros	the noun takes the plural too
~~as casa bonito~~	as casas bonitas	the article, the noun and the adjective all agree
~~os pão~~	os pães	**pão** is one of the few in **-ães**
~~as lições fácil~~	as lições fáceis	the adjective takes the plural of -il: **-eis**
~~em a casa~~	na casa	**em** + **a** always fuse
~~Sou de o Brasil.~~	Sou do Brasil.	**de** + **o** always fuse
~~Moro em o Rio.~~	Moro no Rio.	the city has an article in its name
~~Gosto de o café daqui.~~	Gosto do café daqui.	the contraction is compulsory
~~Sou uma professora.~~	Sou professora.	professions take no article
~~Falo o inglês.~~	Falo inglês.	no article after *falar* + language

3.10 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: CHOOSE THE ARTICLE

Write **o** or **a** before each noun.

1. ____ problema

2. ____ cidade

3. ____ jornal

4. ____ viagem

5. ____ mapa

6. ____ lição

7. ____ dia

8. ____ foto

9. ____ amor

10. ____ canção

PRACTICE · PART B: MAKE THE PLURAL

Write the plural, with its article.

1. o livro

2. a mulher

3. o hotel

4. o pão

5. a lição

6. o país

7. o ônibus

8. o homem

PRACTICE · PART C: FUSE THE WORDS

Complete with the contraction of em, de or por with the article. If no contraction is needed, write the preposition alone.

1. Moro ____ Brasil. (em + o)

2. Ela é ____ Bahia. (de + a)

3. O carro ____ Marta é novo. (de + a)

4. Passo ____ parque todo dia. (por + o)

5. Trabalho ____ banco. (em + o)

6. Moro ____ Curitiba. (em)

7. Gosto ____ café daqui. (de + o)

8. Eles são ____ Estados Unidos. (de + os)

PRACTICE · PART D: ARTICLE OR NOTHING?

Write the correct article, or "X" if none is needed. Use o, a, um, uma.

1. ____ Brasil é grande.

2. Ela é ____ arquiteta.

3. Quero ____ café, por favor.

4. ____ Marina é de Salvador. (spoken)

5. Falo ____ português.

6. Preciso de ____ chave.

7. Que ____ dia lindo!

8. Tem ____ banco aqui perto?

PRACTICE · PART E: FIND THE MISTAKE AND SPEAK

Each sentence has one mistake. Correct it, then read the right version aloud.

1. A problema é difícil.

2. Os livro são caros.

3. As casas são brancos.

4. Moro em o Rio.

5. Sou de o Canadá.

6. Os pão são ótimos.

7. Say five objects in the room you are in, each with the right article, in the singular and in the plural.

8. Describe three things you own with a noun and an adjective that agree, for example **uma mala preta**.

ANSWER KEY

1. **o**: ends in -ema, masculine.
2. **a**: -dade, feminine.
3. **o**: -l, mostly masculine.
4. **a**: -agem, feminine.
5. **o**: an exception in -a.
6. **a**: -ção.
7. **o**: an exception in -a.
8. **a**: short for *fotografia*, feminine.
9. **o**: -or, masculine (**o amor**).
10. **a**: -ção.
11. **os livros**.
12. **as mulheres**.
13. **os hotéis**.
14. **os pães**.
15. **as lições**.
16. **os países**.
17. **os ônibus**: unchanged; only the article shows the plural.
18. **os homens**.
19. **no**.
20. **da**.
21. **da**.
22. **pelo**.
23. **no**.
24. **em**: with a city that has no article, there is no contraction; **em** stays alone.
25. **do**: the specific coffee here.
26. **dos**.
27. **O**: countries take the article.
28. X: a profession takes no article after **ser**.
29. **um**: one coffee.
30. **A**: in speech, the article before a first name is natural.
31. X: no article after *falar* + language.
32. **uma**: **chave** is feminine.
33. X: no article after **que** in exclamations.
34. **um**: **banco** is masculine; **Tem um banco aqui perto?**
35. **O problema é difícil.**
36. **Os livros são caros.**
37. **As casas são brancas.**
38. **Moro no Rio.**
39. **Sou do Canadá.**
40. **Os pães são ótimos.**
41. A model answer: **a mesa, as mesas; o livro, os livros; a janela, as janelas; a porta, as portas; o celular, os celulares**. Check the article and the -s.
42. A model answer: **um celular novo, uma mala preta, uns livros interessantes**. Check the agreement of every adjective.

3.11 Return

These three questions bring back Lessons 1 and 2.

1. Say the four present-tense forms of **ser** and one short sentence with each.
2. Complete with the right form: **A Ana é muito ____ (simpático)**. And: **Elas são ____ (alemão)**.
3. Say aloud **pão** and **pau**. Which one is nasal, and what does each mean?

Check: (1) **sou**, **é**, **somos**, **são**; (2) **simpática**, **alemãs**; (3) **pão** `POW~` is nasal (bread); **pau** `POW` is not (stick).

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Day 1	Say the singular and plural of ten nouns with their articles.
Day 3	Say ten sentences with **no / na / do / da**.
Day 7	Describe your room with six noun phrases that agree.
Day 14	Make plurals of five words in -ão without looking.

3.12 Pocket summary: Lesson 3

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Every noun has a gender.** Learn each noun with its article: **a mesa**, **o livro**.
- **Guess from the ending:** -o masculine, -a feminine; -ção, -são, -dade, -agem feminine; -ema, -oma, -or, -l mostly masculine. Exceptions to remember: **o dia**, **o mapa**, **a mão**, **a flor**.
- **Definite article: o, a, os, as. Indefinite: um, uma, uns, umas.**
- **No article** with professions and nationalities, with *falar* + language, and after *que* in exclamations.
- **Plural:** vowel + -s; -r, -z, stressed -s + -es; -m → -ns; -l → -is; -ão → -ões (default), -ães (**pães**, **cães**), -ãos (**mãos**, **irmãos**).
- **Agreement:** article, noun and adjective share gender and number: **as casas brancas**.
- **Contractions:** em → **no, na, nos, nas, num, numa**; de → **do, da, dos, das**; por → **pelo, pela, pelos, pelas**; a → **ao, à, aos, às**.

3.13 What comes next

In Lesson 4 you meet the verb. You will conjugate regular verbs in -ar, -er and -ir in the present tense, say what you do every day, make your first negative sentences with **não**, and ask questions with **quem**, **onde**, **quando** and **como**.

LESSON 4

The present tense, negation and questions: say what you do

By the end of this lesson you can conjugate regular verbs in -ar, -er and -ir, talk about your habits and your daily life, say what you do not do, answer yes-or-no questions, and ask for information with **quem**, **o que**, **onde**, **quando**, **como**, **por que** and **quanto**.

4.1 A scene you will live

It is breakfast at a hostel in Salvador. Jess, an Australian traveler, sits with her coffee at the long table. Rafael, who works in the neighborhood and drops by every morning, starts a conversation.

DIALOGUE

Rafael: Bom dia! Você mora aqui em Salvador? **Jess:** Não, não moro. Moro em Sydney, mas viajo muito. E você? Trabalha onde? **Rafael:** Trabalho num banco. Mas no fim de semana eu ensino capoeira. **Jess:** Que legal! Eu não falo muito bem, mas estudo português todo dia. **Rafael:** Você fala muito bem! Quer um café? A gente bebe café aqui o dia inteiro. **Jess:** Quero, sim. Eu adoro café. Quanto custa? **Rafael:** Nada. É de graça.

Rafael: Good morning! Do you live here in Salvador? / Jess: No, I don't. I live in Sydney, but I travel a lot. And you? Where do you work? / Rafael: I work at a bank. But on weekends I teach capoeira. / Jess: How cool! I don't speak very well, but I study Portuguese every day. / Rafael: You speak very well! Would you like a coffee? We drink coffee here all day long. / Jess: Yes, please. I love coffee. How much is it? / Rafael: Nothing. It's free.

Look at the verbs: **mora**, **moro**, **viajo**, **trabalha**, **trabalho**, **ensino**, **falo**, **estudo**, **fala**, **bebe**, **adoro**. Each one is different from the infinitive (**morar**, **trabalhar**, **falar**), and each ending tells you who is speaking. Notice, too, what is missing: Rafael never says "do" or "does". **Você mora aqui?** is a statement with a question mark and a rising voice. And Jess says **não moro** with a single **não** in front of the verb. That is the whole negative.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
morar	moh-RAR	to live (in a place)
viajar	vee-ah-ZHAR	to travel
ensinar	eh~-see-NAR	to teach
capoeira	kah-poh-AY-rah	capoeira (a Brazilian martial art and dance)

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
o fim de semana	oo FEE~ djee seh-MAH-nah	the weekend
beber	beh-BEHR	to drink
de graça	djee GRAH-sah	free, for nothing

4.2 The trap: English hides the person, Portuguese shows it

English verbs hardly change: *I work, you work, we work, they work*, and only *he works* adds an -s. English also needs a helper for questions and negatives: *Do you work? I do not work.* Portuguese does the opposite.

1. **The verb changes with the person**: **eu trabalho**, **ele trabalha**, **nós trabalhamos**, **eles trabalham**.
2. **There is no *do* or *does*.** The question is the statement with a rising voice, and the negative is the statement with **não** in front of the verb.
3. **One present for many English tenses.** **Moro em Salvador** translates *I live in Salvador*, but **Eu falo português todo dia** is *I speak Portuguese every day*. Later you will meet **estou falando** (*I am speaking*), but the simple present also serves for what is happening around now and even for the near future: **Amanhã eu viajo** (I leave tomorrow).

4.3 How a verb is built

Every Portuguese verb has an **infinitive**, the "to ___" form, and it always ends in **-ar**, **-er** or **-ir**. Remove the ending and you have the **stem**. Then add the endings of the present tense.

1 **Find the group**

Look at the last two letters of the infinitive. **Falar** (to speak) is an **-ar** verb; **comer** (to eat) is an **-er** verb; **abrir** (to open) is an **-ir** verb. Most Portuguese verbs are -ar verbs, so that is the group to learn first.

2 **Remove the ending**

Falar → **fal-**. **Comer** → **com-**. **Abrir** → **abr-**.

3 **Add the ending that matches the person**

There are only **four** forms you need, because **você**, **ele**, **ela** and **a gente** share one, and **vocês**, **eles** and **elas** share another.

PERSON	-AR: FALAR	-ER: COMER	-IR: ABRIR
eu	falo FAH-loo	como KOH-moo	abro AH-broo
você / ele / ela / a gente	fala FAH-lah	come KAW-mee	abre AH-bree
nós	falamos fah-LAH-mooss	comemos koh-MEH-mooss	abrimos ah-BREE-mooss
vocês / eles / elas	falam FAH-lah~oo	comem KAW-meh~ee	abrem AH-breh~ee

Learn the endings, not the three verbs:

	-AR	-ER	-IR
eu	-o	-o	-o
você / ele / ela / a gente	-a	-e	-e
nós	-amos	-emos	-imos
vocês / eles / elas	-am	-em	-em

Look at the table: the -er and -ir verbs differ in only one place, the **nós** form (**-emos** against **-imos**). Everything else is the same. And the **eu** form always ends in **-o**.

> TIP
>
> **The pronoun is optional, the ending is not.** **Falo**, **fala** and **falam** work alone because the ending tells you the person. But **fala** could be **você**, **ele**, **ela** or **a gente**, so keep the pronoun or name when it is not clear from context: **Você fala inglês?**, **Ela fala inglês**.

The stress moves in the nós form

The stress sits on the stem in three of the four forms: **FA-lo**, **FA-la**, **FA-lam**. In the **nós** form it moves to the ending: **fa-LA-mos**. Say it aloud: **falo** `FAH-loo`, but **falamos** `fah-LAH-mooss`. This needs no new rule. Lesson 1 says that words ending in a vowel or in **-s** are stressed on the second-to-last syllable. In **falo** that syllable is the stem; in **falamos** the extra syllable **-mos** pushes the stress onto the ending.

The third-person plural ending **-am** is pronounced `ah~oo`, and **-em** is `eh~ee`. Do not say "AM" as in *ham*. Compare **ele fala** `EH-lee FAH-lah` and **eles falam** `EH-leess FAH-lah~oo`: in speech, the difference between singular and plural is precisely that final nasal sound, so make it clear.

What about tu?

If you travel in the South or Northeast, you may hear **tu** forms: **tu falas**, **tu comes**, **tu abres**, ending in **-s**; or **tu fala**, **tu come**, with the **ele** form. You can safely stay with **você**.

4.4 Twenty-five regular verbs to start with

Start with the infinitives below. Each one follows the endings in 4.3.

-AR	GUIDE	MEANING	-ER / -IR	GUIDE	MEANING
falar	fah-LAR	to speak	comer	koh-MEHR	to eat
morar	moh-RAR	to live	beber	beh-BEHR	to drink
trabalhar	trah-bah-LYAR	to work	aprender	ah-preh~-DEHR	to learn
estudar	ehs-too-DAR	to study	vender	veh~-DEHR	to sell
comprar	koh~-PRAR	to buy	escrever	ehs-kreh-VEHR	to write
chegar	sheh-GAR	to arrive	entender	eh~-teh~-DEHR	to understand
usar	oo-ZAR	to use	viver	vee-VEHR	to live (be alive)
precisar	preh-see-ZAR	to need	correr	koh-HEHR	to run
ajudar	ah-zhoo-DAR	to help	abrir	ah-BREER	to open
pagar	pah-GAR	to pay	partir	par-TCHEER	to leave
esperar	ehs-peh-RAR	to wait, to hope	decidir	deh-see-DJEER	to decide
ficar	fee-KAR	to stay, to be located	assistir	ah-sees-TCHEER	to watch
viajar	vee-ah-ZHAR	to travel	dividir	djee-vee-DJEER	to divide, to share

Two common verbs work with a small word after them. **Gostar** (to like) and **precisar** (to need) take **de**: **Gosto de café**, **Preciso de ajuda** (I need help). Other verbs, like **esperar** (to wait), **pagar** (to pay) and **ajudar** (to help), take no preposition in Portuguese: **Espero o ônibus**, **Pago a conta**, **Ajudo o Pedro**. You will meet more of these in Lesson 8.

Two more useful ones, with a meaning you cannot guess: **tomar café** toh-MAR kah-FEH (to have coffee; also *to drink*, *to take*) and **pegar o ônibus** peh-GAR oo OH-nee-booss (to catch the bus). Brazilians say **tomar** for drinks and medicines, **pegar** for transport, and **comer** for food.

Small spelling facts about the *eu* form

In the present tense a regular verb does not change its spelling except in a few cases. Two you will see early:

- Verbs ending in **-ger** or **-gir** change the **g** to **j** in the **eu** form, to keep the *zh* sound: **dirigir** (to drive) → **dirijo**, **proteger** → **protejo**.
- Verbs ending in **-cer** change **c** to **ç**: **conhecer** → **conheço**. (This verb comes in Lesson 7.)

4.5 Using the present tense

The present tense of the Brazilian speaker covers more than the English one.

USE	EXAMPLE	MEANING
a fact or a state	**Moro em Salvador.**	I live in Salvador.
a habit	**Estudo português todo dia.**	I study Portuguese every day.
a routine of a group	**A gente bebe café o dia inteiro.**	We drink coffee all day.
something planned	**Amanhã eu viajo.**	I'm leaving tomorrow.
a general truth	**O sol nasce no leste.**	The sun rises in the east.

For frequency, the usual words go in front of the verb:

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
sempre	SEH~-pree	always	**Sempre bebo café de manhã.**
normalmente	nor-mah-oo-MEH~-tchee	normally	**Normalmente chego cedo.**
às vezes	ahss VEH-zeess	sometimes	**Às vezes como fora.**
nunca	NOO~-kah	never	**Nunca bebo café à noite.**
todo dia	TOH-doo DJEE-ah	every day	**Estudo todo dia.**
de manhã	djee mah-NYAH~	in the morning	**De manhã trabalho em casa.**

(**Cedo** SEH-doo means *early*.) **Todo dia** and **todos os dias** are the same, with **todo dia** the more natural in speech.

4.6 Making a negative: não

To say what you do not do, put **não** in front of the verb. Nothing else changes. There is no *do* or *does*.

POSITIVE	NEGATIVE
Eu moro em Salvador.	**Eu não moro em Salvador.**
Ele fala alemão.	**Ele não fala alemão.**

POSITIVE	NEGATIVE
Nós comemos carne.	Nós não comemos carne.

When you answer a yes-or-no question, Brazilians often repeat the verb, with or without **sim**, instead of giving a bare *yes*:

QUESTION	YES	NO
Você mora aqui?	Moro, sim.	Não, não moro.
Ela fala inglês?	Fala, sim.	Não, não fala.
Vocês bebem café?	Bebemos, sim.	Não, não bebemos.

Note that "no" appears twice: the answer **não**, and then the **não** that belongs to the verb. A common reply is just **Não** or **Não moro**.

Negative words: Portuguese is fine with several

English avoids the double negative ("I don't know nothing"). Portuguese needs it. When the negative word **follows** the verb, the verb also gets **não**.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
nada	NAH-dah	nothing	**Não como nada.** (I don't eat anything.)
ninguém	nee~-GEH~ee	nobody	**Não conheço ninguém aqui.**
nunca	NOO~-kah	never	**Nunca como carne.** or **Não como carne nunca.**
nenhum / nenhuma	neh-NYOO~	no, not one	**Não tenho nenhum problema.**

When the negative word comes **before** the verb, you do not add **não**: **Nunca como carne**, **Ninguém sabe**, **Nada funciona**. Both patterns are correct and natural. Choose one and use it every time.

4.7 Asking questions

Yes-or-no questions

In Portuguese, a yes-or-no question has the **same word order** as the statement. The only difference is the melody: your voice rises at the end.

STATEMENT (VOICE FALLS)	QUESTION (VOICE RISES)
Você mora aqui.	Você mora aqui?
Ela trabalha num banco.	Ela trabalha num banco?
Vocês falam inglês.	Vocês falam inglês?

Brazilians often add a confirming word at the end: **né?** `neh` (right? isn't it?), a short form of **não é?**: **Você mora aqui, né?** It is a very natural way to ask for agreement, and it is one of the small words that make you sound Brazilian. You can also give two options with **ou** (or): **Você quer café ou chá?**

Question words

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
quem	KEH~ee	who	Quem fala português aqui?
o que	oo KEE	what	O que você faz?
onde	OH~-djee	where	Onde você mora?

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
quando	KWAH~-doo	when	Quando você viaja?
como	KOH-moo	how	Como você vai para o trabalho?
por que	poor KEE	why	Por que você estuda português?
qual / quais	KWAH-oo / KWIESS	which	Qual é a sua cidade?
quanto / quanta	KWAH~-too / KWAH~-tah	how much	Quanto custa o café?
quantos / quantas	KWAH~-tooss / KWAH~-tahss	how many	Quantos anos você tem?

1 **Put the question word first**

In Portuguese the question word begins the sentence, and the rest follows in statement order: **Onde você mora?**, not "Onde mora você?" (although that also exists in writing). In casual speech you will often hear the word at the end instead: **Você mora onde?** It is correct, informal, and very common.

2 **Use "quem" with a singular verb**

With ordinary verbs, **quem** takes the **ele/ela** form, even when you expect several people: **Quem fala português aqui?** (Who here speaks Portuguese?).

3 **Add "é que" when you want to sound natural**

Brazilians often insert **é que** after the question word: **Onde é que você mora?** OH~-djee eh kee voh-SEH MAW-rah. It adds a little emphasis, like *where on earth do you live?*, and appears in everyday talk. You do not need to use it, but you will hear it.

4 **Keep the four "why" words apart**

There are four spellings, and Brazilian schools teach them separately. At the start or middle of a question: **por que** (two words): **Por que você estuda?** At the end of a sentence: **por quê**: **Você estuda? Por quê?** In an answer: **porque** (one word): **Porque gosto da língua.** The noun "the reason" is **o porquê**. You need only the first and third forms for now.

WATCH OUT

Qual and **o que** both translate *what* in some English sentences. Use **qual** when you choose among possibilities: **Qual é o seu nome?**, **Qual é a sua cidade?** Use **o que** for open questions with a verb: **O que você faz?**, **O que é isso?**

4.8 The irregular verbs you already need

A few of the most frequent verbs in Portuguese are irregular in the present. You have met **ser** (Lesson 2) and a few in the scenes. Here is a first look at six more; each form is given with a guide. Lessons 5 and 7 teach you to use them.

	TER (TO HAVE)	IR (TO GO)	FAZER (TO DO, TO MAKE)	VER (TO SEE)	DAR (TO GIVE)	ESTAR (TO BE)
eu	tenho TEH-nyoo	vou VOH	faço FAH-soo	vejo VEH-zhoo	dou DOH	estou ehs-TOH
você / ele / ela / a gente	tem TEH~ee	vai vie	faz fahss	vê veh	dá dah	está ehs-TAH
nós	temos TEH-mooss	vamos VAH-mooss	fazemos fah-ZEH-mooss	vemos VEH-mooss	damos DAH-mooss	estamos ehs-TAH-mooss
vocês / eles / elas	têm TEH~ee	vão VOW~	fazem FAH-zeh~ee	veem VEH-eh~ee	dão DOW~	estão ehs-TOW~

Look at the pairs **tem** and **têm**. They sound the same, and the circumflex only tells you in writing that the second is plural: **Ele tem**, **Eles têm**. The same system works for **vem** (he comes) and **vêm** (they come) in Lesson 7. And remember that **veem** (they see) lost its circumflex after the 2009 spelling reform.

You already use these verbs in the blocks you have learned: **Tenho trinta anos**, **O que você faz?**, **Vamos?** Learn the full picture in the next lessons; for now, notice only that the **nós** form always ends in **-mos** and the **eles** form in **-m** or a nasal **-ão**.

4.9 A mini-interview: ask, answer, return the question

Real conversation moves in a loop: someone asks, you answer, you ask back. The little word that closes the loop is **e você?** (and you?). Read this short interview aloud, then cover the right-hand column and answer for yourself.

QUESTION	POSSIBLE ANSWER
Você mora aqui?	Moro, sim. E você?
Onde você trabalha?	Trabalho num hospital. E você?
Você fala outras línguas?	Falo inglês e um pouco de espanhol.
O que você faz no fim de semana?	Assisto a filmes e encontro os amigos.
Você come carne?	Não, não como. Sou vegetariano.
Quando você estuda?	Estudo de manhã, antes do trabalho.

Two things to notice. First, the verb in the answer repeats the verb in the question, but its person changes: **Você mora** becomes **Moro**. Second, English speakers tend to answer with a full sentence, "I live here". In Portuguese, the short answer is more natural: **Moro**, **Trabalho num hospital**. The pronoun **eu** appears only for contrast: **Eu moro aqui, mas ela mora em Recife**.

New words in the table: **outro / outra** `OH-troo` (other), **encontrar** `eh~-koh~-TRAR` (to meet, to find), **o filme** `oo FEE-oo-mee` (the film), **antes de** `AH~-tcheess djee` (before), **vegetariano** `veh-zheh-tah-ree-AH-noo`, **o hospital** `oo ohs-pee-TAH-oo`.

4.10 Read a real text

Read the text aloud, first with the guide and then without it.

> Eu sou o Rafael. Moro em Salvador e trabalho num banco. De manhã, tomo café e pego o ônibus. No almoço, como arroz e feijão com os colegas. À noite, assisto a uma série. Aos sábados, ensino capoeira.

Guide:
`EH-oo SOH oo hah-fah-EH-oo. MAW-roo eh~ee sah-oo-vah-DOR ee trah-BAH-lyoo noo~ BAH~-koo. djee mah-NYAH~, TOH-moo kah-FEH ee PEH-goo oo`

Translation: *I am Rafael. I live in Salvador and work at a bank. In the morning, I have coffee and catch the bus. At lunch, I eat rice and beans with my colleagues. At night, I watch a series. On Saturdays, I teach capoeira.*

Check the verbs: **moro**, **trabalho**, **tomo**, **pego**, **como**, **assisto**, **ensino**. All are **eu** forms in **-o**. Now rewrite the text about someone else, changing every verb to the **ele** form: **Ele mora em Salvador e trabalha num banco…**

4.11 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu fala português.~~	Eu falo português.	**eu** always takes the ending **-o**
~~Ele falo inglês.~~	Ele fala inglês.	**ele** takes **-a** (verbs in -ar)
~~Nós come arroz.~~	Nós comemos arroz.	**nós** ends in **-mos**
~~Eles fala português.~~	Eles falam português.	the plural ends in **-m**
~~Você faz fala português?~~	Você fala português?	there is no *do* or *does*
~~Eu não faço falo alemão.~~	Eu não falo alemão.	the negative is **não** plus the verb
~~Eu falo não alemão.~~	Eu não falo alemão.	**não** goes in front of the verb
~~Eu tenho nada.~~	Eu não tenho nada.	after the verb, **nada** needs **não** before the verb
~~Eu sou moro em Salvador.~~	Moro em Salvador.	do not add *ser* to a verb; **moro** already says "I live"
~~Eu gosto café.~~	Eu gosto de café.	**gostar** takes **de**
~~Eu preciso um café.~~	Eu preciso de um café.	**precisar** takes **de**
~~Quanto anos você tem?~~	Quantos anos você tem?	**quanto** agrees with **anos**

4.12 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: CONJUGATE THE VERB

Write the correct present-tense form.

1. Eu (falar) ____ inglês e português.

2. Você (morar) ____ aqui?

3. Nós (comer) ____ arroz todo dia.

4. Eles (trabalhar) ____ num hospital.

5. A gente (beber) ____ muito café.

6. Eu (abrir) ____ a loja de manhã.

7. Vocês (aprender) ____ rápido.

8. Ela (escrever) ____ para a mãe.

9. Eu (assistir) ____ a uma série.

10. Nós (viver) ____ perto do centro.

11. Ele (ter) ____ dois irmãos.

12. Eles (ir) ____ ao cinema.

13. Eu (fazer) ____ exercícios.

14. Nós (ver) ____ televisão.

PRACTICE · PART B: CHOOSE THE QUESTION WORD

Complete each question with quem, o que, onde, quando, como, por que, qual or quanto.

1. ____ você mora?

2. ____ fala português aqui?

3. ____ você faz? (Your job.)

4. ____ você viaja? (In July.)

5. ____ você vai para o trabalho? (By bus.)

6. ____ você estuda português? (Because I love it.)

7. ____ é o seu nome?

8. ____ custa o café?

PRACTICE · PART C: SAY NO

Make each sentence negative, or answer the question negatively.

1. Eu moro em Lisboa.

2. Ele fala alemão.

3. Nós comemos carne.

4. Eles bebem café.

5. Você fala russo? (Answer: no.)

6. Elas trabalham aqui? (Answer: no.)

7. Eu como tudo. (Say: I don’t eat anything.)

8. Eu sempre bebo café à noite. (Say: I never drink coffee at night.)

PRACTICE · PART D: CORRECT THE MISTAKE

Each sentence has one mistake. Correct it.

1. Eu falo não alemão.

2. Você faz fala inglês?

3. Ele trabalho num banco.

4. Nós come arroz.

5. Eles fala inglês.

6. Eu gosto café.

7. Quanto anos você tem?

8. Onde mora você?

PRACTICE · PART E: SPEAK AND WRITE

1. Say five things you do every day, using five different verbs in the **eu** form.

2. Say three things you never do, with **nunca** or **não**.

3. Write four questions to a new colleague, using four different question words.

4. Describe what a friend or family member does, with at least four verbs in the **ele/ela** form.

ANSWER KEY

1. **falo**.
2. **mora**: **você** takes the **ele** form.
3. **comemos**.
4. **trabalham**.
5. **bebe**: **a gente** takes the **ele** form.
6. **abro**.
7. **aprendem**.
8. **escreve**.
9. **assisto**. (Say **assisto a uma série** or just **assisto série**; both are heard.)
10. **vivemos**.
11. **tem**.
12. **vão**.
13. **faço**.
14. **vemos**.
15. **Onde**.
16. **Quem**.
17. **O que**.
18. **Quando**.
19. **Como**.
20. **Por que**.
21. **Qual**.
22. **Quanto**.
23. **Eu não moro em Lisboa.**
24. **Ele não fala alemão.**
25. **Nós não comemos carne.**
26. **Eles não bebem café.**
27. **Não, não falo.**
28. **Não, não trabalham.**
29. **Não como nada.**
30. **Nunca bebo café à noite.** (or **Não bebo café à noite nunca.**)
31. **Eu não falo alemão.**
32. **Você fala inglês?**
33. **Ele trabalha num banco.**
34. **Nós comemos arroz.**
35. **Eles falam inglês.**
36. **Eu gosto de café.**
37. **Quantos anos você tem?**
38. **Onde você mora?**
39. A model answer: **Estudo português. Tomo café. Trabalho em casa. Como arroz. Assisto a uma série.** Check that every verb ends in **-o**.
40. A model answer: **Nunca como carne. Não bebo álcool. Não assisto televisão.**
41. A model answer: **Onde você mora? O que você faz? Quando você chega? Por que você estuda português?**
42. A model answer: **A minha irmã mora em Lisboa. Ela trabalha num hospital. Ela fala três línguas. Ela viaja muito.** Check that every verb ends in **-a**.

4.13 Return

These three questions bring back Lessons 1 to 3.

1. Make the plural, with the article: **a lição**, **o hotel**, **o pão**.
2. Complete with the fused form: **Moro ____ Brasil** (em + o), **Sou ____ Bahia** (de + a).

3. Say the four present-tense forms of **ser** and give the stress of **falamos** and **falam**.

Check: (1) **as lições**, **os hotéis**, **os pães**; (2) **no**, **da**; (3) **sou**, **é**, **somos**, **são**; **fa-LA-mos** (on the ending), **FA-lam** (on the stem).

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Day 1	Conjugate **falar**, **comer** and **abrir** aloud, in the four forms.
Day 3	Say ten sentences about your day, five positive and five negative.
Day 7	Ask a friend (or yourself) eight questions with eight different question words.
Day 14	Tell a short story about someone's routine, using the **ele/ela** form only.

4.14 Pocket summary: Lesson 4

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Three groups:** -ar, -er, -ir. Take off the ending and add: **eu -o**; **você/ele/ela/a gente -a** (-ar) or **-e** (-er, -ir); **nós -amos / -emos / -imos**; **vocês/eles/elas -am** (-ar) or **-em** (-er, -ir).
- **Stress:** on the stem (**FAlo**, **FAla**, **FAlam**) except in **nós**: **faLAmos**.
- **Pronouns are optional**; keep them with **é**, **fala** and any ambiguous form.
- **Negative:** **não** + verb. Negative words after the verb need **não** before it: **Não como nada**. Before the verb, they stand alone: **Nunca como carne**.
- **Questions:** same order as the statement, voice up. Question word first: **quem**, **o que**, **onde**, **quando**, **como**, **por que**, **qual**, **quanto**. In speech: **né?** and **é que**.
- **Verbs with de:** **gostar de**, **precisar de**.
- **First irregulars:** **ter**, **ir**, **fazer**, **ver**, **dar**, **estar**, with **eu tenho / vou / faço / vejo / dou / estou**.
- **Spelling:** **dirigir** → **dirijo**, **conhecer** → **conheço**; **têm** (plural) and **tem** (singular) sound alike.

4.15 What comes next

In Lesson 5 you meet the two Portuguese verbs for *to be* side by side. You will learn **estar** for states and places, **ter** for having and for age, **tem** and **há** for *there is*, and the great contrast of **ser** and **estar**: **ele é chato** is not **ele está chato**.

LESSON 5

Estar, ter, haver: ser or estar, and “there is”

By the end of this lesson you can say where things and people are, describe how you feel right now, say what you have and what exists (“there is”), choose between **ser** and **estar** with confidence, and use the contractions **ao**, **à**, **daqui**, **pra** and **pro** in everyday speech.

5.1 A scene you will live

Laura has just arrived in Rio after a long flight. Marcos, who rents her the apartment, meets her at the door.

DIALOGUE

Laura: Oi! Você é o Marcos? **Marcos:** Sou eu! Bem-vinda! Você está cansada da viagem? **Laura:** Um pouco. E estou com fome. Tem algum restaurante por aqui? **Marcos:** Tem, sim. Tem uma pizzaria na esquina e um restaurante japonês em frente à praça. **Laura:** Ótimo. E o banheiro? Onde fica? **Marcos:** Está ali, ao lado da cozinha. A internet tem senha. Está na parede, perto da porta. **Laura:** Perfeito. Muito obrigada!

Laura: Hi! Are you Marcos? / Marcos: That’s me! Welcome! Are you tired from the trip? / Laura: A little. And I’m hungry. Is there a restaurant around here? / Marcos: Yes, there is. There’s a pizzeria on the corner and a Japanese restaurant across from the square. / Laura: Great. And the bathroom? Where is it? / Marcos: It’s right there, next to the kitchen. The internet has a password. It’s on the wall, near the door. / Laura: Perfect. Thank you very much!

Count the “to be” verbs: **é** (“Você é o Marcos?”), **está** (“Você está cansada”), **estou** (“Estou com fome”), **fica** (where the bathroom is), **está** again (it is there). Two verbs, **ser** and **estar**, where English uses only “to be”. And there are two surprises: **tem** means *there is* in the question **Tem algum restaurante?**, and the same **tem** means *has* in **A internet tem senha**.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
bem-vindo / bem-vinda	beh~ee-VEE~-doo	welcome
cansado / cansada	kah~-SAH-doo	tired
a fome	ah FOH-mee	hunger
algum	ow-GOO~	any, some
o restaurante	oo heh-stow-RAH~-tchee	the restaurant
a esquina	ah ehs-KEE-nah	the corner
a praça	ah PRAH-sah	the square

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
em frente a	eh~ee FREH~-tchee ah	in front of, across from
ao lado de	ow LAH-doo djee	next to
perto de	PEHR-too djee	near
a senha	ah SEH-nyah	the password
a parede	ah pah-REH-djee	the wall

5.2 The trap: one “to be” in English, two in Portuguese

English says *I am Laura*, *I am tired*, *I am in Rio* and *I am twenty* with the same verb. Portuguese uses **different verbs**:

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE	VERB
I am Laura.	Eu sou a Laura.	ser
I am tired.	Estou cansada.	estar
I am in Rio.	Estou no Rio.	estar
I am twenty.	Tenho vinte anos.	ter
I am hungry.	Estou com fome. / Tenho fome.	estar / ter
There is a bank.	Tem um banco.	ter

So the lesson has three traps in a row. First, English “to be” splits into **ser** and **estar**. Second, a lot of states that English says with “to be” (*I am hungry, cold, afraid*) use **ter** or **estar com** in Portuguese. Third, English “there is” uses no “be” verb in Brazilian speech: Brazilians say **tem**, literally “has”.

5.3 Estar: how you are, where you are

You met the forms of **estar** in Lesson 4. Here they are again, with the informal forms that Brazilians really use.

PERSON	STANDARD	GUIDE	SPOKEN
eu	estou	ehs-TOH	tô toh
você / ele / ela / a gente	está	ehs-TAH	tá tah
nós	estamos	ehs-TAH-mooss	(a gente) tá
vocês / eles / elas	estão	ehs-TOW~	tão TOW~

In speech and in text messages, **estou** becomes **tô** and **está** becomes **tá**: **Tô cansada**, **Tá bom**, **Tá frio**. Both are normal in conversation and in chats; use **estou** and **está** when you write formally or want to be careful. The word **tá** alone also means *okay*: **Tá**, **tá bom**, **tá certo**.

Estar is the verb for **a situation that can change**: where someone or something is right now, and how someone feels or looks right now. It has three main uses.

1 **Use estar for where something or someone is**

Estou no hotel. Os meus pais estão em Lisboa. A chave está na mesa. The place can be anywhere: even if you live in Rio for ten years, you say **Estou no Rio**.

2 **Use estar for how someone is now**

This is the "state of the moment": feelings, health, tiredness, mood. **Estou cansada. Ele está doente. Elas estão felizes. O café está quente.** (The coffee is hot, right now.)

3 **Use estar before "com" for physical sensations**

Estou com fome (I'm hungry), **Estou com sede** `SEH-djee` (thirsty), **Estou com sono** `SOH-noo` (sleepy), **Estou com frio** (cold), **Estou com calor** (hot), **Estou com pressa** `PREH-sah` (in a hurry), **Estou com medo** `MEH-doo` (afraid). Brazilians say it all day.

You will also use **estar** to form the progressive, as in **Estou estudando** (I am studying). That belongs to Lesson 9. For now, memorize only that **estar** is the verb of "right now".

> TIP
>
> The question **Como você está?** `KOH-moo voh-SEH ehs-TAH` means *How are you (right now)?* The standard answers: **Estou bem, obrigado** / **obrigada**, **Tô bem, e você?**, **Mais ou menos** `MIES oh MEH-nooss` (so-so), **Estou cansado**. **Tudo bem?** from Lesson 1 is the casual version.

5.4 Saying where things are

Place is where learners most often get stuck. These are the words you need.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
aqui	ah-KEE	here
aí	ah-EE	there (near you)
ali	ah-LEE	over there
lá	lah	there (far)
perto de	PEHR-too djee	near
longe de	LOH~-zhee djee	far from
ao lado de	ow LAH-doo djee	next to
em frente a / de	eh~ee FREH~-tchee ah	opposite, across from
atrás de	ah-TRAHSS djee	behind
entre	EH~-tree	between
em cima de	eh~ee SEE-mah djee	on top of
embaixo de	eh~-BIE-shoo djee	under
dentro de	DEH~-troo djee	inside
fora de	FAW-rah djee	outside
na esquina	nah ehs-KEE-nah	on the corner
no centro	noo SEH~-troo	downtown

These words end in **de** or **a**, so they fuse with an article following them: **perto do hotel**, **ao lado da farmácia**, **em frente ao banco**, **atrás da loja**, **longe do centro**. The contractions are the ones from Lesson 3; the only new ones are **ao** and **à**, which you will see in 5.8.

Now you have two verbs for “is located”, and a third is the one Brazilians use most.

VERB	USE	EXAMPLE
estar	a person or thing in a place now	**A Marina está no trabalho.**
ficar	a fixed place: a building, a city, a street	**O banco fica na rua principal.**
ser	the place of an event	**A festa é na casa da Júlia.**

Look at the contrast between the first two. People move, so **estar** fits: **Onde está o Pedro?** (Where is Pedro?). Buildings do not move, so Brazilians say **ficar**: **Onde fica o banco?** (Where is the bank?). You can say **Onde está o banco?** too, and it is understood, but **fica** is the natural question. The third verb is the surprise: when you say where an **event** happens (a party, a class, a meeting, a wedding), use **ser**: **A reunião é na sala dois**, **O casamento é na igreja**. Think of an event as something that **is**, not something that is *located*.

HOW IT COMPARES

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE
Where is the bank?	**Onde fica o banco?** (fixed place)
Where is Pedro?	**Onde está o Pedro?** (a person, now)
Where is the party?	**Onde é a festa?** (an event)

5.5 Ter: to have, and much more

Ter is irregular in the present tense (it appeared in Lesson 4), and it is the second most useful verb in the language after **ser**.

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE	MEANING
eu	**tenho**	TEH-nyoo	I have
você / ele / ela / a gente	**tem**	TEH~ee	you have / he has / she has / we have
nós	**temos**	TEH-mooss	we have
vocês / eles / elas	**têm**	TEH~ee	you have / they have

Four uses to know right away:

1. **Possession and family:** **Tenho um carro**, **Ela tem dois irmãos**, **Você tem filhos?**
2. **Age:** **Tenho trinta anos** (Lesson 2).
3. **Feelings and sensations:** **Tenho fome**, **Tenho sede**, **Tenho sono**, **Tenho frio**, **Tenho calor**, **Tenho medo**, **Tenho pressa**. These are the same as **estar com**. **Tenho fome** and **Estou com fome** are both correct, and Brazilians use both all the time.
4. **“There is” and “there are”:** see the next section.

WATCH OUT

The plural **têm** sounds exactly like the singular **tem**. The circumflex only appears in writing. In speech you hear the context: **Ele tem** and **Eles têm** sound the same.

5.6 “There is”: tem, há and existir

English “there is” and “there are” have no subject in Portuguese. Brazilians say **tem** in everyday speech. It is invariable: singular or plural, the verb does not change.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Tem um banco aqui perto?	Is there a bank near here?
Tem, sim. / **Não tem.**	Yes, there is. / No, there isn’t.
Tem muita gente na praia.	There are a lot of people on the beach.
Tem dois restaurantes na rua.	There are two restaurants on the street.
Não tem táxi.	There are no taxis.

You will also meet **há** `ah`, the same idea in a more formal or written style: **Há muitos turistas na cidade**. And **existir** `eh-zees-TCHEER` is used mostly for “exists” in a formal sense: **Existe uma solução**. A learner can use **tem** everywhere in conversation and **há** in writing.

There is a small trap: because **tem** also means “he has”, the plural **têm** must not be used for “there are”. Say **Tem muitos carros na rua**, never **Têm muitos carros**. When the speaker means *they have*, the plural is used: **Os brasileiros têm muitos amigos**.

Há has a second job: it marks **time that has passed**: **Moro aqui há dois anos** (I have lived here for two years). You will see this again with the numbers of Lesson 6.

5.7 Ser × estar: the great contrast

Now that you have both verbs, the central rule is this one.

Ser says what something *is*: its identity, its nature, where it comes from.
Estar says how something *is right now*: its situation, its state, where it is.

	SER	ESTAR
identity, name	**Sou a Laura.**	
nationality, origin	**Sou do Brasil.**	
profession	**Ela é médica.**	
permanent qualities	**A casa é grande.**	
time, dates	**É uma hora.**	
event location	**A festa é na casa da Ana.**	
location of a person or object		**Ela está em casa.**
feeling, health, mood		**Ele está cansado.**
temporary condition		**O café está frio.**
progressive (Lesson 9)		**Estou estudando.**

Some adjectives work with **both** verbs, and the meaning changes. This is where you really learn the difference.

WITH SER	WITH ESTAR
Ele é chato. SHAH-too He is a boring or annoying person.	**Ele está chato hoje.** He is being annoying today.
Ela é bonita. She is pretty.	**Ela está bonita hoje.** She looks pretty today (she dressed up).
Ele é nervoso. ner-VOH-zoo He is a nervous person.	**Ele está nervoso.** He is nervous now.
Ela é feliz. She is a happy person.	**Ela está feliz.** She is happy now.
Ele é calmo. He is calm by nature.	**Ele está calmo.** He is calm at the moment.
O Pedro é doente. He has a long-term illness.	**O Pedro está doente.** He is sick (now).

1 **Ask yourself: "Is it what it IS, or how it IS NOW?"**

If you are naming or classifying (*who, what, where from, what kind*), use **ser**. If you are describing a situation that can change (*where, how right now*), use **estar**.

2 **Check the verbs that you cannot translate**

Some English sentences hide a trap. "The coffee is cold" is **O café está frio**, because the temperature is a state. "The coffee is expensive" is **O café é caro**, because the price is a feature. Likewise **A sopa está quente** (the soup is hot now) but **A sopa é boa** (the soup is a good one).

3 **Remember what to do with marital status**

In Brazil, people say **Sou casado** / **Sou casada** (I am married) and **Sou solteiro** / **Sou solteira** (I am single), with **ser**, even though you could argue the state can change. Learn these as blocks.

> TIP
>
> When you cannot decide, try both in your head with "usually" and "right now". "Pedro is usually friendly" → **ser**. "Pedro is sad right now" → **estar**. If both fit, the meaning will change, as in **chato**. If the sentence says where someone or something is, use **estar** (or **ficar** for a building). If it says where an event is, use **ser**.

5.8 The contractions of place: ao, à, daqui, pra and pro

In Lesson 3 you learned **no**, **na**, **do**, **da**, **pelo**, **pela**. Now you add the contraction of **a** (to) and the forms Brazilians use in speech.

PREPOSITION	+ O	+ A	+ OS	+ AS
a (to)	**ao**	**à**	**aos**	**às**

The **grave accent** on **à** and **às** is called the **crase** KRAH-zee. It marks the fusion of the preposition **a** with the article **a**. The rule: use it when the verb asks for **a** and the noun is feminine and takes **a**. A simple test: replace the noun with a masculine one. If you would say **ao**, write **à**: **Vou ao mercado** → **Vou à feira**. There is no crase before a masculine noun (**ao**), before a verb (**a ler**), or before a place with no article: **Vou a Londres**, **Vou a Portugal**.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Vou ao banco.	I'm going to the bank.
Vou à praia.	I'm going to the beach.
Vou aos Estados Unidos.	I'm going to the United States.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Em frente à praça.	Across from the square.

In speech, Brazilians often use **em** instead of **a** with movement verbs: **Vou no banco**, **Vou na praia**. It is very common and not a mistake in conversation. In writing and formal contexts, choose **ao** and **à**. Another extremely common spoken form is **para** `PAH-rah` shortened to **pra** `prah` (and **para o → pro** `proo`): **Vou pra casa**, **Vou pro trabalho**, **Pra viagem?** (as in the padaria in Lesson 1). Write **para** in formal texts; use **pra** and **pro** in conversation and chats.

Some adverbs also fuse with **de**: **aqui → daqui** `dah-KEE`, **aí → daí** `dah-EE`, **ali → dali** `dah-LEE`, **lá → de lá**. You hear **Sou daqui** (I'm from here), **Saio dali**, **Moro perto daqui** (I live near here).

5.9 Tem or está? Introducing a thing, and locating a known thing

One more contrast makes your Portuguese sound natural, and it needs the vocabulary of a home. First the words.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
a sala	`ah SAH-lah`	the living room
o quarto	`oo KWAR-too`	the bedroom
a cozinha	`ah koh-ZEE-nyah`	the kitchen
o banheiro	`oo bah-NYAY-roo`	the bathroom
a varanda	`ah vah-RAH~-dah`	the balcony
a cama	`ah KAH-mah`	the bed
o sofá	`oo soh-FAH`	the sofa
a geladeira	`ah zheh-lah-DAY-rah`	the refrigerator
o chuveiro	`oo shoo-VAY-roo`	the shower

Now compare these two pairs.

INTRODUCE SOMETHING NEW WITH TEM	LOCATE SOMETHING KNOWN WITH ESTAR
Tem um sofá na sala. There is a sofa in the living room.	**O sofá está na sala.** The sofa is in the living room.
Tem uma geladeira na cozinha. There is a refrigerator in the kitchen.	**A geladeira está na cozinha.** The refrigerator is in the kitchen.
Tem um banheiro aqui? Is there a bathroom here?	**Onde está o banheiro?** Where is the bathroom?

The difference is **new** against **known**. With **tem** you present something the listener may not know about, and the noun usually has **um**, **uma** or no article at all: **Tem café?** With **estar** (or **ficar**) you say where a specific thing the listener already knows is, and the noun has **o** or **a**: **O café está na mesa**. English does the same with *there is a coffee on the table* against *the coffee is on the table*. So do not say **Tem o banheiro na sala**; say **O banheiro fica ao lado da sala** or ask **Onde fica o banheiro?**

A short exchange to practice, with the roles of Laura and Marcos:

> **Tem toalha no banheiro?** Is there a towel in the bathroom? **Tem, sim. A toalha está atrás da porta.** Yes, there is. The towel is behind the door.

(New word: **a toalha** ah toh-AH-lyah, the towel.) Notice how the second answer moves from **tem** to **está** the moment the towel becomes a known object.

5.10 Read a real text

Read the text aloud, first with the guide, then without it.

> Eu sou a Laura e estou no Rio de Janeiro. O apartamento é pequeno, mas é bonito e fica perto da praia. Tem uma cozinha, uma sala e um quarto. Hoje estou cansada, mas estou muito feliz. A cidade é linda e as pessoas são simpáticas.

Guide:

EH-oo SOH ah LOW-rah ee ehs-TOH noo HEE-oo djee zhah-NAY-roo. oo ah-par-tah-MEH~-too eh peh-KEH-noo, mahss eh boh-NEE-too ee FEE-kah PEHI

Translation: *I am Laura and I'm in Rio de Janeiro. The apartment is small, but it's pretty and it's near the beach. There is a kitchen, a living room and a bedroom. Today I'm tired, but I'm very happy. The city is beautiful and the people are friendly.*

Notice the choices: **sou** for her name, **estou** for her location and for tiredness, **é pequeno** for the apartment's size, **fica** for the building's position, **tem** for what exists, **são simpáticas** for the people's character.

5.11 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu sou cansada.~~	Estou cansada.	tiredness is a state of the moment: **estar**
~~Eu sou com fome.~~	Estou com fome. / Tenho fome.	hunger is not an identity; never **ser com**
~~Eu estou professora.~~	Sou professora.	a profession names who you are: **ser**
~~Eu estou de São Paulo.~~	Sou de São Paulo.	origin: **ser**
~~Têm muitos carros na rua.~~	Tem muitos carros na rua.	"there are" is **tem**, invariable
~~Há um banco aqui?~~ ~~(in speech)~~	Tem um banco aqui?	**há** is formal; **tem** is what Brazilians say
~~A festa está na casa da Ana.~~	A festa é na casa da Ana.	an event takes **ser**
~~Onde é o banco?~~	Onde fica o banco?	for a building, use **ficar** (or **estar**)
~~Eu tenho 20.~~	Eu tenho 20 anos.	do not forget **anos**
~~Tenho frio.~~ ~~(about the weather)~~	Está frio.	**tenho frio** is what you feel; the weather is **está frio**
~~Vou em a praia.~~	Vou à praia.	**a** + **a** = **à** (or **na** in speech)
~~O hotel está de o lado do banco.~~	O hotel fica ao lado do banco.	use **ao lado de** and fuse **de** + **o** = **do**

5.12 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: CHOOSE THE RIGHT FORM OF ESTAR

Write the correct form.

1. Eu ____ em casa.

2. Você ____ cansado?

3. Nós ____ no hotel.

4. Eles ____ aqui.

5. A gente ____ com fome.

6. Elas ____ ocupadas.

PRACTICE · PART B: SER OR ESTAR?

Complete with the correct form of **ser** or **estar**.

1. A aula ____ na sexta.

2. Onde ____ a Marina?

3. Eu ____ cansado hoje.

4. Ela ____ médica.

5. O café ____ frio.

6. Eles ____ de Portugal.

7. Meu pai ____ doente hoje.

8. Ele ____ muito simpático.

9. Nós ____ no centro.

10. A casa ____ branca.

PRACTICE · PART C: TER, ESTAR COM, AND "THERE IS"

Say each sentence in two ways, with **ter** and with **estar com**.

1. I'm hungry. (eu)

2. She is sleepy. (ela)

3. We are in a hurry. (nós)

4. They are cold. (eles)

Then translate with **tem**:

1. How old are you? (Use **ter**.)

2. There is a bank near here.

3. There are no taxis.

4. Is there coffee?

PRACTICE · PART D: CORRECT THE MISTAKE

Each sentence has one mistake. Correct it.

1. Eu sou cansado.

2. Eu sou com fome.

3. Ele está médico.

4. Têm muitos carros na rua.

5. A festa está na casa da Ana.

6. Eu estou de São Paulo.

7. Vou em a praia.

8. O hotel está de o lado do banco.

PRACTICE · PART E: SPEAK AND WRITE

1. Describe where five things are in your room, with **estar** or **ficar** and a place word.

2. Say how you feel right now and why.

3. Write three pairs of sentences with **ser** and **estar** for the same adjective, as in 5.7. For example, with **feliz**.

4. Ask a stranger where three places are: a bank, a pharmacy, a supermarket.

ANSWER KEY

1. **estou** (or **tô** in speech).
2. **está**.
3. **estamos**.
4. **estão**.
5. **está** (or **tá**): **a gente** takes the **ele** form.
6. **estão**.
7. **é**: an event (a class) takes **ser**.
8. **está**: where a person is now.
9. **estou**.
10. **é**: profession.
11. **está**: temperature at the moment.
12. **são**: origin.
13. **está**: sick today.
14. **é**: a quality of his character. (**Está muito simpático hoje** is also possible, with a change of meaning: he is being nice today.)
15. **estamos**: location.
16. **é**: a lasting quality. (**Está branca** would mean it was just painted white or looks white right now, which is a very particular context.)
17. **Eu tenho fome.** / **Eu estou com fome.**
18. **Ela tem sono.** / **Ela está com sono.**
19. **Nós temos pressa.** / **Nós estamos com pressa.**
20. **Eles têm frio.** / **Eles estão com frio.**
21. **Quantos anos você tem?**
22. **Tem um banco aqui perto.**
23. **Não tem táxi.**
24. **Tem café?**
25. **Eu estou cansado.**
26. **Eu estou com fome.** (or **Eu tenho fome.**)
27. **Ele é médico.**
28. **Tem muitos carros na rua.**
29. **A festa é na casa da Ana.**
30. **Eu sou de São Paulo.**
31. **Vou à praia.** (or **Vou na praia.** in speech)
32. **O hotel fica ao lado do banco.** (or **está ao lado do banco**)
33. A model answer: **O celular está em cima da mesa. A mala fica embaixo da cama. A janela fica atrás do sofá.** Check that each place word fuses correctly with its article.
34. A model answer: **Estou cansada porque trabalho muito, mas estou feliz.**
35. A model answer: **Ela é feliz. Ela está feliz hoje.** / **Ele é nervoso. Ele está nervoso agora.**
36. A model answer: **Com licença, onde fica o banco? Onde fica a farmácia? E o supermercado, fica longe?**

5.13 Return

These three questions bring back Lessons 1 to 4.

1. Conjugate **morar** for **eu**, **nós** and **eles**. Where does the stress fall in each form?
2. Correct the sentence **Quanto anos você tem?** and say why.
3. Make the plural of **a mão** and **o pão**, and say which one is nasal in the singular as well.

Check: (1) **moro** (`MAW-roo`), **moramos** (`moh-RAH-mooss`), **moram** (`MAW-rah~oo`); (2) **Quantos anos você tem?**, because **quanto** agrees with **anos**; (3) **as mãos**, **os pães**; both **mão** and **pão** are nasal.

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Day 1	Say the four forms of **estar** and the four forms of **ter**, aloud.
Day 3	Describe the place where you are right now using five different place words.
Day 7	Say ten sentences with **ser** or **estar** and say why you chose each.
Day 14	Write a short message to a host saying that you are tired, hungry, and where the bathroom is.

5.14 Pocket summary: Lesson 5

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Ser** names what something is (identity, origin, profession, lasting qualities, time, event location). **Estar** names how or where it is now (location, feeling, temporary state).
- **Estar:** **estou, está, estamos, estão**; spoken **tô, tá**. **Ter:** **tenho, tem, temos, têm**.
- **Location:** **estar** for people and objects, **ficar** for buildings and places, **ser** for events.
- **Sensations:** **estar com** or **ter**: **Estou com fome** = **Tenho fome**. Age: **ter**.
- **There is / there are:** **tem** (invariable) in speech, **há** in writing.
- **Place words** (**perto de, ao lado de, em frente a**) fuse with the article: **perto do banco**, **ao lado da praça**.
- **Contractions of a:** **ao, à, aos, às**. In speech: **vou no banco**; **pra**, **pro** for **para**, **para o**.
- **Adjectives with both verbs change meaning:** **ele é chato** (annoying person) / **ele está chato** (being annoying today).

5.15 What comes next

In Lesson 6 you learn numbers from zero to a thousand, how to tell the time, say the date, and read prices. You will see the surprise of **são duas horas** (plural) and **é uma hora** (singular), and the Brazilian way of asking **Quanto custa?**

LESSON 6

Numbers, time, dates and prices: the practical lesson

By the end of this lesson you can count from zero to a thousand and beyond, tell the time and say when something happens, give the date and the day of the week, and ask about and understand prices in reais.

6.1 A scene you will live

Daniel stands at the ticket window of the bus station in São Paulo. He wants to go to Curitiba today. The clerk looks up from her screen.

DIALOGUE

Daniel: Boa tarde. Tem ônibus para Curitiba hoje? **Atendente:** Tem, sim. Tem um às quatro e meia e outro às oito da noite. **Daniel:** Quanto custa a passagem? **Atendente:** Cento e vinte e cinco reais. **Daniel:** Posso pagar no cartão? **Atendente:** Pode, sim. Débito ou crédito? **Daniel:** Crédito. Que horas são agora? **Atendente:** São duas e quinze. **Daniel:** Então vou pegar o das quatro e meia. Obrigado!

Daniel: Good afternoon. Is there a bus to Curitiba today? / Clerk: Yes, there is. There's one at half past four and another at eight at night. / Daniel: How much is the ticket? / Clerk: One hundred and twenty-five reais. / Daniel: Can I pay by card? / Clerk: Yes, you can. Debit or credit? / Daniel: Credit. What time is it now? / Clerk: It's two fifteen. / Daniel: Then I'll take the four-thirty one. Thank you!

In a single minute, the scene uses a time of day, a price in reais, a number in the hundreds, and the clock. Notice two details that this lesson explains. The clerk says **às quatro e meia** (at half past four) and **às oito da noite** (at eight in the evening), with **às** for "at" in front of the hour. And she says **São duas e quinze** with the plural verb **são**, because the hour is plural. At one o'clock she would say **É uma hora**, with **é**.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
a passagem	ah pah-SAH-zheh~ee	the ticket (for transport)
o cartão	oo kar-TOW~	the card
o débito	oo DEH-bee-too	debit
o crédito	oo KREH-djee-too	credit
o atendente / a atendente	ah-teh~-DEH~-tchee	the clerk, the attendant
agora	ah-GAW-rah	now

6.2 The trap: plural hours, genders in numbers, and decimal commas

English numbers are simple: they never change, and the time is always "it is".
Portuguese has four small surprises.

1. **The time is plural, except at one o'clock.** São duas horas, São dez horas, but É uma hora, É meio-dia and É meia-noite. English says *it is* every time.
2. **Some numbers have gender.** Um / uma, dois / duas, and the hundreds from 200: duzentos / duzentas. You say duas casas and dois livros.
3. **"One thousand" is just mil.** Never um mil. And cem becomes cento when something follows: cem but cento e vinte.
4. **The punctuation is reversed.** Brazil writes the decimal with a comma and the thousands with a dot: R$ 12,50 is "twelve reais and fifty centavos", and R$ 1.250,00 is "one thousand two hundred fifty reais".

6.3 Numbers from zero to twenty

Learn these twenty-one numbers first. They are the base for everything else.

NUMBER	PORTUGUESE	GUIDE
0	zero	ZEH-roo
1	um / uma	oo~ / OO-mah
2	dois / duas	DOYSS / DOO-ahss
3	três	trehss
4	quatro	KWAH-troo
5	cinco	SEE~-koo
6	seis	SAYSS
7	sete	SEH-tchee
8	oito	OY-too
9	nove	NAW-vee
10	dez	dehss
11	onze	OH~-zee
12	doze	DOH-zee
13	treze	TREH-zee
14	catorze (also quatorze)	kah-TOR-zee
15	quinze	KEE~-zee
16	dezesseis	deh-zeh-SAYSS
17	dezessete	deh-zeh-SEH-tchee
18	dezoito	deh-ZOY-too
19	dezenove	deh-zeh-NAW-vee
20	vinte	VEE~-tchee

Only two numbers have a feminine form in this range: um → uma, and dois → duas. The other numbers never change.

MASCULINE	FEMININE
um café, dois cafés	uma cerveja, duas cervejas
vinte e um alunos	vinte e uma alunas

Phone numbers deserve a note. Brazilians say each digit on its own and use **meia** MAY-ah (a half dozen) for **6**, to avoid confusion over the phone. They say **zero** for 0: **(11) 98765-4321** is **onze, nove oito sete meia cinco, quatro três dois um**.

6.4 From twenty-one to ninety-nine

The tens are regular. To make a number between 21 and 99, say the ten, then **e** (and), then the unit.

NUMBER	PORTUGUESE	GUIDE
20	**vinte**	VEE~-tchee
30	**trinta**	TREE~-tah
40	**quarenta**	kwah-REH~-tah
50	**cinquenta**	see~-KWEH~-tah
60	**sessenta**	seh-SEH~-tah
70	**setenta**	seh-TEH~-tah
80	**oitenta**	oy-TEH~-tah
90	**noventa**	noh-VEH~-tah

So 21 is **vinte e um**, 35 is **trinta e cinco**, 48 is **quarenta e oito**, 99 is **noventa e nove**. For feminine nouns use the feminine forms: **vinte e uma pessoas**, **trinta e duas mulheres**.

> TIP
>
> Say the tens aloud in a row: *vinte, trinta, quarenta, cinquenta, sessenta, setenta, oitenta, noventa*. The pattern never changes: ten + **e** + unit. In speech, many people drop the **e** when they read a number quickly, but the full form is the correct one.

6.5 Hundreds, thousands and millions

The hundreds are the part where English speakers make mistakes, because there is a small change of form.

NUMBER	PORTUGUESE	GUIDE
100	**cem** (alone) / **cento** (when more follows)	SEH~ee / SEH~-too
200	**duzentos / duzentas**	doo-ZEH~-tooss
300	**trezentos / trezentas**	treh-ZEH~-tooss
400	**quatrocentos / quatrocentas**	kwah-troh-SEH~-tooss
500	**quinhentos / quinhentas**	kee-NYEH~-tooss
600	**seiscentos / seiscentas**	say-SEH~-tooss
700	**setecentos / setecentas**	seh-tchee-SEH~-tooss
800	**oitocentos / oitocentas**	oy-too-SEH~-tooss
900	**novecentos / novecentas**	naw-vee-SEH~-tooss
1,000	**mil**	MEE-oo

1 **Use "cem" and "cento" correctly**

Exactly 100 is **cem**: **cem reais**. Anything between 101 and 199 uses **cento**: **cento e um** (101), **cento e vinte e cinco** (125, as in the scene), **cento e noventa e nove** (199).

2 **Put "e" between the parts**

Connect the hundreds, tens and units with **e**: **trezentos e quarenta e dois** (342), **novecentos e noventa e nove** (999). This is different from English, which does not use “and” (or uses it only once).

3 **Make the hundreds agree**

From 200, the hundreds agree in gender with the noun they count: **duzentos livros** (masculine), **duzentas casas** (feminine), **quinhentas pessoas**. The same holds for the final **um/uma** and **dois/duas** of a long number: **cento e vinte e uma casas**, **trezentos e dois livros**.

Thousands and beyond

Mil never changes and never needs **um**: **mil reais** (1,000), **dois mil reais** (2,000), **vinte mil** (20,000), **cem mil** (100,000). A million is a noun: **um milhão** mee-LYOW~ , **dois milhões** mee-LYOH~eess , and it takes **de** before the noun: **um milhão de reais**, **dois milhões de pessoas**.

To join the parts of a large number, use **e** before the **last** element when it is a number below 100 or a round hundred: **mil e vinte** (1,020), **mil e duzentos** (1,200), **dois mil e quinhentos** (2,500). In other cases there is no **e** right after **mil**: **mil duzentos e trinta** (1,230).

Years are written and said as ordinary numbers: 2026 is **dois mil e vinte e seis**, 1999 is **mil novecentos e noventa e nove**. The preposition is **em**: **em dois mil e vinte e seis**.

6.6 Ordinal numbers

Ordinals say “first, second, third”. They are adjectives, so they agree.

NUMBER	MASCULINE	FEMININE	GUIDE (MASC.)
1st	primeiro	primeira	pree-MAY-roo
2nd	segundo	segunda	seh-GOO~-doo
3rd	terceiro	terceira	ter-SAY-roo
4th	quarto	quarta	KWAR-too
5th	quinto	quinta	KEE~-too
6th	sexto	sexta	SEHS-too
7th	sétimo	sétima	SEH-tchee-moo
8th	oitavo	oitava	oy-TAH-voo
9th	nono	nona	NOH-noo
10th	décimo	décima	DEH-see-moo

You will use them for floors, streets and dates: **o primeiro andar** (the first floor), **a segunda rua à direita** (the second street on the right), **a terceira porta** (the third door). In Brazil the ground floor is **o térreo** oo TEH-heh-oo , so

o primeiro andar is the floor **above** it. From eleven on, speakers normally use the ordinary number after the noun: **o andar onze**, **a página vinte**.

6.7 What time is it?

Ask and answer

The question is **Que horas são?** kee AW-rahss SOW~ , literally "what hours are?" It is plural, and so is the answer:

TIME	PORTUGUESE
1:00	**É uma hora.**
2:00	**São duas horas.**
3:00	**São três horas.**
12:00	**É meio-dia.** MAY-oo DJEE-ah
12:00 at night	**É meia-noite.** MAY-ah NOY-tchee

Rule: from 2:00 on, the verb is **são** and the hour is plural. At 1:00 (and at noon and midnight) the verb is **é**, singular. The same holds when minutes are added: **É uma e dez**, **São duas e dez**.

Minutes and halves

To add minutes after the hour, say **e**: **São três e dez** (3:10), **São três e vinte e cinco** (3:25). The half hour is **e meia** ee MAY-ah : **São três e meia** (3:30). The quarter hour is **e quinze** (spoken) or **e um quarto**: **São três e quinze**.

To say minutes **before** the hour, use **para** (or the spoken **pra**) with the next hour: **São quinze para as quatro** (3:45, literally "fifteen to four"), **São dez para as duas** (1:50), **É um quarto para a uma** (12:45). You can say it with **faltam**: **Faltam dez para as duas** FAH-oo-tah~oo (ten minutes are missing until two).

TIME	PORTUGUESE
8:00	**São oito horas.**
8:15	**São oito e quinze.**
8:30	**São oito e meia.**
8:45	**São quinze para as nove.**
8:50	**São dez para as nove.**

Add **da manhã** (a.m.), **da tarde** (afternoon) and **da noite** (evening, night) to be clear: **São oito horas da manhã**, **São três da tarde**, **São nove da noite**. Airlines and timetables use the 24-hour clock: **às catorze horas**.

When something happens

For "at" a time, use **à / às**: the fused form of **a** + the article that you saw in Lesson 5. It agrees with the hour: **à uma**, **às duas**, **às três**.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
A aula é às oito.	The class is at eight.
O ônibus sai à uma e meia.	The bus leaves at one-thirty.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Almoço ao meio-dia.	I have lunch at noon.
Durmo à meia-noite.	I sleep at midnight.
A que horas é a reunião?	At what time is the meeting?
Chego às seis em ponto.	I arrive at six sharp.

The question for "at what time" is **A que horas…?** `ah kee AW-rahss`, and the answer begins with **às** or **à**. A nice detail: *early* is **cedo** `SEH-doo`, *late* is **tarde**, *sharp* is **em ponto** `eh~ee POH~-too`, and *about* is **mais ou menos** (more or less).

6.8 Days, months and dates

The days of the week

DAY	GUIDE
segunda-feira	`seh-GOO~-dah FAY-rah`
terça-feira	`TER-sah FAY-rah`
quarta-feira	`KWAR-tah FAY-rah`
quinta-feira	`KEE~-tah FAY-rah`
sexta-feira	`SEHS-tah FAY-rah`
sábado	`SAH-bah-doo`
domingo	`doh-MEE~-goo`

In daily speech Brazilians drop **-feira**: **segunda**, **terça**, **quarta**, **quinta**, **sexta**. The days from Monday to Friday are feminine (**a segunda**), while **sábado** and **domingo** are masculine (**o sábado**). Days are not capitalized. To say "on a day", use **em** with the article: **na segunda**, **no sábado**; for "every Monday" use the plural: **às segundas**, **aos sábados**. Related words: **hoje** `OH-zhee` (today), **amanhã** `ah-mah-NYAH~` (tomorrow), **ontem** `OH~-teh~ee` (yesterday), **o fim de semana** (the weekend).

The months and seasons

MONTH	GUIDE	MONTH	GUIDE
janeiro	`zhah-NAY-roo`	julho	`ZHOO-lyoo`
fevereiro	`feh-veh-RAY-roo`	agosto	`ah-GOHS-too`
março	`MAR-soo`	setembro	`seh-TEH~-broo`
abril	`ah-BREE-oo`	outubro	`oh-TOO-broo`
maio	`MIE-oo`	novembro	`noh-VEH~-broo`
junho	`ZHOO-nyoo`	dezembro	`deh-ZEH~-broo`

The months are not capitalized either. Use **em** with a month: **em maio**, **em dezembro**. The seasons: **o verão** `oo veh-ROW~` (summer), **o outono** `oo oh-TOH-noo` (autumn), **o inverno** `oo ee~-VEHR-noo` (winter), **a primavera** `ah pree-mah-VEH-rah` (spring). In Brazil, which is in the Southern Hemisphere, summer runs from December to March, and the New Year is celebrated in the heat. Say **no verão**, **no inverno**, **na primavera**.

Saying the date

QUESTION	ANSWER
Que dia é hoje?	Hoje é dia treze de outubro. or Hoje é treze.
Qual é a data de hoje?	É treze de outubro de dois mil e vinte e seis.
Quando é o aniversário da Ana?	É dia cinco de março.

The pattern is **cardinal number + de + month**: vinte e cinco de dezembro. The only exception is the first of the month, which uses the ordinal: primeiro de maio (not "um de maio"). In writing, Brazilians put the day first: **13/10/2026** is 13 October 2026, so 01/05 is the first of May, not January 5. The word for "birthday" is o aniversário `oo ah-nee-ver-SAH-ree-oo`.

6.9 Prices and money

The Brazilian currency is the real `heh-AH-oo` (plural reais `heh-IESS`), written R$. A hundredth is a centavo `seh~-TAH-voo`. Notice that Brazilians write the decimal comma: R$ 12,50.

WRITTEN	SAID
R$ 1,00	um real
R$ 5,00	cinco reais
R$ 12,50	doze reais e cinquenta centavos (in a shop: doze e cinquenta)
R$ 125,00	cento e vinte e cinco reais
R$ 1.200,00	mil e duzentos reais
R$ 0,75	setenta e cinco centavos

Asking the price and paying

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
Quanto custa?	KWAH~-too KOOS-tah	How much does it cost?
Quanto é?	KWAH~-too eh	How much is it?
Quanto fica?	KWAH~-too FEE-kah	How much does it come to?
Quanto custam?	KWAH~-too KOOS-tah~oo	How much are they?
É caro. / É barato.		It's expensive. / It's cheap.
Aceita cartão?	ah-SAY-tah kar-TOW~	Do you accept cards?
Posso pagar no cartão?		Can I pay by card?
em dinheiro	eh~ee djee-NYAY-roo	in cash
no Pix	noo PEEKS	by Pix (the instant bank transfer used throughout Brazil)
Tem troco?	TEH~ee TROH-koo	Do you have change?
A conta, por favor.	ah KOH~-tah, poor fah-VOR	The check, please.

Two verb notes. Custa is singular because it agrees with one thing, custam for several: Quanto custa o café?, Quanto custam os pães? And posso comes from poder, which you meet in Lesson 7: treat Posso pagar...? as a block for now.

WATCH OUT

Prices of food and drink are often given with a unit: **o quilo** oo KEE-loo (kilogram, as in **vinte reais o quilo**), **a dúzia** ah DOO-zee-ah (dozen), **o litro** oo LEE-troo, **a unidade**. Half a kilo is **meio quilo**. Note that "half" is **meio** before a masculine noun and **meia** before a feminine one: **meio quilo**, **meia dúzia**.

6.10 Numbers in real situations: quantities, amounts and bargains

Numbers rarely travel alone. In a shop or on the street you hear them with measures, and with a few small words that are worth learning now.

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
cada	KAH-dah	each, every
por	poor	per, for
o quilo	oo KEE-loo	the kilo
meio quilo	MAY-oo KEE-loo	half a kilo
a dúzia	ah DOO-zee-ah	the dozen
o litro	oo LEE-troo	the liter
o desconto	oo djees-KOH~-too	the discount
o total	oo toh-TAH-oo	the total

Here is a short exchange at a fruit stand. Read it aloud and replace the numbers with your own.

> **Quanto custa o quilo da manga?** How much is a kilo of mango? **Seis reais o quilo. Três quilos por quinze.** Six reais a kilo. Three kilos for fifteen. **Então quero três quilos. E uma dúzia de laranjas.** Then I'll take three kilos. And a dozen oranges. **Dá vinte e dois reais no total.** That makes twenty-two reais in total.

Three small patterns to notice. First, prices with a unit use the article, never "per": **seis reais o quilo**. Second, the preposition **por** carries the meaning of "for" in offers: **três por dez reais**. Third, you hear **dá** (from **dar**) in the sense of "it comes to": **Dá trinta reais**. It has the same use as **fica** in Lesson 3.

Round numbers and estimates. When you do not know the exact number, Brazilians say **uns** or **cerca de** before it: **uns vinte minutos** (about twenty minutes), **cerca de cem pessoas** (around a hundred people). And when you want to say "a few", use **alguns** or **poucos** in front of the noun. These give your numbers a natural sound.

Fractions and percentages. **Metade** meh-TAH-djee is the word for "half" as a noun: **a metade do preço**. A percentage reads as a number plus **por cento** poor SEH~-too: **dez por cento** (10%), **cinquenta por cento** (50%). In a shop you will see **desconto de vinte por cento**.

6.11 Read a real text

Read the text aloud, first with the guide, then without it.

> O café da Rua das Flores abre às sete da manhã e fecha às nove da noite, de segunda a sábado. No domingo, abre ao meio-dia. Um café custa quatro reais e cinquenta centavos. Um pão de queijo custa seis reais.

Guide:

oo kah-FEH dah HOO-ah dahss FLOH-reess AH-bree ahss SEH-tchee dah mah-NYAH~ ee FEH-shah ahss NAW-vee dah NOY-tchee, djee seh-GOO~-dah a

Translation: *The café on Flowers Street opens at seven in the morning and closes at nine at night, from Monday to Saturday. On Sunday, it opens at noon. A coffee costs four reais fifty. A cheese bread costs six reais.*

Check the details: **às sete** and **às nove** (plural hours), **ao meio-dia** (the fusion of **a** + **o**), **de segunda a sábado** (from Monday to Saturday), and the price said in full words. The verbs **abre**, **fecha** and **custa** are third-person singular forms you already know from Lesson 4.

6.12 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~É duas horas.~~	São duas horas.	from two o'clock on, the hour is plural: **são**
~~São uma hora.~~	É uma hora.	one o'clock is singular: **é**
~~Qual é a hora?~~	Que horas são?	the usual question is **Que horas são?**
~~Um mil reais~~	Mil reais	**mil** never takes **um**
~~Cem e vinte~~	Cento e vinte	**cem** only at exactly 100
~~Duzentos casas~~	Duzentas casas	the hundreds agree with the noun
~~Dois pessoas~~	Duas pessoas	**dois** → **duas** before a feminine noun
~~Vinte-um~~	Vinte e um	tens and units are joined by **e**
~~Um de maio~~	Primeiro de maio	the first of the month takes the ordinal
~~Hoje é o treze de outubro.~~	Hoje é dia treze de outubro.	the pattern is **dia** + number
~~Em segunda~~	Na segunda	days take **em** + article: **na**
~~A aula é as oito.~~	A aula é às oito.	"at" + hour = **às**, with the grave accent
~~R$ 12.50~~	R$ 12,50	Brazil uses the decimal comma
~~Três e quinze horas~~	São três e quinze.	in speech: no **horas** after the minutes

6.13 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: WRITE THE NUMBER IN WORDS

1. 15

2. 21

3. 39

4. 56

5. 72

6. 100

7. 101

8. 245

9. 1.000

10. 2.026

PRACTICE · PART B: MAKE THE NUMBER AGREE

Complete with the correct form.

1. ____ casas (2)

2. ____ livros (2)

3. ____ casas (200)

4. ____ livros (200)

5. Vinte e ____ pessoas (21)

6. Trinta e ____ carros (31)

PRACTICE · PART C: TELL THE TIME

Write the time in words, as an answer to **Que horas são?**

1. 1:00

2. 2:15

3. 3:30

4. 4:45

5. 12:00 (noon)

6. 12:30 (noon)

7. 6:10

8. 8:50

Then say when it happens, with **à**, **às** or **ao**.

1. **A aula é** ____ (8:00)

2. **A reunião é** ____ (1:30)

3. **O voo sai** ____ (12:00 noon)

PRACTICE · PART D: PRICES AND DATES

Write the price in words.

1. R$ 5,00

2. R$ 12,50

3. R$ 1.200

4. R$ 350

5. R$ 1,00

Write the date in words.

1. 01/05

2. 15/09

3. 25/12

PRACTICE · PART E: SPEAK AND WRITE

1. Say your phone number aloud, digit by digit, and read it again with **meia** for 6.

2. Say today's date and the day of the week.

3. Say the times of five things in your day, using **às**, for example **Acordo às sete**. (You may use **acordo** as a block.)

4. Ask the price of three items you would like to buy, with **Quanto custa?** or **Quanto custam?**

5. You are in a café in Rio. Order two coffees and ask the price, using numbers and **por favor**.

ANSWER KEY

1. **quinze**.
2. **vinte e um**.
3. **trinta e nove**.
4. **cinquenta e seis**.
5. **setenta e dois**.
6. **cem**.
7. **cento e um**.
8. **duzentos e quarenta e cinco**.
9. **mil**.
10. **dois mil e vinte e seis**.
11. **duas** casas.
12. **dois** livros.
13. **duzentas** casas.
14. **duzentos** livros.
15. **uma**: **pessoas** is feminine.
16. **um**: **carros** is masculine.
17. **É uma hora.**
18. **São duas e quinze.**
19. **São três e meia.**
20. **São quinze para as cinco.** (or **São quatro e quarenta e cinco.**)
21. **É meio-dia.**
22. **É meio-dia e meia.**
23. **São seis e dez.**
24. **São dez para as nove.**
25. **às oito**.
26. **à uma e meia**: **à** agrees with **uma**.
27. **ao meio-dia**.
28. **cinco reais**.
29. **doze reais e cinquenta centavos**.
30. **mil e duzentos reais**.
31. **trezentos e cinquenta reais**.
32. **um real**.
33. **primeiro de maio**.
34. **quinze de setembro**.
35. **vinte e cinco de dezembro**.
36. Check that you say each digit, and use **meia** for 6.
37. A model answer: **Hoje é dia treze de outubro. É terça-feira.** Use the real date. In Brazil the day comes first.
38. A model answer: **Acordo às sete. Almoço ao meio-dia. Saio do trabalho às seis. Janto às oito. Durmo à meia-noite.** Check **à** and **às**.
39. A model answer: **Quanto custa o café? Quanto custam as laranjas? Quanto custa a passagem?**
40. A model answer: **Boa tarde. Dois cafés, por favor. Quanto é?**

6.14 Return

These three questions bring back Lessons 1 to 5.

1. Which verb do you use to say where a party is, and which to say where a bank is? Give one sentence of each.
2. Say **there are two restaurants on the street** in Portuguese. Which verb?
3. Where does the stress fall in **vinte** and **trezentos**? Why?

Check: (1) **A festa é na casa da Ana** (**ser** for the event) and **O banco fica na esquina** (**ficar** or **estar**); (2) **Tem dois restaurantes na rua**; (3) **VIN-te** (ends in **-e**, second-to-last), **tre-ZEN-tos** (ends in **-os**, second-to-last).

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Day 1	Count from zero to twenty aloud, then back.
Day 3	Say the time of five clocks you see during the day.
Day 7	Say ten prices from a supermarket flyer or a shop window.
Day 14	Say the date of five important days in your year.

6.15 Pocket summary: Lesson 6

POCKET SUMMARY

- **0–20:** **zero, um/uma, dois/duas, três, quatro, cinco, seis, sete, oito, nove, dez, onze, doze, treze, catorze, quinze, dezesseis, dezessete, dezoito, dezenove, vinte**.
- **Tens:** **vinte, trinta, quarenta, cinquenta, sessenta, setenta, oitenta, noventa**; join with **e**: **trinta e cinco**.
- **Hundreds:** **cem** (exactly 100), **cento e…**; **duzentos/-as** up to **novecentos/-as**; they agree with the noun. **Mil**, never **um mil**; **um milhão de**.
- **Time:** **É uma hora** / **São duas horas**; **e meia**, **e quinze**, **quinze para as…**; **meio-dia**, **meia-noite**. At a time: **à uma**, **às duas**, **ao meio-dia**.
- **Dates:** **Hoje é dia treze de outubro**; first of the month is **primeiro**; day first in writing (13/10).
- **Days and months:** lowercase; **na segunda**, **em maio**; weekdays Monday to Friday are feminine.
- **Prices:** **Quanto custa? Quanto é?** R$ 12,50 = **doze reais e cinquenta centavos**; decimal comma, thousands dot.
- **Phone numbers:** digit by digit; **meia** for 6.

6.16 What comes next

In Lesson 7 you meet the most useful irregular verbs: **ir**, **fazer**, **poder**, **querer**, **saber**, **vir**, **dizer** and a few friends. With them you can ask permission, make requests, say what you want and what you know, and finally tell **saber** from **conhecer**.

LESSON 7

Irregular essentials and modals: go, do, can, want, know

By the end of this lesson you can conjugate the ten most useful irregular verbs in the present tense, ask permission and make requests with **poder**, say what you want and what you have to do, and tell **saber** from **conhecer**.

7.1 A scene you will live

Sam, who works in São Paulo for a few months, is planning Saturday with two colleagues in a bar after work.

DIALOGUE

Bruno: E aí, Sam? O que você quer fazer no sábado? **Sam:** Quero conhecer o centro. Vocês podem ir comigo? **Ana:** Eu posso, mas só de tarde. De manhã tenho que trabalhar. **Bruno:** Eu vou também. Você sabe pegar o metrô? **Sam:** Sei, sim. Mas não sei onde fica a estação. **Bruno:** Sem problema. Eu vou com você. **Ana:** Combinado! Às duas na estação.

Bruno: So, Sam? What do you want to do on Saturday? / Sam: I want to see downtown. Can you come with me? / Ana: I can, but only in the afternoon. In the morning I have to work. / Bruno: I'm going too. Do you know how to take the subway? / Sam: Yes, I do. But I don't know where the station is. / Bruno: No problem. I'll go with you. / Ana: Agreed! At two at the station.

Count the irregular verbs: **quer**, **podem**, **posso**, **tenho**, **vou**, **sabe**, **sei**. They look nothing like the regular patterns of Lesson 4, and they are the verbs of daily life: wanting, being able, going, knowing. Notice a second thing: after **querer**, **poder** and **saber**, the next verb stays in the infinitive, with no "to" and no preposition: **quero conhecer**, **podem ir**, **sabe pegar**. That one pattern covers almost everything in this lesson.

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
E aí?	ee ah-EE	So? What's up? (a casual greeting)
conhecer	koh-nyeh-SEHR	to get to know, to visit a place for the first time
comigo	koh-MEE-goo	with me
só	saw	only, just
o metrô	oo meh-TROH	the subway
a estação	ah ehs-tah-SOW~	the station

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING
sem problema	seh~ee proh-BLEH-mah	no problem
combinado	koh~-bee-NAH-doo	agreed, deal

7.2 The trap: irregular, but in a pattern

Four habits cause trouble here.

1. **Irregular verbs change inside.** English *go / went* is irregular too, but Portuguese irregularity is concentrated in the **eu** form: **faço**, **digo**, **trago**, **sei**. The other forms are mostly regular.
2. **"Can" is a full verb.** English *can* has no endings. Portuguese **poder** changes with the person: **posso**, **pode**, **podemos**, **podem**.
3. **The next verb stays in the infinitive.** Not "I want to go" with a particle: **Quero ir**. Not "I can to go": **Posso ir**.
4. **One "to know" in English, two in Portuguese.** **Saber** is for facts and skills; **conhecer** is for people and places.

7.3 Ir: to go

Ir is the most irregular verb after **ser**. It does not resemble its infinitive at all.

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE
eu	**vou**	VOH
você / ele / ela / a gente	**vai**	vie
nós	**vamos**	VAH-mooss
vocês / eles / elas	**vão**	VOW~

Ir takes a place with a preposition: **ir a** (formal, with the fusions **ao**, **à**), **ir para** (spoken **pra**, **pro**), and in speech simply **ir em**. All of these are correct in different registers: **Vou ao banco**, **Vou para casa**, **Vou pro trabalho**, **Vou no banco**.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Vou para casa.	I'm going home.
Vou de ônibus.	I'm going by bus.
Vou a pé.	I'm walking (literally: I go on foot).
Vamos?	Shall we go? / Let's go?
Vamos comer!	Let's eat!
Já vou!	I'm coming! (literally: I'm already going)
Vou embora.	I'm leaving.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **English "I'm coming" is Já vou, not Já venho.** In Portuguese you use **ir** when you move toward **the person you are talking to** or toward a place the listener will be: **Já vou!**, **Eu vou aí**. You use **vir** when the movement is toward **the speaker**: **Vem cá!** (Come here!). English says "I'm coming" in both situations. Portuguese chooses by the speaker's position.

With transport, use **de** for vehicles and **a pé** for walking: **de ônibus**, **de metrô**, **de carro**, **de táxi**, **de bicicleta**, **a pé**. English says "by bus"; Portuguese says "of bus".

A bonus: **ir** plus an infinitive builds the near future, "I am going to…". **Vou estudar**, **Vamos comer**. You will study it in Lesson 9, but you can already use it as a block.

7.4 Fazer: to do, to make

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE
eu	**faço**	FAH-soo
você / ele / ela / a gente	**faz**	fahss
nós	**fazemos**	fah-ZEH-mooss
vocês / eles / elas	**fazem**	FAH-zeh~ee

Fazer covers "do" and "make", and it has uses that English "do" does not.

USE	EXAMPLE	MEANING
doing	**O que você faz?**	What do you do?
making	**Faço o jantar.**	I make dinner.
activity	**Faço exercício de manhã.**	I exercise in the morning.
shopping	**Faço compras no sábado.**	I go shopping on Saturday.
weather	**Faz calor. / Faz frio. / Faz sol.**	It's hot. / It's cold. / It's sunny.
time passed	**Faz dois anos que moro aqui.**	I've lived here for two years.
question	**Faço uma pergunta?**	May I ask a question?

Two of these deserve attention. First, **weather** uses **fazer** in the third person: **Faz frio hoje**. You can also say **Está frio** to describe the weather right now (Lesson 5). Second, **Faz + time + que + present** is the natural way to say "for + period" in Brazilian speech: **Faz três meses que estudo português**. You can also say **Estudo português há três meses**.

7.5 Vir: to come

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE
eu	**venho**	VEH-nyoo
você / ele / ela / a gente	**vem**	VEH~ee
nós	**vimos**	VEE-mooss
vocês / eles / elas	**vêm**	VEH~ee

Like **tem** and **têm**, the singular **vem** and the plural **vêm** are only different in writing. The infinitive is **vir** veer . A few examples: **Venho de ônibus**, **Ele vem amanhã**, **Elas vêm de Recife**, **De onde você vem?**, **Vem comigo!**. Notice that **vimos** also means "we saw" (from **ver**) in the past; context tells you which one.

7.6 More verbs with an irregular *eu* form

A large group of verbs behave like **ter**, **fazer** and **vir**: the **eu** form is irregular, and the rest follow the usual endings (with a small change in the stem).

	DIZER (TO SAY)	TRAZER (TO BRING)	LER (TO READ)	SAIR (TO LEAVE, GO OUT)	PÔR (TO PUT)	CONHECER (TO KNOW A PERSON OR PLACE)
eu	digo DJEE-goo	trago TRAH-goo	leio LAY-oo	saio SIE-oo	ponho POH-nyoo	conheço koh-NYEH-soo
você / ele / ela	diz djeess	traz trahss	lê leh	sai sie	põe POH~ee	conhece koh-NYEH-see
nós	dizemos djee-ZEH-mooss	trazemos trah-ZEH-mooss	lemos LEH-mooss	saímos sah-EE-mooss	pomos POH-mooss	conhecemos koh-nyeh-SEH-mooss
vocês / eles / elas	dizem DJEE-zeh~ee	trazem TRAH-zeh~ee	leem LEH-eh~ee	saem SAH-eh~ee	põem POH~-eh~ee	conhecem koh-NYEH-seh~ee

A few more **eu** forms to learn as you meet them: **peço** (from **pedir**, to ask for), **ouço** (from **ouvir**, to hear), **durmo** (from **dormir**, to sleep), **sirvo** (from **servir**, to serve), **caibo** (from **caber**, to fit). Three that you have seen: **tenho** (from **ter**), **vejo** (from **ver**), **dou** (from **dar**).

Look at the pattern in the **eu** forms: they end in **-go** (**digo**, **trago**), **-ço** (**conheço**, **peço**), **-ho** (**venho**, **tenho**, **ponho**), **-io** (**leio**, **saio**), or have a vowel change (**sei**, **vou**, **dou**, **estou**). When you meet a new verb, learn the **eu** form with the infinitive.

> TIP
>
> A spelling reform note. The third-person plural of **ler**, **ver** and **crer** is **leem**, **veem**, **creem**, with no circumflex since 2009. Among these marks that distinguish words, the circumflex survives only in the pairs **tem / têm** and **vem / vêm** (and their compounds, like **contém / contêm**), in **pôr**, to separate it from the preposition **por**, and in **pôde** (past: *could*), to separate it from **pode**.

7.7 The modal verbs: poder, querer, saber, dever, precisar

A **modal verb** is a verb that changes the meaning of another verb: *can, want, know how to, must, need*. In Portuguese the modal is conjugated, and the second verb stays in the infinitive.

PERSON	PODER (CAN)	QUERER (WANT)	SABER (KNOW)	DEVER (MUST, SHOULD)
eu	posso PAW-soo	quero KEH-roo	sei say	devo DEH-voo
você / ele / ela / a gente	pode PAW-djee	quer kehr	sabe SAH-bee	deve DEH-vee
nós	podemos poh-DEH-mooss	queremos keh-REH-mooss	sabemos sah-BEH-mooss	devemos deh-VEH-mooss
vocês / eles / elas	podem PAW-deh~ee	querem KEH-reh~ee	sabem SAH-beh~ee	devem DEH-veh~ee

Poder: can, may

Poder poh-DEHR covers ability, possibility, permission and request.

USE	EXAMPLE	MEANING
ability	**Posso trabalhar até tarde.**	I can work late.
permission	**Posso entrar?**	May I come in?
request	**Você pode repetir?**	Can you repeat?
request	**Pode falar mais devagar?**	Can you speak more slowly?
prohibition	**Aqui não pode fumar.**	Smoking isn't allowed here.
possibility	**Pode ser.**	Maybe. / Could be.

USE	EXAMPLE	MEANING
agreement	**Pode ser às duas?**	Is two o'clock OK?

Devagar `deh-vah-GAR` means slowly. A very useful structure for learners is **Pode + infinitive?**: **Pode repetir?**, **Pode ajudar?**, **Pode falar mais devagar?** It is polite and short. For asking about possibility, Brazilians also say **Dá para...?** or **Dá pra...?** (literally "does it give for?"): **Dá pra pagar no cartão?**, **Dá para ir a pé?** It means "Is it possible to…?" and is extremely common in speech.

Querer: want

Querer `keh-REHR` says what you want. It can be followed by a noun or by an infinitive.

USE	EXAMPLE	MEANING
noun	**Quero um café.**	I want a coffee.
infinitive	**Quero conhecer o centro.**	I want to see downtown.
offer	**Quer um café?**	Would you like a coffee?
invitation	**Quer ir comigo?**	Do you want to come with me?
negative	**Não quero.**	I don't want to.

Quero is direct, and in many service situations a Brazilian prefers the softer **queria** (Lesson 13). For now, add **por favor** and a smile: **Quero um café, por favor.** As an offer, **Quer...?** is very warm and natural: **Quer ajuda?** (Want some help?), **Quer água?**

Saber: know a fact, know how to

Saber `sah-BEHR` is for knowledge: facts, information, and skills. The **eu** form **sei** `say` is irregular and very frequent.

USE	EXAMPLE	MEANING
fact	**Sei o seu nome.**	I know your name.
information	**Não sei onde fica a estação.**	I don't know where the station is.
skill (+ infinitive)	**Você sabe nadar?**	Can you swim?
skill	**Ela sabe falar quatro línguas.**	She can speak four languages.
reply	**Sei, sim. / Não sei.**	Yes, I do. / I don't know.
informal	**Sei lá!**	Who knows! / I have no idea!

When **saber** is followed by an infinitive, it means "know how to": **Sabe cozinhar?** It is not the same as **poder**: **Posso nadar** means "I am allowed to / I am able to swim here and now", **Sei nadar** means "I have the skill of swimming".

Dever, precisar and ter que: must, need, have to

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Preciso ir.	I need to go.
Preciso de ajuda.	I need help.
Tenho que trabalhar.	I have to work.
Você deve descansar.	You should rest.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
Ele deve chegar às oito.	He is supposed to arrive at eight. / He should arrive at eight.
Deve ser difícil.	It must be difficult.

For obligation, Brazilians prefer **precisar** `preh-see-ZAR` and **ter que** (also **ter de** in writing). **Dever** `deh-VEHR` is used for advice, for expectations ("he is supposed to") and for guesses ("it must be"). Be careful with the preposition: **preciso de + noun** (**Preciso de um táxi**), but **preciso + infinitive** with no **de**: **Preciso pegar um táxi**. And **ter que** has a fixed **que**: **Tenho que ir**.

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Quero ir em a praia.~~	Quero ir à praia.	a + a always fuse into à (or na in speech)
~~Eu posso falo.~~	Eu posso falar.	after a modal verb the next verb stays in the infinitive
~~Eu quero para ir.~~	Eu quero ir.	no para between querer and an infinitive
~~Preciso ir ao banheiro de.~~	Preciso ir ao banheiro.	de belongs only before a noun: preciso de um banheiro

7.8 Saber × conhecer

English uses *to know* for both. Portuguese separates them.

	SABER	CONHECER
Idea	knowledge: facts, information, skills	familiarity: people, places, things
Object	a clause or an infinitive	a person, a place, a thing
Example	Sei onde ele mora.	Conheço o João.
Example	Sei falar português.	Conheço o Brasil.
Question	Você sabe a resposta?	Você conhece este restaurante?
Negative	Não sei.	Não conheço.

1 **Ask yourself what the object is**

Is it a **person, a place or a thing you have experienced**? Use **conhecer**: **Conheço Salvador**, **Conheço a Ana**. Is it **information, a fact, or a skill**? Use **saber**: **Sei o nome dela**, **Sei dançar**, **Sei que ela mora aqui**.

2 **Check what "meeting" means**

Conhecer also means "to meet for the first time", "to get acquainted": **Prazer em conhecer você** (Nice to meet you), **Quero conhecer o Brasil** (I want to visit Brazil). It is not just "to know"; it is "to come to know".

3 **Do not use saber with people or places**

Sei o João sounds like "I know a fact about João". **Conheço o João** is "I know João". The same for places: **Conheço o Rio** means you have been there.

7.9 Asking, offering, inviting: the language of daily life

With **poder**, **querer** and **ir** you already have the three most useful tools for social life. Here are the formulas.

YOU WANT TO...	SAY...	MEANING
ask for permission	Posso sentar aqui?	May I sit here?

YOU WANT TO...	SAY...	MEANING
ask for help	**Pode me ajudar?**	Can you help me?
ask for a repetition	**Pode repetir, por favor?**	Can you repeat, please?
ask for slowness	**Pode falar mais devagar?**	Could you speak more slowly?
offer	**Quer ajuda?**	Do you want help?
invite	**Vamos tomar um café?**	Shall we have a coffee?
suggest	**Vamos?**	Shall we go?
accept	**Vamos, sim!**	Yes, let's!
refuse politely	**Hoje não posso.**	I can't today.
ask if it is possible	**Dá para pagar no cartão?**	Is it possible to pay by card?

A short note about **me** in **Pode me ajudar?**: it means "me", and it goes before the verb in Brazilian speech. Lesson 12 explains why. For now, learn **Pode me ajudar?** as a block.

For invitations, the phrase **Vamos + infinitive** is the simplest way to say "Let's…": **Vamos comer**, **Vamos ver**, **Vamos tomar um café**. It has no pronoun and it works with everyone.

7.10 One event, five attitudes

The verbs of this lesson let you talk about the same event from different angles. This is the most useful exercise to make them automatic. Take one event, **viajar em julho** (to travel in July), and look at the sentences.

ATTITUDE	SENTENCE	MEANING
wish	**Quero viajar em julho.**	I want to travel in July.
plan	**Vou viajar em julho.**	I'm going to travel in July.
ability, permission	**Posso viajar em julho.**	I can (I'm free to) travel in July.
need	**Preciso viajar em julho.**	I need to travel in July.
obligation	**Tenho que viajar em julho.**	I have to travel in July.
expectation	**Devo viajar em julho.**	I should / I'm expected to travel in July.

In each sentence the second verb is the same infinitive, **viajar**. Only the first verb changes. This is why one pattern, "conjugated verb + infinitive", serves for a huge part of Portuguese conversation. You can negate it by putting **não** before the first verb: **Não posso viajar em julho**, **Não quero viajar em julho**.

Now watch the pattern in a short real exchange between two friends planning a weekend. Read it aloud, and notice that the verb after the modal never changes.

> **O que você quer fazer no fim de semana?** What do you want to do on the weekend? **Não sei ainda. Posso ir à praia, mas tenho que estudar no domingo.** I don't know yet. I can go to the beach, but I have to study on Sunday. **Podemos ir sábado. Eu faço um lanche e a gente leva.** We can go on Saturday. I'll make a snack and we'll take it. **Boa ideia! A que horas você quer sair?** Good idea! What time do you want to leave? **Vamos sair às nove.** Let's leave at nine.

New words: **ainda** ah-EE~-dah (yet, still), **a praia** ah PRIE-ah (the beach), **o lanche** oo LAH~-shee (the snack), **a ideia** ah ee-DAY-ah (the idea), **levar** leh-VAR (to take, to carry along). Notice **a gente leva**: **a gente** with the **ele** form, as you learned in Lesson 2.

7.11 Read a real text

Read the text aloud, first with the guide, then without it.

> Eu sei falar um pouco de português e quero aprender mais. Todo dia faço exercícios e vejo vídeos. Hoje não posso sair, porque tenho que trabalhar. Mas amanhã vou conhecer o centro.

Guide:

EH-oo say fah-LAR oo~ POH-koo djee por-too-GEHSS ee KEH-roo ah-preh~-DEHR mies. TOH-doo DJEE-ah FAH-soo eh-zer-SEE-see-ooss ee VEH-zhoo V

Translation: *I can speak a little Portuguese and I want to learn more. Every day I do exercises and watch videos. Today I can't go out, because I have to work. But tomorrow I'm going to see downtown.*

Check the verbs: **sei** (skill), **quero** (want, with an infinitive), **faço**, **vejo** (irregular **eu** forms), **posso** (can), **tenho que** (have to), **vou conhecer** (will see for the first time). Now say the same text about another person (**ele**): **Ele sabe falar…, quer aprender…, faz…, vê…**.

7.12 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu fazo~~	Eu faço	the **eu** form of **fazer** is irregular
~~Eu sabo~~	Eu sei	**saber** has **sei** in the first person
~~Eu vo~~	Eu vou	write and say **vou**
~~Eu quero para ir~~	Eu quero ir	no preposition between **querer** and the infinitive
~~Eu posso falo~~	Eu posso falar	the second verb stays in the infinitive
~~Eu sei o João.~~	Eu conheço o João.	people take **conhecer**
~~Eu conheço nadar.~~	Eu sei nadar.	skills take **saber**
~~Já venho!~~ ~~(meaning "I'm coming!")~~	Já vou!	going toward the listener is **ir**
~~Você pode ajudar eu?~~	Você pode me ajudar?	in speech the object pronoun goes before the verb (Lesson 12)
~~Eu preciso ir para banheiro.~~	Eu preciso ir ao banheiro.	**ir a** with the article: **ao**
~~Eu tenho que de trabalhar.~~	Eu tenho que trabalhar.	**ter que** has no **de**
~~Eles são dizem a verdade.~~	Eles dizem a verdade.	do not put **ser** before an ordinary verb

7.13 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: CONJUGATE

Write the correct present-tense form.

1. Eu (ir) ____ ao banco.

2. Ela (fazer) ____ o jantar.

3. Nós (vir) ____ de ônibus.

4. Eles (poder) ____ ir.

5. Eu (querer) ____ um café.

6. Você (saber) ____ nadar?

7. Eu (dizer) ____ a verdade.

8. Nós (trazer) ____ o vinho.

9. Eles (ler) ____ muito.

10. Eu (sair) ____ às oito.

11. Eu (pôr) ____ açúcar no café.

12. Nós (ir) ____ ao cinema.

PRACTICE · PART B: SABER OR CONHECER?

Complete with the correct form.

1. Eu ____ o Rio muito bem.

2. Você ____ falar francês?

3. Eu não ____ a resposta.

4. Você ____ o João?

5. Eles ____ onde fica o hotel.

6. Nós ____ esse restaurante.

7. Ela ____ nadar muito bem.

8. Eu não ____ essa cidade.

PRACTICE · PART C: WHICH MODAL?

Complete with poder, querer, ter que, precisar or dever, in the right form.

1. ____ entrar? (May I come in?)

2. Hoje eu ____ trabalhar até tarde. (I have to)

3. Você ____ me ajudar? (Can you)

4. Eu ____ ir ao banheiro. (I need to)

5. ____ um café? (Would you like a coffee?)

6. Aqui não ____ fumar. (It isn't allowed)

7. Nós ____ ir embora cedo. (We want to)

8. Ele ____ chegar às oito. (He's supposed to)

PRACTICE · PART D: CORRECT THE MISTAKE

Each sentence has one mistake. Correct it.

1. Eu quero para ir ao cinema.

2. Eu sei o João.

3. Eu conheço nadar.

4. Eu fazo exercício todo dia.

5. Eu sabo falar português.

6. Eu posso falo inglês.

7. Eu tenho que de ir.

8. Já venho! (meaning "I'm coming!")

PRACTICE · PART E: SPEAK AND WRITE

1. Ask permission three different ways: to sit, to open a window, to take a photo. (**a janela**, **tirar uma foto**.)

2. Invite a friend to do something this weekend, using **Vamos…?**, and refuse an invitation politely.

3. Say three things you know how to do and three things you do not know how to do.

4. Say who you know in your city and which cities you know in Brazil.

5. Describe today's weather with **fazer** and a place in your city, for example **Em Londres hoje faz frio.**

ANSWER KEY

1. **vou**.
2. **faz**.
3. **vimos**.
4. **podem**.
5. **quero**.
6. **sabe**.
7. **digo**.
8. **trazemos**.
9. **leem**.
10. **saio**.
11. **ponho**.
12. **vamos**.
13. **conheço**: a place you know.
14. **sabe**: a skill.
15. **sei**: a fact.
16. **conhece**: a person.
17. **sabem**: information.
18. **conhecemos**: a place.
19. **sabe**: a skill.
20. **conheço**: a place.
21. **Posso** (permission).
22. **tenho que** (obligation; **preciso** is also correct).
23. **pode** (request).
24. **preciso**: **preciso ir**.
25. **Quer** (offer).
26. **pode**: **não pode** (prohibition).
27. **queremos**.
28. **deve** (expectation).
29. **Eu quero ir ao cinema.**
30. **Eu conheço o João.**
31. **Eu sei nadar.**
32. **Eu faço exercício todo dia.**
33. **Eu sei falar português.**
34. **Eu posso falar inglês.**
35. **Eu tenho que ir.**
36. **Já vou!**
37. Model answers: **Posso sentar aqui? Posso abrir a janela? Posso tirar uma foto?** Check that each second verb is in the infinitive.
38. A model answer: **Vamos ao cinema no sábado?** and **Obrigado, mas hoje não posso.**
39. A model answer: **Sei cozinhar, sei nadar e sei dirigir. Não sei dançar, não sei tocar violão e não sei esquiar.** Check that **saber** is followed by an infinitive.
40. A model answer: **Conheço a Ana e o Pedro. Conheço o Rio e Salvador.** Check that **conhecer** has a person or a place as the object.
41. A model answer: **Em Londres hoje faz frio e faz sol.**

7.14 Return

These three questions bring back Lessons 1 to 6.

1. Say the time in two ways: **3:30** and **3:45**. Which verb, **é** or **são**?
2. Choose between **ser** and **estar**: **A reunião ___ às nove. O café ___ frio.**
3. Make the plural: **o jornal**, **a lição**, **o homem**.

Check: (1) **São três e meia**, **São quinze para as quatro**; **são** from two o'clock on; (2) **é** (an event time), **está** (a state); (3) **os jornais**, **as lições**, **os homens**.

WHEN	WHAT TO DO
Day 1	Conjugate **ir**, **fazer**, **poder** and **querer** aloud, four forms each.
Day 3	Say ten sentences with **poder + infinitive**.
Day 7	Say five sentences with **saber** and five with **conhecer**.
Day 14	Tell a friend what you want to do, can do and have to do next week.

7.15 Pocket summary: Lesson 7

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Ir:** **vou, vai, vamos, vão**. **Fazer:** **faço, faz, fazemos, fazem**; also weather (**faz frio**) and "for a time" (**faz dois anos que**). **Vir:** **venho, vem, vimos, vêm**.
- **Irregular *eu* forms:** **digo, trago, leio, saio, ponho, conheço, peço, ouço, sei, vejo, dou**.
- **Modals + infinitive:** **poder** (**posso, pode, podemos, podem**), **querer** (**quero, quer**), **saber** (**sei, sabe**), **dever**. No preposition before the infinitive.
- **Poder** for ability, permission, request: **Posso entrar? Pode repetir? Aqui não pode fumar. Dá para...?** for "is it possible?"
- **Obligation:** **preciso (de)**, **tenho que**; **advice and probability:** **deve**.
- **Saber × conhecer:** facts and skills versus people and places.
- **Ir × vir:** **Já vou!** is "I'm coming"; **Vem cá** is "come here".
- **Invitations:** **Vamos + infinitive**.

7.16 What comes next

In Lesson 8 you learn to say what is yours and what you like. You will meet the possessives **meu**, **seu**, **dele**, **dela**, the demonstratives **este**, **esse**, **aquele**, and the verbs **gostar de**, **amar** and **preferir**.

LESSON 8

Possessives, demonstratives, liking and preferring

By the end of this lesson you can say whose something is without confusing “his”, “her” and “your”, point at things near and far the way Brazilians do, say what you like, love and prefer, and use **muito** and **pouco** without making them agree when they should not.

8.1 A scene you will live

You share an apartment in Belo Horizonte with two Brazilians. On Saturday morning your phone is at 3% and you cannot find your charger. There are three chargers on the living-room table, and you have to ask about each of them.

> **Emma:** Bruno, esse carregador é seu? **Bruno:** Não, é da Clara. O meu está no quarto. Aquele ali, o preto, é o meu. **Emma:** E esses óculos? **Bruno:** São dele. Do Rafael. Ele deixa tudo aqui na sala. **Emma:** E essa mochila azul? É sua? **Bruno:** É minha, sim. Você gosta dela? **Emma:** Gosto muito. Mas eu prefiro a verde.

Translation: *Bruno, is this charger yours? / No, it is Clara’s. Mine is in the bedroom. That one over there, the black one, is mine. / And these glasses? / They are his. Rafael’s. He leaves everything here in the living room. / And this blue backpack? Is it yours? / It is mine, yes. Do you like it? / I like it a lot. But I prefer the green one.*

Six small problems are hiding in that conversation: **seu** (your) next to **dele** (his), **esse** next to **aquele**, **aqui** next to **ali**, the little word **de** that follows **gostar** (**gosta dela**), the verb **preferir**, and **muito** used as an adverb. This lesson takes them one at a time.

Words you will need, with their guides:

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
o carregador	oo kah-heh-gah-DOR	the charger
os óculos	ooss AW-koo-looss	the glasses (always plural)
a mochila	ah moh-SHEE-lah	the backpack
o guarda-chuva	oo GWAR-dah SHOO-vah	the umbrella
a sala	ah SAH-lah	the living room
o quarto	oo KWAR-too	the bedroom
deixar	day-SHAR	to leave (something somewhere); to let

8.2 The trap: English counts owners, Portuguese counts things

English has one small word for each owner: *my, your, his, her, our, their*. The word never changes with the thing owned: *my brother, my sister, my brothers, my sisters.* If the owner is a woman, you say *her brother*, and the "her" tells you about the owner.

Portuguese works the other way round. The possessive agrees with the **thing owned**, in gender and number, exactly like an adjective. It says nothing about the owner's sex.

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE	WHAT AGREES
my brother	**meu irmão**	masculine singular thing
my sister	**minha irmã**	feminine singular thing
my brothers	**meus irmãos**	masculine plural thing
my sisters	**minhas irmãs**	feminine plural thing
her brother	**o irmão dela**	(see 8.4: the owner is named separately)
his brother	**o irmão dele**	the same

So a woman says **meu irmão** and a man says **minha irmã**. Both are "my". The word follows the noun, not the speaker. This is the first of two traps. The second is that "his", "her" and "your" are tangled together in the third person, and that is where **dele** and **dela** come in.

8.3 The possessives of the speaker, of the listener and of "us"

Learn the full table once. The forms for *I* and *we* are easy to use because nothing is ambiguous about them.

OWNER	MASC. SING.	FEM. SING.	MASC. PL.	FEM. PL.
my (eu)	**meu** MEH-oo	**minha** MEE-nyah	**meus** MEH-ooss	**minhas** MEE-nyahss
your (você)	**seu** SEH-oo	**sua** SOO-ah	**seus** SEH-ooss	**suas** SOO-ahss
our (nós, a gente)	**nosso** NAW-soo	**nossa** NAW-sah	**nossos** NAW-sooss	**nossas** NAW-sahss
your (tu, in some regions)	**teu** TEH-oo	**tua** TOO-ah	**teus** TEH-ooss	**tuas** TOO-ahss

Remember that **você takes seu** because it is grammatically a third-person word, as you learned with the pronouns: **você tem** uses the same verb form as **ele tem**. In the south of Brazil and in parts of the north and northeast, people say **tu** and use **teu** and **tua**. You should recognize them; you can always use **você** and **seu** and be understood everywhere.

1 **Choose the form by the noun**

Find the noun, decide its gender and number, and match it. The speaker's sex does not matter.

meu pai, **minha mãe**, **meu carro**, **minha casa**, **meus amigos**, **minhas amigas**.

2 **Decide whether to add the article**

In Brazil you may say **meu pai** or **o meu pai**, **minha casa** or **a minha casa**. Both are correct and both are common. The article gives a slightly more careful sound, and in Portugal it is used more often than in Brazil. After the verb **ser** used to say whose something is, you normally drop it: **O carro é meu** (not "é o meu", unless you are choosing between several cars).

Next to a name, the article stays optional in the same way: **o meu amigo Bruno**, **meu amigo Bruno**.

3 **Use the possessive alone as a pronoun**

You do not need a second word for "mine", "yours", "ours" as English does. The same word works, with the article when it replaces a noun:

- **Esse carregador é seu?** (Is this charger yours?)
- **Não, o meu está no quarto.** (No, mine is in the bedroom.)
- **Os nossos vizinhos são simpáticos. E os seus?** (Our neighbors are nice. And yours?)

4 **Say "a friend of mine" with the possessive after the noun**

English moves to *of mine*. Portuguese does it with the possessive after an indefinite noun and **no article**:

- **um amigo meu** (a friend of mine)
- **uma prima minha** (a cousin of mine)
- **uns colegas nossos** (some colleagues of ours)

> TIP
>
> When the owner is obvious, Portuguese often drops the possessive and says only *the*. This is common with body parts and with things that belong to the subject: **Eu lavo as mãos** (I wash my hands), **Ela perdeu a carteira** (she lost her wallet; the owner is clear from the subject). English insists on *my* and *her* here.

8.4 The big ambiguity: seu, sua, dele, dela

Look at this sentence:

> Ana viu Paulo com a sua irmã.

It can mean *Ana saw Paulo with Ana's sister*, *with Paulo's sister* or *with your sister* (if you were talking to Ana, Paulo or someone else). **Seu** and **sua** can mean *your*, *his*, *her* and *their*. Portuguese speakers know this and avoid it.

The fix is simple, and Brazilians use it all the time: for "his", "her" and "their", leave **seu** aside and say **de + the owner**. With a pronoun, **de** and **ele** fuse into one word:

OWNER	SAY	EXAMPLE
his	**dele** DEH-lee	**o carro dele** (his car)
her	**dela** DEH-lah	**a casa dela** (her house)
their (masc. or mixed)	**deles** DEH-leess	**os filhos deles** (their children)
their (all women)	**delas** DEH-lahss	**as amigas delas** (their friends)
a named owner	**do Paulo**, **da Ana**	**o carro do Paulo**, **a irmã da Ana**

OWNER	SAY	EXAMPLE
the person you address	**seu**, **sua**, **de você**	**o seu carro**

Notice what changes. The word before **dele** or **dela** agrees with the **thing owned** (**o carro**, **a casa**), and **dele/dela** agrees with the **owner**. The result is exactly the information English gives you with *his car* and *her car*.

So the speaker of Brazilian Portuguese says:

MESSAGE	BRAZILIAN WAY
Ana saw Paulo with Paulo's sister.	**A Ana viu o Paulo com a irmã dele.**
Ana saw Paulo with her own sister.	**A Ana viu o Paulo com a irmã dela.**
Ana saw Paulo with your sister.	**A Ana viu o Paulo com a sua irmã.** (to the listener)

WATCH OUT

In spoken Brazilian Portuguese, **seu** and **sua** almost always mean **your** (you = **você**). When someone means "his" or "her", they say **dele** or **dela**. In writing, and in some older speakers' speech, **seu** can still mean "his" or "her", so you will read it. In conversation you can use the rule: **seu is yours; dele/dela/deles/delas is theirs.**

For "our", use **nosso** or the colloquial **da gente**, which is natural with **a gente** as the subject: **Esse carro é da gente** = **Esse carro é nosso**. **O apartamento da gente é pequeno**.

Whose is it?

To ask whose something is, use **de quem**. The answer uses **ser** + the possessive, or **de** + the owner:

QUESTION	ANSWER
De quem é esse guarda-chuva?	**É meu.** / **É do Rafael.** / **É dela.**
De quem são esses óculos?	**São do Bruno.** / **São dele.**

De fuses with the article of the owner: **de** + **o** = **do**, **de** + **a** = **da**, **de** + **os** = **dos**, **de** + **as** = **das**. This is the same contraction you used in the lesson on articles. With a name used without article (**de Clara**), nothing fuses, but many Brazilians put an article before a first name in conversation (**a Clara**, **o Rafael**), so you will hear **da Clara** and **do Rafael** all the time. Both are acceptable.

8.5 This, that, that over there: the demonstratives

English has two steps: *this* (near) and *that* (far). Portuguese is traditionally taught with three, tied to the three persons:

NEAR WHOM?	MASC. SING.	FEM. SING.	MASC. PL.	FEM. PL.	NEUTRAL
me (the speaker)	**este** EHS-tchee	**esta** EHS-tah	**estes** EHS-tcheess	**estas** EHS-tahss	**isto** EES-too
you (the listener)	**esse** EH-see	**essa** EH-sah	**esses** EH-seess	**essas** EH-sahss	**isso** EE-soo
neither of us, far	**aquele** ah-KEH-lee	**aquela** ah-KEH-lah	**aqueles** ah-KEH-leess	**aquelas** ah-KEH-lahss	**aquilo** ah-KEE-loo

That is the textbook. Here is what Brazilians do with it in daily speech.

1 **Use esse, essa, esses, essas for both "this" and "that" near you**

In everyday speech, **este**, **esta** and **isto** are heard far less often than **esse**, **essa** and **isso**. A Brazilian holding a cup will often say **Gosto desse café** meaning *I like this coffee*, even though the textbook says **deste**. You will still read **este/esta/isto** in newspapers, signs and formal talks, and you will hear them in careful speech, so you must recognize them. For your own speech, **esse/essa/isso** is the safe default.

2 **Use aquele, aquela, aqueles, aquelas for things far from both of you**

That includes things far in distance (the building at the end of the street), far in time (**naquela época**, *in those days*), or something you are not sure how to name.

3 **Use the neutral forms when you do not name the thing**

Isto, **isso** and **aquilo** never agree: they refer to something you cannot or do not want to name, or to a whole idea.

- **O que é isso?** (What is this / that?)
- **Aquilo ali é um banco?** (Is that over there a bank?)
- **Isso mesmo!** (Exactly!)
- **Não gosto disso.** (I do not like this / that.)

Essa × aquela in a real choice

Hold a shirt in your hand in a shop in Recife. In the textbook, your hand has **esta camisa** and the display behind the cashier has **aquela camisa**. In speech, you say **essa camisa** for the one in your hand, and **aquela** for the one behind the counter. If the clerk points to a shirt next to you and asks **Quer experimentar essa?**, the **essa** points to something close to you both.

HOW IT COMPARES

IN ENGLISH	IN PORTUGUESE
this / that (two steps)	**esse** (close) and **aquele** (far): two steps in speech, three in the textbook
this and *that* are used alone as pronouns: *I like this*	alone as a pronoun for an unnamed thing: **isso** / **aquilo**; for a named thing, **esse** + noun or the noun is dropped: **Gosto desse**
that can refer to what was just said: *That's true*	**Isso é verdade**; **Esse problema é grande** refers to a problem already mentioned

The contractions

Demonstratives fuse with **em** and **de**, as articles do. Say them aloud, because they are among the most frequent words in the language.

PREPOSITION	+ ESSE	+ ESSA	+ ISSO	+ AQUELE	+ AQUELA	+ AQUILO
de	desse DEH-see	dessa DEH-sah	disso DJEE-soo	daquele dah-KEH-lee	daquela dah-KEH-lah	daquilo dah-KEE-loo
em	nesse NEH-see	nessa NEH-sah	nisso NEE-soo	naquele nah-KEH-lee	naquela nah-KEH-lah	naquilo nah-KEE-loo

The same happens with **este/esta/isto**: **deste**, **desta**, **disto**, **neste**, **nesta**, **nisto**. You will read them more than you say them.

- **Eu moro nesse prédio.** (I live in this building.)
- **Você gosta dessa música?** (Do you like this song?)
- **Não tenho nada a ver com aquilo.** (I have nothing to do with that.)

With **a** (to), **aquele**, **aquela** and **aquilo** fuse too and take a grave accent: **àquele**, **àquela**, **àquilo**: **Vou àquela festa**. This is the mark you saw in Lesson 1 under "acento grave", and you will meet it in reading before you use it in speech.

8.6 Aqui, aí, ali, lá: the place words that go with them

The demonstratives have a matching set of place words.

WORD	GUIDE	WHERE	GOES WITH
aqui	ah-KEE	here, near me	**este** / **esse**
aí	ah-EE	there, near you or just there	**esse**
ali	ah-LEE	over there, within sight	**aquele**
lá	lah	far away, often out of sight	**aquele**
cá	kah	here (mostly with movement: **vem cá**)	

- **Venha cá!** / **Vem aqui!** (Come here!)
- **Tem pão aí?** (Is there bread there? Said by phone to someone at home.)
- **O banheiro fica ali, à direita.** (The bathroom is over there, on the right.)
- **Meus pais moram lá em Recife.** (My parents live there in Recife.)

TIP

The Brazilian habit: pair the demonstrative with the place word. Do it every time you point. It sounds natural and makes your meaning clearer than the demonstrative alone.

- **Quero esse aqui.** (I want this one.)
- **Você pode pegar essa aí pra mim?** (Can you get that one for me?)
- **Aquele ali é o meu ônibus.** (That one over there is my bus.)

1 **Combine them with the right verb**

Use **estar** for location, as you learned: **Meu celular está aqui**. Use **ficar** for a fixed location of a building, a street or a city: **O banco fica ali**. Both appear in the same conversation.

8.7 Gostar: you always need "de"

In English you *like* something. The verb takes a direct object. In Portuguese, **gostar** always needs the preposition **de** before the thing or person that you like. The verb is a regular **-ar** verb, like the ones in the lesson on the present tense.

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE
eu	**gosto**	GAWS-too
você, ele, ela, a gente	**gosta**	GAWS-tah
nós	**gostamos**	gohs-TAH-mooss
vocês, eles, elas	**gostam**	GAWS-tah~oo

Then add **de** and the thing. If a noun with an article follows, **de** fuses with the article as in 8.4:

YOU LIKE…	SAY
a noun without article	**Eu gosto de café.**
a noun with article	**Eu gosto do Rafael.** / **Ela gosta da casa.** / **Gostamos dos vizinhos.**
a person, as a pronoun	**Eu gosto dele.** / **Eu gosto dela.** / **Ela gosta de mim.** / **Gosto de você.**
a verb	**Eu gosto de cozinhar.** (infinitive, no change)
a demonstrative	**Gosto disso.** / **Gosto desse.**

Notice **gosto dele**, not "gosto de ele": the two words fuse. After a preposition, "me" becomes **mim**: **Ela gosta de mim** (not "de eu"). We will return to this in Lesson 12.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **Only an infinitive follows gostar de.** Not a conjugated verb, and not "-ing": **Gosto de dançar** (I like dancing), never "gosto dançar". The small word **de** is easy to forget when you are focusing on the verb. Keep it.

How much do you like it?

Put the intensity next to the verb, never before it:

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
Gosto muito de samba.	GAWS-too MOO~ee-too djee SAH~-bah	I like samba a lot.
Gosto bastante.	GAWS-too bahs-TAH~-tchee	I like it quite a lot.
Gosto um pouco.	GAWS-too oo~ POH-koo	I like it a little.
Não gosto muito.	NOW~ GAWS-too MOO~ee-too	I do not like it much.
Não gosto nada.	NOW~ GAWS-too NAH-dah	I do not like it at all.
Adoro viajar.	ah-DAW-roo vee-ah-ZHAR	I love traveling.
Detesto esperar.	deh-TEHS-too ehs-peh-RAR	I hate waiting.
Odeio fila.	oh-DAY-oo FEE-lah	I hate lines.

Notice that **adorar**, **detestar** and **odiar** take **no de**: **adoro café**, **detesto trânsito**. They are the exceptions that confirm the rule. Only **gostar** needs the preposition.

Gostar × amar

Use **gostar** for almost everything: food, music, places, people you like. Use **amar** ah-MAR for strong, deep love, mostly of people: **Eu amo meus filhos**, **Eu te amo**. In casual speech people also say **Eu amo pizza** or **Eu amo esse lugar**, a slightly enthusiastic way to say *I love it*, but **adorar** is the more neutral word for things you are very fond of.

Be careful with people. **Eu gosto de você** is gentle: it means *I like you* and can be a friendly compliment or, depending on the tone, a first step toward romance. **Eu te amo** is much stronger and is not said to a friend lightly.

8.8 Preferir: choosing between two things

Preferir preh-feh-REER is an **-ir** verb whose stem vowel changes from **e** to **i** in the **eu** form only (**prefiro**). The rest of its present tense is regular:

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE
eu	**prefiro**	preh-FEE-roo
você, ele, ela, a gente	**prefere**	preh-FEH-ree
nós	**preferimos**	preh-feh-REE-mooss
vocês, eles, elas	**preferem**	preh-FEH-reh~ee

It takes a direct object, so there is no extra preposition before the thing preferred:

- **Eu prefiro a mochila verde.** (I prefer the green backpack.)
- **Prefiro café.** (I prefer coffee.)
- **Ela prefere ficar em casa.** (She prefers to stay at home.)
- **Nós preferimos viajar de ônibus.** (We prefer to travel by bus.)

To say what you prefer **to** what, the traditional preposition is **a**:

- **Prefiro café a chá.** (I prefer coffee to tea.)
- **Prefiro ficar em casa a sair.** (I prefer staying in to going out.)

In everyday Brazilian speech you will also hear **Prefiro café do que chá** and **Prefiro café que chá**. Teachers and style guides may correct them. If you want a safe, natural alternative, there is one that nobody corrects: **Gosto mais de café do que de chá** (I like coffee more than tea). The comparison with **mais … do que** is explained in Lesson 13.

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu prefiro mais café.~~	**Eu prefiro café.**	**preferir** already means "like more"; do not add **mais**
~~Eu gosto café.~~	**Eu gosto de café.**	**gostar** always takes **de**
~~Eu gosto de ela.~~	**Eu gosto dela.**	**de** + **ela** fuse into one word
~~Ela gosta de eu.~~	**Ela gosta de mim.**	after a preposition, "me" is **mim**
~~Eu adoro de pizza.~~	**Eu adoro pizza.**	**adorar**, **amar**, **odiar** take no **de**

8.9 Muito and pouco: sometimes they agree and sometimes they do not

Muito (a lot, much, many, very) and **pouco** (little, few, not much) are among the most frequent words in the language. They have two jobs, and the grammar is different for each. Misusing them is a recognizable beginner mark.

Job 1: adjective before a noun. The word is a quantity (*a lot of*, *little*). It agrees in gender and number with the noun, like any adjective.

MEANING	MASC. SING.	FEM. SING.	MASC. PL.	FEM. PL.
a lot, many	**muito**	**muita**	**muitos**	**muitas**
little, few	**pouco**	**pouca**	**poucos**	**poucas**

- **Tem muito trânsito hoje.** (There is a lot of traffic today.)
- **Tem muita gente na praia.** (There are lots of people at the beach.) Notice that **gente** is feminine singular, so it takes **muita**.
- **Tenho muitos amigos aqui.** (I have many friends here.)
- **Ela tem poucas amigas.** (She has few female friends.)
- **Temos pouco tempo.** (We have little time.)

Job 2: adverb. When the word modifies a verb, an adjective or another adverb, it never agrees. It stays **muito** or **pouco**.

- **Eu gosto muito de samba.** (I like samba a lot.) Verb.
- **Elas são muito simpáticas.** (They are very nice.) Adjective: not "muitas simpáticas".
- **Ele fala pouco.** (He does not talk much.)
- **Você fala muito bem.** (You speak very well.) Adverb.

Test: can you replace the word with *very* (or *a lot*, if there is no noun)? Then it is an adverb and does not change. If you can say *a lot of* / *a little of* the noun, it is a quantity word and it agrees.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **Muito obrigado or muito obrigada?** In both cases **muito** stays the same, because it modifies **obrigado** as an adverb. The ending of **obrigado/a** follows the speaker, as you learned in Lesson 1.

Pouco and um pouco are opposites

This is one of the traps that costs foreigners the most. The article changes the meaning completely.

PORTUGUESE	MEANING	EFFECT
Falo pouco português.	I speak little Portuguese.	negative: not enough
Falo um pouco de português.	I speak a little Portuguese.	positive: some
Tenho pouco dinheiro.	I have little money.	not enough
Tenho um pouco de dinheiro.	I have some money.	enough to do something

When you want to be modest and polite, say **Falo um pouco de português**. If you say **falo pouco**, a Brazilian may hear a complaint.

Three more words of quantity, and when to use them:

WORD	GUIDE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
bastante	bahs-TAH~-tchee	quite a lot, enough	**Eu como bastante.**
demais	djee-MIESS	too much; also "a lot, really"	**Gosto demais!** (I really love it!)
nada	NAH-dah	not at all, nothing	**Não gosto nada.**

Demais has two lives. In a negative or critical sentence it means "too much": **Tem gente demais aqui** (there are too many people here). In an enthusiastic sentence it means "really, so much": **Esse bolo está bom demais** (this cake is so good).

8.10 Putting it all together

Read this text aloud, then answer the two questions after it.

> **Eu moro com dois amigos em Belo Horizonte. O apartamento é pequeno, mas a sala é grande e tem muita luz. No meu quarto tem uma cama, uma mesa e a minha mochila azul. Os óculos do Rafael estão sempre na sala, o carregador da Clara está sempre na cozinha**

> e o meu celular nunca está comigo! Eu gosto muito dos meus amigos, mas eu prefiro quando a casa está calma. Aquele sofá ali é velho, mas é o meu lugar preferido. Eu adoro ler nele.

Translation: *I live with two friends in Belo Horizonte. The apartment is small, but the living room is big and has a lot of light. In my bedroom there is a bed, a table and my blue backpack. Rafael's glasses are always in the living room, Clara's charger is always in the kitchen and my phone is never with me! I like my friends a lot, but I prefer it when the house is calm. That sofa over there is old, but it is my favorite place. I love reading on it.*

1. Why is it **os óculos do Rafael** and not "os óculos dele" in the fourth sentence? (Both are possible; one uses the name, one the pronoun.)
2. What does **muita luz** agree with?

New words in the text: **a cama** `ah KAH-mah` (bed), **a cozinha** `ah koh-ZEE-nyah` (kitchen), **o sofá** `oo soh-FAH` (sofa), **calma** `KAH-oo-mah` (calm), **sempre** `SEH~-pree` (always), **nunca** `NOO~-kah` (never).

8.11 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Ele ama sua mãe. (meaning: his mother)~~	**Ele ama a mãe dele.**	**sua** is ambiguous; in speech **sua** means "your"
~~O dela carro é novo.~~	**O carro dela é novo.**	**dele/dela** go after the noun; the article agrees with the thing owned
~~Ela é minha irmão.~~	**Ele é meu irmão.**	the possessive agrees with the noun (**irmão** is masculine)
~~Eu gosto música.~~	**Eu gosto de música.**	**gostar** always takes **de**
~~Eu gosto de dançando.~~	**Eu gosto de dançar.**	an infinitive follows **gostar de**, never a "-ing" form
~~Muitas pessoas são muitas simpáticas.~~	**Muitas pessoas são muito simpáticas.**	**muito** as an adverb does not agree
~~Falo pouco de português, por favor.~~	**Falo um pouco de português.**	**pouco** means "not enough", **um pouco** means "some"
~~Eu quero esse aí aqui.~~	**Quero esse aqui.**	pick one place word to match the demonstrative
~~O que é isto aí?~~	**O que é isso?**	**isso** is the natural spoken word

8.12 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: CHOOSE THE POSSESSIVE

Complete with the correct form of the possessive in parentheses. The speaker's sex does not matter.

1. ___ irmã mora em Curitiba. (my)

2. Onde estão ___ chaves? (my)

3. Você tem ___ documentos? (your, speaking to one person)

4. Nós gostamos do ___ bairro. (our)

5. Esta é ___ mãe, Dona Lúcia. (my)

6. ___ **filhos têm cinco e sete anos.** (our)

7. **Esse carro é ___.** (mine)

PRACTICE · PART B: REMOVE THE AMBIGUITY

Rewrite each sentence so it is clear whose it is. Use **dele**, **dela**, **deles** or **delas**.

1. **A Marta ama o seu irmão.** (Marta's brother)

2. **O Paulo perdeu a sua carteira.** (Paulo's wallet)

3. **Os vizinhos venderam o seu carro.** (the neighbors' car)

4. **Vi a Júlia e a Camila com as suas mães.** (the girls' mothers)

5. Choose the natural answer to **De quem é essa bolsa?** (Ana's bag): (a) **É da Ana.** (b) **É de a Ana.** (c) **É a Ana.**

6. Complete: **De quem é esse guarda-chuva? — É ___ Ricardo.** (de + o)

PRACTICE · PART C: POINT AND PLACE

Complete with the right word.

1. Two shirts, one in your hand and one on the far wall: **___ aqui é barata, mas ___ ali é cara.** (essa / aquela)

2. A far object whose name you do not know: **O que é ___?**

3. **Você mora ___ prédio ali?** (in that building over there: em + aquele)

4. **Eu gosto ___ música.** (of this song: de + essa)

5. You call a friend at home: **Tem pão ___?** (aqui / aí / ali)

6. **Meus pais moram ___ em Recife, bem longe.** (aqui / aí / lá)

7. Translate: *I want this one (in my hand).*

PRACTICE · PART D: LIKE AND PREFER

Complete or correct.

1. **Eu gosto ___ café.**

2. **Ela gosta ___ dançar.**

3. **Nós ___ muito de pizza.** (gostar)

4. **Eu ___ chá.** (preferir)

5. **Eu gosto ___ ela.** (de + ela)

6. Correct the mistake: **Eu gosto música brasileira.**

7. Say in Portuguese: *I prefer to stay at home.*

PRACTICE · PART E: MUITO, POUCO AND YOUR OWN SENTENCES

1. Tem ___ gente na fila. (a lot of)

2. As ruas estão ___ cheias. (very)

3. Eu tenho ___ dinheiro. (little, not enough)

4. Write three sentences about yourself: one about your family using a possessive, one saying what you like (using **gostar de**), one about something you prefer.

ANSWER KEY

1. **Minha irmã** or **A minha irmã**.
2. **minhas**: **chaves** is feminine plural.
3. **seus**: **documentos** is masculine plural, and **você** takes **seu**.
4. **nosso**: **bairro** is masculine singular.
5. **minha**: **Esta é minha mãe** (or **a minha mãe**).
6. **Nossos**: **filhos** is masculine plural.
7. **meu**: **carro** is masculine singular. **Esse carro é meu.**
8. **A Marta ama o irmão dela.**
9. **O Paulo perdeu a carteira dele.**
10. **Os vizinhos venderam o carro deles.**
11. **Vi a Júlia e a Camila com as mães delas.**
12. (a) **É da Ana.**
13. **do**: **É do Ricardo.**
14. **Essa** ... **aquela**.
15. **aquilo**: **O que é aquilo?**
16. **naquele**: **Você mora naquele prédio ali?**
17. **dessa**: **Eu gosto dessa música.**
18. **aí**: the bread is where the listener is.
19. **lá**: far away.
20. **Quero esse aqui.** (Also acceptable: **Quero este**, in careful speech.)
21. **de**.
22. **de**.
23. **gostamos**.
24. **prefiro**: **Eu prefiro chá.**
25. **dela**: **Eu gosto dela.**
26. **Eu gosto de música brasileira.**
27. **Prefiro ficar em casa.** (Also **Eu prefiro ficar em casa**.)
28. **muita**: **gente** is feminine singular, so **Tem muita gente na fila.**
29. **muito**: adverb, never agrees. **As ruas estão muito cheias.**
30. **pouco**: **Eu tenho pouco dinheiro.**
31. Check that your sentence 1 has a possessive that agrees with the noun, sentence 2 has **de** after **gostar**, and sentence 3 uses **prefiro** without **mais**. A model: **Minha irmã mora em Londres. Eu gosto de cozinhar. Prefiro café a chá.**

8.13 Return

Before you go on, answer from earlier lessons, without looking:

1. How do you say *I am Brazilian* if you are a woman? (Lesson 2)
2. What is the contraction of **em** + **a**? (Lesson 5 and Lesson 3)
3. How do you say *it is half past three*? (Lesson 6)

Model answers: 1. **Eu sou brasileira.** 2. **na**. 3. **São três e meia.**

Come back to this lesson after one day, three days, a week and two weeks, and answer Part B and Part D again out loud.

8.14 Pocket summary: Lesson 8

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Possessives agree with the thing owned**, not the owner: **meu**, **minha**, **meus**, **minhas**; **seu** (your), **nosso**. The article is optional: **meu pai** / **o meu pai**.
- **He, she, they:** **dele**, **dela**, **deles**, **delas** (after the noun). In speech, **seu** means "your".
- **Whose?** **De quem é?** — **É meu** / **É do Rafael** / **É dela**. A friend of mine: **um amigo meu**.
- **Demonstratives:** **esse/essa** (close; the spoken default), **aquele/aquela** (far), **isso/aquilo** (neutral). **Este/esta/isto** are formal or written.
- **Place words:** **aqui** (here), **aí** (there with you), **ali** (over there), **lá** (far). Pair them: **esse aqui**, **essa aí**, **aquele ali**.
- **Contractions:** **desse**, **nesse**, **disso**, **nisso**, **daquele**, **naquele**, **daquilo**, **naquilo**.
- **Gostar de** + noun or infinitive: **gosto de café**, **gosto de cozinhar**, **gosto dela**, **gosta de mim**. **Adorar**, **amar**, **odiar**, **detestar** take no **de**.
- **Preferir** takes no **mais**: **prefiro café a chá**; safe alternative: **gosto mais de café do que de chá**.
- **Muito/pouco:** before a noun they agree (**muita gente**, **poucos amigos**); before a verb or adjective they do not (**muito simpáticas**). **Pouco** = not enough; **um pouco** = some.

8.15 What comes next

In Lesson 9 you will tell people about your day. You will meet the small pronoun **me** in **eu me levanto**, the reflexive verbs, and two tenses that make you sound natural very quickly: **vou fazer** for the future and **estou fazendo** for what is happening right now.

LESSON 9

Reflexives, routines, ir + infinitive and estar + gerund

By the end of this lesson you can describe your day in order, say what you are going to do tomorrow, say what is happening right now, and use the small pronouns **me**, **te** and **se** where Brazilians use them.

9.1 A scene you will live

It is Sunday night. Clara, your Brazilian flatmate, sees your open backpack on the floor and asks about your week.

> **Clara:** O que você está fazendo? **Emma:** Estou arrumando a mochila. Amanhã eu começo no trabalho novo. **Clara:** A que horas você se levanta? **Emma:** Eu acordo às seis e meia, mas só me levanto às sete. Tomo banho, tomo café e saio às oito. **Clara:** E vai de quê? **Emma:** Vou pegar o ônibus. Depois, à noite, a gente se vê, né? **Clara:** Claro! Eu vou chegar tarde. Boa sorte!

Translation: *What are you doing? / I am packing my backpack. Tomorrow I start at the new job. / What time do you get up? / I wake up at six thirty, but I only get up at seven. I take a shower, have coffee and leave at eight. / And how are you going? / I am going to take the bus. Then, in the evening, we will see each other, right? / Of course! I will be home late. Good luck!*

Three things in this scene are new, and they are the three pillars of the lesson. First, the little words **se** and **me** (**você se levanta**, **eu me levanto**, **a gente se vê**). Second, **vou pegar** and **vai chegar**: a future built from **ir**. Third, **estou arrumando**: what is happening now.

New words from the scene, with guides:

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
arrumar	ah-hoo-MAR	to tidy; to pack; to arrange
acordar	ah-kor-DAR	to wake up
levantar-se	leh-vah~-TAR-see	to get up
tomar banho	toh-MAR BAH-nyoo	to take a shower or bath
sair	sah-EER	to leave, to go out
pegar	peh-GAR	to take (a bus), to get, to catch
né?	neh	right? isn't it? (spoken, short for **não é?**)

9.2 The trap: why does Portuguese say “I raise myself”?

In English, many daily actions need no pronoun: *I wake up, I get up, I shower, I get dressed, I sit down, I lie down.* English does not say *I wake myself.*

Portuguese grammar says that, for certain verbs, the action returns to the person who does it, and so it adds a pronoun: **eu me levanto** (literally *I raise myself*), **ele se veste** (he dresses himself), **nós nos sentamos** (we sit ourselves down). These are called **reflexive verbs**, and the pronoun is a **reflexive pronoun**.

If you leave the pronoun out, Brazilians understand you almost always. But in some cases you say something different (or odd), and in others you sound wrong. The second trap is that the verbs are not the same in both languages. Portuguese has reflexives where English does not, and **does not** have them where you would expect: English *to take a shower* has no reflexive in Portuguese (**tomar banho**), while English *to feel* (**sentir-se**) becomes reflexive when you talk about yourself.

9.3 The reflexive pronouns

SUBJECT	REFLEXIVE PRONOUN	EXAMPLE
eu	me	Eu me levanto às sete.
você, ele, ela	se	Ela se levanta cedo.
a gente	se	A gente se encontra às cinco.
nós	nos	Nós nos levantamos tarde.
vocês, eles, elas	se	Eles se levantam às seis.
tu (regions)	te	Tu te levantas cedo?

The dictionary form of such a verb is written with **-se** attached by a hyphen: **levantar-se**, **sentar-se**, **chamar-se**. When you conjugate it, the pronoun goes **before** the verb.

1 **Put the pronoun before the verb**

In Brazilian speech the pronoun comes before the conjugated verb: **eu me levanto**, **ela se chama Ana**, **a gente se vê**. Written texts and European Portuguese often put it after, with a hyphen: **levanto-me**, **chama-se Ana**. You will read these forms, but do not use them when speaking Brazilian Portuguese.

2 **Keep the pronoun in a negative sentence, between {{não}} and the verb**

Eu não me levanto cedo. (I do not get up early.) **Ela não se sente bem.** (She does not feel well.)

3 **With two verbs, put the pronoun before the second verb, the infinitive**

Eu preciso me levantar cedo. Vou me deitar agora. Quero me sentar aqui. This is the normal spoken Brazilian pattern. The written style, **preciso levantar-me**, is formal.

WATCH OUT

A gente and se. A gente takes the third-person form of the verb and **se**: **a gente se vê**, **a gente se levanta**. Only the very careful **nós** takes **nos**: **nós nos vemos**. In speech you will hear **a gente se vê** a hundred times for each **nós nos vemos**.

9.4 Which verbs are reflexive in Brazil?

You do not need to memorize a long list. Sort the verbs into three groups.

Group 1: reflexive in everyday speech

These verbs are used with **me/se/nos** all the time. Learn them as a unit.

VERB	GUIDE	MEANING	EXAMPLE
chamar-se	shah-MAR-see	to be called	Eu me chamo Emma. / Como você se chama?
sentir-se	seh~-TCHEER-see	to feel (yourself)	Eu me sinto cansado. (I feel tired)
sentar-se	seh~-TAR-see	to sit down	Pode se sentar. (You may sit down)
deitar-se	day-TAR-see	to lie down	Eu me deito às onze.
divertir-se	djee-ver-TCHEER-see	to have fun	A gente se diverte muito. / Divirta-se!
preocupar-se	preh-oh-koo-PAR-see	to worry	Não se preocupe. (Don't worry)
vestir-se	vehs-TCHEER-see	to get dressed	Eu me visto rápido.

Notice **sentir-se** and **vestir-se**. In the **eu** form, the vowel changes: **sinto** SEE~-too, **visto** VEES-too, **divirto** djee-VEER-too. The other persons keep the **e**: **sente**, **veste**, **diverte**. These are common verbs, so it is worth hearing them in the table above.

Group 2: verbs where the pronoun is optional

For some verbs, the version with **me** and the version without it are both correct, and Brazilians choose either one. This applies to **levantar**, **lembrar** and **esquecer**:

WITH PRONOUN	WITHOUT PRONOUN	MEANING
Eu me levanto às sete.	Eu levanto às sete.	I get up at seven.
Eu me lembro dele.	Eu lembro dele.	I remember him.
Eu me esqueci da chave.	Eu esqueci a chave.	I forgot the key.

Notice that **lembrar** and **esquecer** take **de** after the pronoun version (**me lembro de**, **me esqueci de**), while the version without the pronoun can take the thing directly (**esqueci a chave**). Choose one version of each verb and use it consistently; you will understand both.

Group 3: no pronoun in Brazil

Many English reflexive-sounding actions have **no** pronoun in Portuguese. Do not add one.

SAY	NOT	MEANING
Eu acordo às seis.	~~Eu me acordo~~	I wake up
Eu tomo banho.	~~Eu me banho~~	I take a shower
Eu durmo oito horas.	~~Eu me durmo~~	I sleep
Eu escovo os dentes.	~~Eu me escovo os dentes~~	I brush my teeth
Eu lavo as mãos.	~~Eu me lavo as mãos~~	I wash my hands

The last two follow a pattern. **When a body part or a piece of clothing is the object, you do not need the pronoun**: Eu lavo o rosto, Eu visto o casaco, Ele corta o cabelo. The article (**o**, **a**) replaces the possessive, as in Lesson 8.

> TIP
>
> **Acordar** also takes an object: **Eu acordo as crianças às sete** (I wake the children up at seven). With no object, **acordar** means that you wake up yourself. The sentence is clear from context, and that is why Brazilians do not need **me**.

The same pronoun for "each other"

Se and **nos** also mean "each other". The situation decides which meaning you hear.

- **A gente se vê amanhã.** (We will see each other tomorrow. A common farewell.)
- **Eles se amam.** (They love each other.)
- **Vamos nos encontrar às cinco?** (Shall we meet at five?)
- **Nós nos falamos por WhatsApp.** (We talk to each other on WhatsApp.)

9.5 Your day, in order

Here is the vocabulary of a normal day. Say each phrase in the first person, with **eu** or without.

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
acordar	ah-kor-DAR	to wake up
levantar	leh-vah~-TAR	to get up
tomar café da manhã	toh-MAR kah-FEH dah mah-NYAH~	to have breakfast
ir para o trabalho	eer PAH-rah oo trah-BAH-lyoo	to go to work
chegar em casa	sheh-GAR eh~ee KAH-zah	to get home
almoçar	ah-oo-moh-SAR	to have lunch
jantar	zhah~-TAR	to have dinner
voltar	voh-oo-TAR	to come back
assistir	ah-sees-TCHEER	to watch (TV, a series)
dormir	dor-MEER	to sleep

Some forms to know in the present tense:

VERB	EU	VOCÊ, ELE, ELA, A GENTE	NÓS	VOCÊS, ELES
sair	saio SAH-yoo	sai sie	saímos sah-EE-mooss	saem SAH-eh~ee
dormir	durmo DOOR-moo	dorme DAWR-mee	dormimos	dormem
pegar	pego PEH-goo	pega	pegamos	pegam

Sair is irregular in the **eu** form (**saio**) and in **nós** (**saímos**, with the accent). **Dormir** changes **o** to **u** in **eu durmo**, the same type of change as **sinto** and **visto**. Everything else is regular.

When do you do it? The words that organize a day

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
de manhã	djee mah-NYAH~	in the morning
à tarde	ah TAR-djee	in the afternoon
à noite	ah NOY-tchee	at night

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
de madrugada	djee mah-droo-GAH-dah	very early, in the small hours
depois	deh-POYSS	afterwards
antes	AH~-tcheess	before
primeiro	pree-MAY-roo	first
por último	por OOL-tchee-moo	lastly

Notice **de manhã** but **à tarde** and **à noite**. The first one uses **de**, and the other two use **a** + **a** = **à**. You also met **à** in Lesson 5: that is the grave accent. For exact times use **às**: **às sete**, **às oito e meia**, **ao meio-dia** (at noon).

How often?

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
sempre	SEH~-pree	always
geralmente	zheh-rah-oo-MEH~-tchee	usually
normalmente	nor-mah-oo-MEH~-tchee	normally
às vezes	ahss VEH-zeess	sometimes
quase nunca	KWAH-zee NOO~-kah	almost never
nunca	NOO~-kah	never
todo dia / todos os dias	TOH-doo DJEE-ah	every day
toda semana	TOH-dah seh-MAH-nah	every week

Put **sempre**, **geralmente**, **normalmente** and **quase nunca** before the verb: **Eu sempre tomo café. Às vezes** can start or end the sentence.

WATCH OUT

Nunca can be used with or without não, and the position decides. Before the verb, **nunca** stands alone: **Eu nunca como carne.** After the verb, you need **não** before it: **Eu não como carne nunca.** Do not put both before the verb: ~~Eu não nunca como carne~~. In Portuguese, double negation is correct (and expected); English *I don't never* is wrong, Portuguese **não … nunca** is right. The same applies to **ninguém** (nobody) and **nada** (nothing): **Não vi ninguém**, **Ninguém me viu**.

9.6 Ir + infinitive: the everyday future

In the earlier lessons you met **ir**: **vou**, **vai**, **vamos**, **vão**. With an infinitive after it, **ir** builds the normal spoken future, and the structure is the same as English *I am going to…*

SUBJECT	FORM	EXAMPLE
eu	vou	Eu vou trabalhar amanhã.
você, ele, ela, a gente	vai	Ela vai viajar no sábado.
nós	vamos	Nós vamos almoçar juntos.
vocês, eles, elas	vão	Eles vão chegar tarde.

Only **ir** changes. The second verb stays in the infinitive, in any person. Negative: **não** before **ir**: **Eu não vou sair hoje.** Question: use the same order as a statement, with the rising voice: **Você vai almoçar em casa?** or add a question word: **O que você vai fazer amanhã?**

With a reflexive verb, the pronoun comes before the infinitive: **Amanhã eu vou me levantar mais cedo. A gente vai se encontrar às cinco.**

1 Add a time expression

The future is clearer when it has a time word.

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
hoje à noite	OH-zhee ah NOY-tchee	tonight
amanhã	ah-mah-NYAH~	tomorrow
depois	deh-POYSS	later
daqui a pouco	dah-KEE ah POH-koo	in a little while
semana que vem	seh-MAH-nah kee veh~ee	next week
mês que vem	mehss kee veh~ee	next month
ano que vem	AH-noo kee veh~ee	next year
daqui a dois dias	dah-KEE ah doyss DJEE-ahss	two days from now

Que vem literally means "that comes". In Brazil it is the normal spoken way to say *next*: **na semana que vem**, **no mês que vem**.

2 Remember the suggestion: {{vamos}} + infinitive

Vamos followed by an infinitive means *let's*: **Vamos comer?** (Shall we eat?), **Vamos nos ver amanhã.** (Let's see each other tomorrow.) The same word is also the **nós** form of **ir**, and the context tells you which.

HOW IT COMPARES

IN ENGLISH	IN PORTUGUESE
I am going to the beach tomorrow (present continuous for the future)	**Amanhã eu vou à praia**: the plain present of **ir** already gives the future
I'm working tomorrow	**Amanhã eu trabalho** or **Amanhã eu vou trabalhar**: not **estou trabalhando**
I will call you	**Vou te ligar** (more on **te** in Lesson 12)

Portuguese also has a one-word future (**falarei**, **comerei**). It is used in writing, in formal speech and in some set phrases, but in conversation Brazilians use **vou falar**. You do not need to produce it at this level.

9.7 Estar + gerund: what is happening now

To say what is in progress, use **estar** + the **gerund**, which ends in **-ndo**.

SUBJECT	ESTAR	SPOKEN FORM
eu	**estou** ehs-TOH	**tô** toh
você, ele, ela, a gente	**está** ehs-TAH	**tá** tah
nós	**estamos** ehs-TAH-mooss	
vocês, eles, elas	**estão** ehs-TOW~	**tão** tow~

In relaxed speech, **estou** becomes **tô** and **está** becomes **tá**: **Tô saindo**, **Ela tá dormindo**. You will hear this constantly, so recognize it. In writing and in a more careful style, use the full form.

How to form the gerund

VERB TYPE	RULE	EXAMPLE
-ar	drop -r, add -ndo: -ando	falar → falando fah-LAH~-doo
-er	-endo	comer → comendo koh-MEH~-doo
-ir	-indo	abrir → abrindo ah-BREE~-doo

The rule is regular for every verb you have met, with one exception: **pôr** (to put) makes **pondo** POH~-doo. Verbs that are irregular in other tenses have regular gerunds: **fazer → fazendo** fah-ZEH~-doo, **dizer → dizendo**, **ver → vendo**, **ir → indo**, **vir → vindo**, **sair → saindo**, **ter → tendo**, **dormir → dormindo**.

The gerund never changes: not for person, not for gender, not for number.

- **Eu estou estudando português.** (I am studying Portuguese.)
- **Você está fazendo o quê?** (What are you doing?)
- **Eles estão dormindo.** (They are asleep.)
- **A gente tá chegando.** (We are arriving.)

With a reflexive verb, the pronoun comes **before the gerund** in Brazilian speech: **Estou me arrumando** (I am getting ready), **Ela está se vestindo**.

> TIP
>
> In fast speech many Brazilians drop the **d** of **-ndo**: **falando** sounds like **falano**, **fazendo** like **fazeno**. It is real, and it is not an error. Write the full word.

What estar + gerund is NOT

English uses *-ing* for a lot of things. Portuguese is stricter.

1. **Use it for something happening now, or in a temporary period**
   Estou lendo um livro ótimo. (I am reading a great book. Not necessarily at this second.) **Estou morando em São Paulo.** (I am living in São Paulo. A temporary situation.)

2. **Use the plain present for habits and facts**
   Eu trabalho num banco. (I work at a bank.) **Ela mora no Rio.** (She lives in Rio.) The progressive would suggest that the situation is temporary. If you say **Estou trabalhando num banco**, you are saying that you are working there for now.

3. **Do not use it for the future**
   Amanhã eu viajo or **Amanhã eu vou viajar** (tomorrow I travel / I am going to travel), but not ~~Amanhã estou viajando~~ in this sense.

Here is a small contrast that Brazilians use all the time. **Já estou indo** (literally *I am already going*) means "I am on my way". **Estou chegando** means "I am almost there". Both are the answer to a worried "Where are you?" on WhatsApp.

HOW IT COMPARES

WHERE	HOW TO SAY *I AM WORKING*
Brazil	**Estou trabalhando.** (estar + gerund)
Portugal	**Estou a trabalhar.** (estar + **a** + infinitive)

In Portugal people use **estar a** + infinitive instead of the gerund. If you watch Portuguese films or talk with Portuguese friends, you will hear **estou a fazer** where a Brazilian says **estou fazendo**. Both are correct in their country.

9.8 Putting it together

Read this text aloud. It uses all three tools from this lesson: reflexives, **ir** + infinitive and **estar** + gerund.

> Normalmente eu acordo às seis e meia, mas só me levanto às sete. Tomo banho, escovo os dentes e tomo café. Saio de casa às oito e pego o ônibus. Chego ao trabalho às nove. Almoço ao meio-dia com os colegas. À noite eu volto para casa, jantamos e assistimos a uma série. Eu quase nunca me deito depois da meia-noite. Hoje é domingo, então estou descansando e estou arrumando a mochila. Amanhã vou começar um trabalho novo e vou me levantar mais cedo.

Translation: *Normally I wake up at six thirty, but I only get up at seven. I shower, brush my teeth and have coffee. I leave the house at eight and take the bus. I get to work at nine. I have lunch at noon with my colleagues. In the evening I go back home, we have dinner and watch a series. I almost never go to bed after midnight. Today is Sunday, so I am resting and I am packing my backpack. Tomorrow I am going to start a new job and I am going to get up earlier.*

Two details worth noticing. **Assistimos a uma série** uses **a** after **assistir** when it means *to watch* in careful Portuguese (**assistir a**); in speech people often drop the **a**: **assistimos uma série**. And **chego ao trabalho** is the careful form; in speech **chego no trabalho** is the normal one, as in **chego em casa**.

New words in this text: **colega** `koh-LEH-gah` (colleague), **série** `SEH-ree-ee` (series), **descansar** `djees-kah~-SAR` (to rest), **meia-noite** `MAY-ah NOY-tchee` (midnight).

9.9 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu me acordo às sete.~~	**Eu acordo às sete.**	**acordar** does not need **me** in Brazil
~~Eu me escovo os dentes.~~	**Eu escovo os dentes.**	with a body part as object, no reflexive
~~Eu levanto-me cedo.~~	**Eu me levanto cedo.**	in Brazilian speech the pronoun goes before the verb
~~Eu não me nunca levanto cedo.~~	**Eu nunca me levanto cedo.**	**nunca** before the verb replaces **não**
~~Eu vou me levantar-me.~~	**Eu vou me levantar.**	one pronoun, before the infinitive
~~Eu estou trabalho num banco.~~	**Eu trabalho num banco.**	**estar** needs a gerund; for a habit use the present

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu estou trabalhar agora.~~	Eu estou trabalhando agora.	the gerund ends in -ndo; the infinitive does not follow estar in Brazil
~~Amanhã estou viajando.~~	Amanhã eu viajo. / Amanhã eu vou viajar.	estar + gerund is for now, not for the future
~~Eu vou ir ao mercado.~~	Eu vou ao mercado.	ir already carries the future; do not double it
~~Eu vou a trabalhar.~~	Eu vou trabalhar.	no a between ir and the infinitive
~~Eu me chamo é Emma.~~	Eu me chamo Emma.	no é here; or say Meu nome é Emma

9.10 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: CHOOSE THE PRONOUN

Complete with me, te, se or nos.

1. Eu ___ chamo Emma.
2. Você ___ sente bem?
3. A gente ___ vê amanhã.
4. Nós ___ divertimos muito nas festas.
5. Eles ___ levantam às seis.
6. Eu não ___ lembro do nome dele.
7. Como você ___ chama?
8. Vou ___ deitar cedo hoje.

PRACTICE · PART B: WITH OR WITHOUT A PRONOUN?

Choose the natural Brazilian form.

1. Eu (a) acordo (b) me acordo às seis.
2. Eu (a) escovo (b) me escovo os dentes.
3. Ele (a) toma (b) se toma banho de manhã.
4. Ele (a) sente (b) se sente cansado hoje.
5. Complete: Eu ___ (vestir) o casaco e saio.
6. Translate: *I get up at seven.* (Two answers are possible.)

PRACTICE · PART C: SAY WHAT YOU ARE GOING TO DO

Rewrite with ir + infinitive.

1. Eu trabalho amanhã.
2. Ela viaja no sábado.

3. Nós almoçamos juntos.

4. Eles se encontram hoje à noite.

5. Make it negative: Eu vou sair hoje.

6. Ask: *What are you (você) going to do tomorrow?*

PRACTICE · PART D: WHAT IS HAPPENING NOW?

Give the gerund, or complete the sentence.

1. falar →

2. beber →

3. abrir →

4. fazer →

5. Agora eu ___ (estudar) português.

6. Ela ___ (dormir) agora.

7. Eles ___ (se divertir) na festa.

PRACTICE · PART E: TELL YOUR DAY AND CORRECT

1. Write five sentences about your day, in order. Include one frequency word and one sentence with **nunca**.

2. Correct: Eu estou trabalhando num banco todos os dias.

3. Translate: *I am going to the beach tomorrow.*

4. Which are correct? (a) Eu nunca como carne. (b) Eu não nunca como carne. (c) Eu não como carne nunca.

ANSWER KEY

1. **me**.
2. **se**: **você** takes the third-person pronoun.
3. **se**: **a gente** takes **se**.
4. **nos**: **Nós nos divertimos muito nas festas.**
5. **se**.
6. **me**: **Eu não me lembro do nome dele.** (Without the pronoun, **Eu não lembro do nome dele**, also correct.)
7. **se**: **Como você se chama?**
8. **me**: **Vou me deitar cedo hoje.**
9. (a) **acordo**.
10. (a) **escovo**: a body part is the object.
11. (a) **toma**: **tomar banho** has no reflexive.
12. (b) **se sente**: **sentir-se** is reflexive when you talk about how you feel. (Also correct and natural: **Ele está cansado hoje**.)
13. **visto**: **Eu visto o casaco e saio.**
14. **Eu me levanto às sete.** or **Eu levanto às sete.**
15. **Eu vou trabalhar amanhã.**
16. **Ela vai viajar no sábado.**
17. **Nós vamos almoçar juntos.** (Or **A gente vai almoçar junto.**)
18. **Eles vão se encontrar hoje à noite.**
19. **Eu não vou sair hoje.**
20. **O que você vai fazer amanhã?**
21. **falando**.
22. **bebendo**.
23. **abrindo**.
24. **fazendo**.
25. **estou estudando**: **Agora eu estou estudando português.**
26. **está dormindo** (spoken: **tá dormindo**).
27. **estão se divertindo**.
28. Check the order of events and the placement of the pronoun. A model: **Eu acordo às sete. Tomo banho e tomo café. Geralmente pego o ônibus às oito. À noite assisto a uma série. Nunca me deito tarde.**
29. **Eu trabalho num banco todos os dias.** A habit takes the plain present.
30. **Amanhã eu vou à praia.** (Or **Amanhã eu vou para a praia.**)
31. (a) and (c). The double negative in (b) is wrong because **nunca** before the verb replaces **não**.

9.11 Return

Before you go on, answer from earlier lessons, without looking:

1. How do you ask *What time is it?* and answer *it is two o'clock*? (Lesson 6)
2. What is the present tense of **fazer** for **eu** and **nós**? (Lesson 7)
3. How do you say that something is in a place: *the charger is in the kitchen*? (Lesson 5)

Model answers: 1. **Que horas são? — São duas horas.** 2. **faço, fazemos**. 3. **O carregador está na cozinha.**

Come back to Part C and Part D after one day, three days, a week and two weeks, and answer aloud.

9.12 Pocket summary: Lesson 9

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Reflexive pronouns:** me (eu), se (você, ele, ela, a gente, eles), nos (nós), te (tu). Before the verb: eu me levanto, eu não me levanto, vou me levantar.
- **Reflexive in speech:** chamar-se, sentir-se, sentar-se, deitar-se, divertir-se, preocupar-se, vestir-se. **Without pronoun:** acordar, tomar banho, dormir, escovar os dentes, lavar as mãos.
- **Each other:** a gente se vê, eles se amam.
- **Routine words:** de manhã, à tarde, à noite, às sete; sempre, geralmente, às vezes, quase nunca, nunca. Use não … nunca or nunca alone before the verb.
- **Irregular present:** saio, sai, saímos; durmo, dorme; sinto, visto, divirto.
- **Future with ir:** vou, vai, vamos, vão + infinitive. Vamos + infinitive = let's. Time words: amanhã, semana que vem, daqui a pouco.
- **Now:** estar + gerund: -ando, -endo, -indo. Spoken: tô, tá. Habits take the plain present; the future does not take estar + gerund.
- **Portugal:** estar a + infinitive, and the pronoun after the verb: levanto-me.

9.13 What comes next

In Lesson 10 you will start telling stories about the past. You have the tools to say what you do every day; now you will learn to say what you did yesterday, using the preterite: fui, comi, falei, fiz.

LESSON 10

The simple past: what happened

By the end of this lesson you can tell what you did, where you went and what happened yesterday, last week or last year, with the regular endings and the most frequent irregular verbs (**fui**, **tive**, **fiz**, **disse**, **vi**, **dei**, **vim**).

10.1 A scene you will live

It is Monday morning in the office in Belo Horizonte. Paulo, a colleague, sees you at the coffee machine.

> **Paulo:** Oi, Emma! Como foi o fim de semana? **Emma:** Foi ótimo! No sábado eu fui a Ouro Preto com a Clara. **Paulo:** Vocês foram de ônibus? **Emma:** Fomos. Saímos às sete e chegamos às dez. Visitamos duas igrejas e almoçamos comida mineira. **Paulo:** E no domingo? **Emma:** Fiquei em casa. Dormi bastante, li um livro e não fiz mais nada.

Translation: *Hi, Emma! How was the weekend? / It was great! On Saturday I went to Ouro Preto with Clara. / Did you go by bus? / Yes, we did. We left at seven and arrived at ten. We visited two churches and had lunch, Minas style. / And on Sunday? / I stayed at home. I slept a lot, read a book and did nothing else.*

Look at the verbs: **foi**, **fui**, **foram**, **fomos**, **saímos**, **chegamos**, **visitamos**, **almoçamos**, **fiquei**, **dormi**, **li**, **fiz**. Each one tells you something that **happened and is finished**. This tense is called the **pretérito perfeito**; in this book we say *the simple past*.

New words from the scene:

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
o fim de semana	oo FEE~ djee seh-MAH-nah	the weekend
ótimo	AW-tchee-moo	great, excellent
a igreja	ah ee-GREH-zhah	the church
comida mineira	koh-MEE-dah mee-NAY-rah	food from Minas Gerais
visitar	vee-zee-TAR	to visit
ficar	fee-KAR	to stay, to remain; also to become
ontem	OH~-teh~ee	yesterday

10.2 The trap: English has a past with one form, Portuguese has one for each person

English is kind with the simple past. *I ate, you ate, she ate, we ate, they ate.* One form for everybody, and a helper (*did*) for questions and negatives: *Did you eat? I did not eat.*

Portuguese does the opposite. The past tense has a **different ending for each person**, there is **no helper**, and the stress is on the ending. Three consequences follow.

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE	WHAT IS DIFFERENT
I ate	**comi**	the ending shows the person (**-i** = eu)
you ate	**comeu**	another ending (**-eu** = você, ele, ela)
Did you eat?	**Você comeu?**	no helper: just the verb and a rising voice
I did not eat.	**Não comi.**	no helper: **não** + verb
I have eaten / I've already eaten.	**Já comi.**	the same tense covers the English present perfect

The last row is the big relief. In English, *I ate* and *I have eaten* are two tenses with different meanings. In Brazilian Portuguese, in the situations where you would say *I have already eaten*, *I have been to Rio*, *I have never seen that film*, you use **this** simple past (**Já comi**, **Já fui ao Rio**, **Nunca vi esse filme**). Section 10.8 explains what the other form (**tenho comido**) is.

10.3 The regular endings

Take the infinitive, remove **-ar**, **-er** or **-ir**, and add the endings. Say the forms aloud. The stress is on the ending, and that is what makes it different from the present tense.

PERSON	-AR: FALAR	-ER: COMER	-IR: ABRIR
eu	**falei** fah-LAY	**comi** koh-MEE	**abri** ah-BREE
você, ele, ela, a gente	**falou** fah-LOH	**comeu** koh-MEH-oo	**abriu** ah-BREE-oo
nós	**falamos** fah-LAH-mooss	**comemos** koh-MEH-mooss	**abrimos** ah-BREE-mooss
vocês, eles, elas	**falaram** fah-LAH-rah~oo	**comeram** koh-MEH-rah~oo	**abriram** ah-BREE-rah~oo

Spend a minute on this table. The **-er** and **-ir** endings are **identical** (**-i, -eu / -iu, -emos / -imos, -eram / -iram**) except that **-ir** verbs have **i** where **-er** verbs have **e**. The **-ar** group has its own endings.

1 **Learn the {{eu}} and {{você}} endings first**

They are the ones you will use most: **-ei** / **-ou** for **-ar**, **-i** / **-eu** (or **-iu**) for **-er** and **-ir**. Say them in pairs: **falei, falou**; **comi, comeu**; **abri, abriu**.

2 **Use {{a gente}} with the third-person singular**

A gente falou, **a gente comeu**, **a gente abriu**. It is the form you will hear in conversation for "we".

3 **Do not confuse past and present in the third-person plural**

The plural past has an extra syllable, and the stress moves.

PRESENT	PAST
falam FAH-lah~oo	falaram fah-LAH-rah~oo
comem KAW-meh~ee	comeram koh-MEH-rah~oo
abrem AH-breh~ee	abriram ah-BREE-rah~oo

For the singular, listen to where the stress is: **ele fala** FAH-lah (present) and **ele falou** fah-LOH (past).

> WATCH OUT
>
> **For nós, the regular past looks exactly like the present:** falamos, comemos and abrimos can be present or past. Brazilians use the context to tell: **Nós falamos todo dia** (every day, so present) and **Nós falamos ontem** (yesterday, so past). In Portugal, the past of **-ar** verbs is written **falámos**, with an accent, but in Brazil it is not.

Spelling changes in the eu form

Three types of verbs change their spelling in the **eu** form only, so that the sound stays the same.

VERB ENDS IN	EU FORM	EXAMPLE	WHY
-car	-quei	ficar → fiquei fee-KAY, tocar → toquei	keeps the hard *k* sound before *e*
-gar	-guei	chegar → cheguei sheh-GAY, pagar → paguei	keeps the hard *g* sound before *e*
-çar	-cei	começar → comecei koh-meh-SAY, almoçar → almocei	no cedilla before *e*

The other persons do not change: **ele ficou**, **ele chegou**, **ele começou**. (You learned in Lesson 1 why **c** before **e** is *s* and why **gu** is needed: this is the same logic.)

10.4 The irregular verbs you cannot avoid

Some of the most frequent verbs in the language are irregular in the past. You already know their infinitives; now learn the past forms. Do not learn them one by one: look at the patterns.

Ser and ir have the same past

PERSON	FORM	GUIDE
eu	fui	FOO-ee
você, ele, ela, a gente	foi	foy
nós	fomos	FOH-mooss
vocês, eles, elas	foram	FOH-rah~oo

Fui means both *I was* and *I went*. This sounds impossible, but the sentence tells you which one it is:

- **Eu fui ao mercado.** (I went to the market.) A place follows: **ir**.
- **Eu fui professor por dez anos.** (I was a teacher for ten years.) A noun follows: **ser**.
- **A viagem foi ótima.** (The trip was great.) An adjective follows: **ser**.

- **Ela foi ao médico.** (She went to the doctor.) A preposition + place follows: **ir**.

> TIP
>
> **To tell ser from ir:** if the next word is a place with **a**, **para**, **em**, or its contraction (**ao**, **à**, **pro**, **pra**), the verb is **ir**. If the next word is a noun, an adjective, or a full sentence (**foi um prazer**), it is **ser**. In practice, nobody hesitates in conversation.

A group with a new stem: ter, estar, fazer, dizer, poder, querer, saber, pôr, trazer

These verbs change the stem of the past tense. Their endings follow one regular pattern: **-e** (or nothing), **-e** (or nothing), **-emos**, **-eram**, with a circumflex only in **pôde** and **pôs**. The stem is the same for the whole tense, except that some verbs change its vowel in the **você/ele** form: **tive** / **teve**, **fiz** / **fez**, **pude** / **pôde**, **pus** / **pôs**.

INFINITIVE	EU	VOCÊ, ELE, ELA	NÓS	ELES
ter	tive TCHEE-vee	teve TEH-vee	tivemos tchee-VEH-mooss	tiveram tchee-VEH-rah~oo
estar	estive ehs-TCHEE-vee	esteve ehs-TEH-vee	estivemos	estiveram
fazer	fiz feess	fez fehss	fizemos fee-ZEH-mooss	fizeram fee-ZEH-rah~oo
dizer	disse DJEE-see	disse	dissemos djee-SEH-mooss	disseram djee-SEH-rah~oo
poder	pude POO-djee	pôde POH-djee	pudemos	puderam
querer	quis keess	quis	quisemos	quiseram
saber	soube SOH-bee	soube	soubemos	souberam
pôr	pus pooss	pôs pohss	pusemos	puseram
trazer	trouxe TROH-see	trouxe	trouxemos	trouxeram

Notice the circumflex on **pôde** (past) versus **pode** (present): that accent is the only thing that separates them in writing. Do not confuse **pôs** (past) with **põe** (present of **pôr**).

A group that is nearly regular but has a different stem: ver, vir, dar, ler

INFINITIVE	EU	VOCÊ, ELE, ELA	NÓS	ELES
ver	vi vee	viu VEE-oo	vimos VEE-mooss	viram VEE-rah~oo
vir	vim VEE~	veio VAY-oo	viemos vee-EH-mooss	vieram vee-EH-rah~oo
dar	dei day	deu DEH-oo	demos DEH-mooss	deram DEH-rah~oo
ler	li lee	leu LEH-oo	lemos LEH-mooss	leram LEH-rah~oo

Notice that **vir** (past: *came*) and **ver** (past: *saw*) are close. **Vi** is *I saw*; **vim** is *I came*. Say them aloud until your mouth knows the difference: **vi** vee is short and oral; **vim** VEE~ is nasal. **Veio** is *he came*, **viu** is *he saw*.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **Do not apply the regular pattern to these verbs.** The two classic errors from English speakers are ~~fazi~~ (for **fiz**) and ~~disseu~~ (for **disse**). If it helps, learn the **eu** and **você** forms of each verb first: **tive/teve**, **fiz/fez**, **disse/disse**, **vi/viu**, **dei/deu**, **vim/veio**, **pude/pôde**. The rest follows by pattern.

Everything else is regular

Verbs like **sair**, **ouvir**, **dormir**, **pedir** and **chegar** use the regular endings. **Sair** just needs the accent: **saí** `sah-EE`, **saiu** `sah-EE-oo`, **saímos** `sah-EE-mooss`, **saíram** `sah-EE-rah~oo`. **Dormir**: **dormi**, **dormiu**, **dormimos**, **dormiram**.

10.5 When to use the simple past

The simple past tells what **happened**: an event that began and ended, or a series of events in order.

- **Ontem eu acordei às seis.** (Yesterday I woke up at six.)
- **Ela chegou, abriu a porta e entrou.** (She arrived, opened the door and went in.)
- **Nós moramos em Lisboa por dois anos.** (We lived in Lisbon for two years. It is over.)
- **Em 2019 eu fui ao Brasil pela primeira vez.** (In 2019 I went to Brazil for the first time.)

It also answers the question *what happened?* in a story. Lesson 11 adds a second past tense for background and habits, and shows when to choose each one. For now, the rule is: a finished event with a clear beginning and end uses the simple past.

Time markers for the past

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
ontem	`OH~-teh~ee`	yesterday
anteontem	`ah~-tchee-OH~-teh~ee`	the day before yesterday
ontem à noite	`OH~-teh~ee ah NOY-tchee`	last night
na semana passada	`nah seh-MAH-nah pah-SAH-dah`	last week
no mês passado	`noo mehss pah-SAH-doo`	last month
no ano passado	`noo AH-noo pah-SAH-doo`	last year
no sábado, na segunda		on Saturday, on Monday
em 2019		in 2019
uma vez / duas vezes	`OO-mah vehss`	once / twice
de repente	`djee heh-PEH~-tchee`	suddenly
já	`zhah`	already; ever (in questions)
ainda não	`ah-EE~-dah NOW~`	not yet
nunca	`NOO~-kah`	never

Linking events in order

A story in the simple past is a chain of events. These small words keep the chain together, and Brazilians use them constantly in speech.

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
primeiro	`pree-MAY-roo`	first
depois	`deh-POYSS`	then, afterwards
em seguida	`eh~ee seh-GEE-dah`	right after that
aí	`ah-EE`	then (spoken, very frequent)
então	`eh~-TOW~`	so, then

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
por fim	por FEE~	finally
quando	KWAH~-doo	when

- **Primeiro eu fui ao banco, depois almocei e por fim voltei para casa.** (First I went to the bank, then I had lunch and finally I went back home.)
- **Cheguei, aí o telefone tocou e eu atendi.** (I arrived, then the phone rang and I answered.)
- **Quando eu cheguei, a Clara saiu.** (When I arrived, Clara left.)

With **quando**, two simple pasts in a row mean that one event followed the other: first I arrived, then she left. If you want to say that she had already left before you arrived, Lesson 11 gives you the tool for it.

How long ago?

Three ways, all common:

- **Cheguei há duas semanas.** (I arrived two weeks ago.) **Há** + time, **before** the verb or after it.
- **Cheguei duas semanas atrás.** (same: two weeks ago.) **Atrás** after the time.
- **Faz duas semanas que cheguei.** (It is two weeks since I arrived.)

HOW IT COMPARES

IN ENGLISH	IN PORTUGUESE
I have already eaten.	**Já comi.**
I haven't eaten yet.	**Ainda não comi.**
I have never been to Japan.	**Nunca fui ao Japão.**
Have you ever been to Rio?	**Você já foi ao Rio?**
I have lived here for three years (and still do)	**Moro aqui há três anos.** (present tense + **há**)
I lived there for three years (finished)	**Morei lá por três anos.**

Look at the fifth row. This is a very common error for English speakers: when the situation is **still true now**, Portuguese uses the **present tense** plus **há** or **faz**: **Estudo português há seis meses** (I have been studying Portuguese for six months). When it is over, use the simple past.

10.6 Questions, negatives and short answers

No helper verb. The order is the same as in a statement, and the voice rises, or a question word starts the sentence.

TYPE	EXAMPLE
Yes/no question	**Você foi à festa?**
Question word	**O que você fez ontem?**
Where to	**Para onde vocês foram?**
When	**Quando ela chegou?**
Who with	**Com quem você foi?**
How was it	**Como foi a viagem?**
Negative	**Eu não fui à festa.**
Never	**Nunca fui a Salvador.**

For short answers, Brazilians **repeat the verb**. They do not say *yes, I did*. They say the verb:

QUESTION	SHORT ANSWERS
Você viu o jogo?	Vi. / Vi, sim. / Não vi.
Vocês foram à praia?	Fomos. / Fomos, sim. / Não fomos.
Ela já chegou?	Já. / Já chegou. / Ainda não.
Você comeu?	Comi. / Ainda não comi.

Two useful sentences for conversation: **Como foi o seu dia?** (How was your day?) and **Foi ótimo!** / **Foi bom.** / **Foi mais ou menos.** (It was great / good / so-so). Notice that these use **ser** in the simple past: **foi**.

10.7 A few verbs worth meeting in the past

Some verbs are used in the simple past with a nuance you should learn early.

- **Ter** in the past often means *to have* in the sense of *to experience*: **Tive uma ideia** (I had an idea), **Tive febre** (I had a fever), **Não tive tempo** (I did not have time). With **que**, it means *had to*: **Tive que sair cedo** (I had to leave early).
- **Estar** in the past means *was in a place and went away*: **Estive em Lisboa em março** (I was in Lisbon in March). To say *I stayed at home*, Brazilians prefer **ficar**: **Fiquei em casa**.
- **Ficar** also means *to become*, and in the past it is very frequent: **Fiquei cansado** (I got tired), **Fiquei com fome** (I got hungry), **Ela ficou feliz** (she became happy).
- **Fazer** can be used for time: **Fez frio ontem** (it was cold yesterday).

10.8 What about "tenho comido"?

Portuguese has a second form that looks like the English present perfect: **ter** in the present plus the past participle: **tenho comido**, **tenho trabalhado**. It is not the translation of *I have eaten*. It means that something has been happening **repeatedly over a period up to now**: **Tenho trabalhado muito** (I have been working a lot lately). You will meet it in reading. For now, remember that the English *I have eaten / seen / been* is simply the simple past: **comi, vi, fui**.

10.9 Putting it together

Read this paragraph aloud, then answer the question.

> No ano passado eu fiz uma viagem inesquecível. Cheguei ao Rio de Janeiro numa segunda-feira de manhã e fiquei num hostel em Santa Teresa. No primeiro dia eu andei pelo centro e conheci uma garota argentina. Nós almoçamos juntas e depois fomos ao Pão de Açúcar. No terceiro dia choveu muito, então a gente ficou no hostel e jogou cartas. Na sexta-feira eu voltei para casa. Gostei muito de tudo, mas não vi o Cristo Redentor! Por isso, vou voltar.

Translation: *Last year I took an unforgettable trip. I arrived in Rio de Janeiro on a Monday morning and stayed in a hostel in Santa Teresa. On the first day I walked around downtown and met an Argentine girl. We had lunch together and then*

went to Sugarloaf. On the third day it rained a lot, so we stayed at the hostel and played cards. On Friday I went back home. I liked everything very much, but I did not see Christ the Redeemer! So, I am going to go back.

Find the three irregular verbs. (They are **fiz**, **fomos** and **vi**.)

New words: **inesquecível** `ee-nehs-keh-SEE-veh-oo`, **viagem** `vee-AH-zheh~ee`, **a garota** `ah gah-RAW-tah` (girl), **chover** `shoh-VER` (to rain), **jogar cartas** `zhoh-GAR KAR-tahss` (to play cards).

10.10 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Ontem eu falo com ele.~~	**Ontem eu falei com ele.**	**ontem** needs the past tense
~~Eu fazi o trabalho.~~	**Eu fiz o trabalho.**	**fazer** is irregular in the past
~~Ele disseu que sim.~~	**Ele disse que sim.**	**disse** is irregular
~~Eu chegei às dez.~~	**Eu cheguei às dez.**	**-gar** verbs need **-gu-** in the **eu** form
~~Eu ficei em casa.~~	**Eu fiquei em casa.**	**-car** verbs need **-qu-**
~~Nós comeu muito.~~	**Nós comemos muito.**	the ending must match the person
~~Você fui à festa?~~	**Você foi à festa?**	**fui** is only for **eu**
~~Ele vim ontem.~~	**Ele veio ontem.**	**vim** is **eu**; **veio** is **ele**
~~Você fez ir à festa? (for *Did you go?*)~~	**Você foi à festa?**	no helper verb in Portuguese
~~Eu tenho ido ao Brasil duas vezes.~~	**Eu já fui ao Brasil duas vezes.**	the English "have been" is the simple past
~~Eu morei aqui há três anos. (still living here)~~	**Moro aqui há três anos.**	a situation that continues takes the present + **há**
~~Eles falam ontem.~~	**Eles falaram ontem.**	the plural past ends in **-aram**, with the stress on the second-to-last syllable

10.11 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: REGULAR VERBS

Write the form in the simple past.

1. falar, eu
2. comer, você
3. abrir, ela
4. chegar, eu
5. almoçar, nós
6. beber, eles
7. começar, eu

8. ficar, eu

PRACTICE · PART B: IRREGULAR VERBS

Write the form in the simple past.

1. ir, eu

2. ter, você

3. fazer, eu

4. dizer, ela

5. ver, eles

6. vir, ele

7. dar, eu

8. Is **foi** from **ser** or **ir**? **Ele foi ao médico.**

9. Is **foi** from **ser** or **ir**? **O filme foi ótimo.**

PRACTICE · PART C: WHICH TENSE? WHAT MARKER?

Choose the correct form, or translate.

1. Ontem eu (a) como (b) comi muito.

2. Todo dia eu (a) como (b) comi arroz.

3. Nós (a) chegamos (b) chegam ontem às dez.

4. Say: *I have never been to Japan.*

5. Say: *I already ate.*

6. Say: *I haven't eaten yet.*

7. Say: *She arrived two weeks ago.* (use **há**)

PRACTICE · PART D: ASK AND ANSWER

1. Ask: *Where did you (você) go?* (use **para onde**)

2. Ask: *What did you do yesterday?*

3. Answer yes, with only the verb: **Você viu o jogo?**

4. Answer no, for both of you: **Vocês foram à festa?**

PRACTICE · PART E: CORRECT AND WRITE

1. Correct: **Ontem eu vou ao cinema.**

2. Correct: **Eu fazi o trabalho.**

3. Correct: **Ele disseu que sim.**

4. Write five sentences about last weekend. Use at least two irregular verbs and one time marker.

ANSWER KEY

1. **falei**.
2. **comeu**.
3. **abriu**.
4. **cheguei**: **-gar → -guei**.
5. **almoçamos**: the same as the present, so the time marker decides.
6. **beberam**.
7. **comecei**: **-çar → -cei**.
8. **fiquei**: **-car → -quei**.
9. **fui**.
10. **teve**.
11. **fiz**.
12. **disse**.
13. **viram**.
14. **veio**.
15. **dei**.
16. **ir**: a place follows.
17. **ser**: an adjective follows.
18. (b) **comi**: **ontem** needs the past.
19. (a) **como**: **todo dia** is a habit; in this lesson, habits use the present.
20. (a) **chegamos**: (b) is the wrong person.
21. **Nunca fui ao Japão.**
22. **Já comi.**
23. **Ainda não comi.**
24. **Ela chegou há duas semanas.**
25. **Para onde você foi?**
26. **O que você fez ontem?**
27. **Vi.** or **Vi, sim.**
28. **Não fomos.**
29. **Ontem eu fui ao cinema.**
30. **Eu fiz o trabalho.**
31. **Ele disse que sim.**
32. Check the tense endings and that you used **fui, fiz, vi**-type forms correctly. A model: **No sábado eu fui ao cinema. Vi um filme brasileiro. No domingo fiz o almoço e li um livro.**

10.12 Return

Before you go on, answer from earlier lessons, without looking:

1. How do you say *he lives in Rio* and *they live in Rio*? (Lesson 4)
2. How do you say *I am going to travel next week*? (Lesson 9)
3. How do you say the date *March 8th*? (Lesson 6)

Model answers: 1. **Ele mora no Rio. / Eles moram no Rio.** 2. **Vou viajar na semana que vem.** 3. **oito de março** (in Brazil the day comes first, and the cardinal number is used for all days except the first, **primeiro de março**).

Come back to Part A and Part B after one day, three days, a week and two weeks, and say the forms aloud.

10.13 Pocket summary: Lesson 10

POCKET SUMMARY

- **No helper verb:** Você foi? / Não fui. The same tense covers the English simple past and present perfect (Já comi).
- **Regular endings:** -ar: -ei, -ou, -amos, -aram; -er: -i, -eu, -emos, -eram; -ir: -i, -iu, -imos, -iram. The stress is on the ending: fala / falou, falam / falaram.
- **Nós:** same form as the present for regular verbs. **A gente** takes the third-person singular.
- **Spelling in eu:** -car → fiquei, -gar → cheguei, -çar → comecei.
- **Ser and ir are identical:** fui, foi, fomos, foram. A place = ir; a noun or adjective = ser.
- **New stem:** tive, estive, fiz, disse, pude/pôde, quis, soube, pus/pôs, trouxe. **Others:** vi/viu, vim/veio, dei/deu, li/leu.
- **Markers:** ontem, semana passada, no ano passado, em 2019, uma vez, de repente, já, ainda não, nunca. **Ago:** há dois anos, dois anos atrás, faz dois anos.
- **Still true now:** present + há: Moro aqui há três anos.
- **Short answers repeat the verb:** Vi. / Fomos. / Ainda não.

10.14 What comes next

You can now tell what happened. In Lesson 11 you learn the second past tense, the imperfect (era, tinha, falava), which says what things were like, what you used to do and what was going on, and you learn when to choose it over the simple past.

LESSON 11

The imperfect, and choosing between the two pasts

By the end of this lesson you can describe how things used to be, say what was happening when something else happened, say how you felt at a moment in the past, and choose the right past tense by asking one question: is this an event in the story, or the background to the story?

11.1 A scene you will live

Your neighbor Seu Antônio, who is seventy-two, sits in front of the building every afternoon. Today you stop and ask him about his childhood.

> **Emma:** Seu Antônio, como era a sua infância? **Seu Antônio:** Ah, eu morava numa fazenda em Minas. A casa era pequena, mas tinha um quintal enorme. Todo dia eu acordava às cinco e ajudava meu pai. **Emma:** E o senhor gostava? **Seu Antônio:** Gostava! Mas um dia, eu tinha dez anos, caí do cavalo e quebrei o braço. Que susto! **Emma:** Nossa! E o senhor estava com medo? **Seu Antônio:** Estava, claro. Mas no dia seguinte eu já estava de novo no cavalo.

Translation: *Seu Antônio, what was your childhood like? / Ah, I lived on a farm in Minas. The house was small, but it had an enormous backyard. Every day I woke up at five and helped my father. / And did you like it? / I did! But one day, when I was ten, I fell off the horse and broke my arm. What a scare! / Wow! And were you afraid? / Yes, of course. But the next day I was already on the horse again.*

Count the verbs. Most of them end in **-ava** or are forms like **era** and **tinha**: **morava**, **era**, **tinha**, **acordava**, **ajudava**, **gostava**, **estava**. They describe the **setting**: where he lived, what the house was like, what he did every day, how old he was. Only two verbs are different: **caí** and **quebrei**. They are the **events** of the story: the fall and the broken arm.

This is the central idea of the lesson, and the rest follows from it.

New words from the scene:

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
a infância	ah ee~-FAH~-see-ah	childhood
a fazenda	ah fah-ZEH~-dah	farm, ranch
o quintal	oo kee~-TAH-oo	backyard
enorme	eh-NAWR-mee	enormous
o cavalo	oo kah-VAH-loo	horse

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
o braço	oo BRAH-soo	arm
cair	kah-EER	to fall
quebrar	keh-BRAR	to break
o susto	oo SOOS-too	scare, fright
o senhor, a senhora	oo seh-NYOR, ah seh-NYAW-rah	you (polite, for an older or respected person)

11.2 The trap: English has three ways to say it, Portuguese has one tense and a choice

Look at what English does with *to live* in the past:

ENGLISH	WHAT IT MEANS
I lived in Rio.	a period, probably over
I used to live in Rio.	a former state or habit
I was living in Rio when…	in progress at a moment
I would go to the beach every summer.	a repeated habit

English separates these with **different structures**: *used to*, *would*, *was -ing*. Portuguese uses **one tense** for the last three, the imperfect, and keeps the simple past from Lesson 10 for the first.

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE
I used to live in Rio.	Eu morava no Rio.
I was living in Rio.	Eu morava no Rio. / Eu estava morando no Rio.
I would go to the beach every summer.	Eu ia à praia todo verão.
I lived in Rio for two years.	Eu morei no Rio por dois anos.

The second trap is the other way round. Where English uses one past for two ideas, Portuguese forces you to choose. *I lived in Rio* can be the background of a story or a closed chapter of your life. Portuguese has **eu morava no Rio** and **eu morei no Rio**, and they are not the same sentence. That is why this lesson is the most important one of the past tenses: it is not about forms, it is about **point of view**.

HOW IT COMPARES

THE SIMPLE PAST (LESSON 10)	THE IMPERFECT (THIS LESSON)
a camera photograph: the event happened and is complete	a film in progress: the situation, with no start and no end in view
what happened	*what it was like / what used to happen / what was going on*
fiz, comi, fui	fazia, comia, ia

11.3 The forms: easy, and almost without exceptions

Take the infinitive, remove **-ar**, **-er** or **-ir**, and add the endings.

PERSON	-AR: FALAR	-ER: COMER	-IR: ABRIR
eu	falava fah-LAH-vah	comia koh-MEE-ah	abria ah-BREE-ah
você, ele, ela, a gente	falava	comia	abria
nós	falávamos fah-LAH-vah-mooss	comíamos koh-MEE-ah-mooss	abríamos ah-BREE-ah-mooss

PERSON	-AR: FALAR	-ER: COMER	-IR: ABRIR
vocês, eles, elas	falavam fah-LAH-vah~oo	comiam koh-MEE-ah~oo	abriam ah-BREE-ah~oo

The pattern is simple: **-ava** for **-ar** verbs, **-ia** for **-er** and **-ir** verbs. The **eu** form and the **você/ele/ela** form are **identical**, so when it matters, say the pronoun: **eu morava**, **ela morava**. The **nós** form carries an accent on the syllable before the ending (**falávamos**, **comíamos**). With **a gente**, use the singular form: **a gente morava**.

Good news: there are no spelling changes (nothing like **fiquei** or **cheguei** here), and almost no irregular verbs. **Only four verbs are irregular** in the imperfect:

INFINITIVE	EU, VOCÊ, ELE, ELA	NÓS	ELES
ser	era EH-rah	éramos EH-rah-mooss	eram EH-rah~oo
ter	tinha TCHEE-nyah	tínhamos TCHEE-nyah-mooss	tinham TCHEE-nyah~oo
vir	vinha VEE-nyah	vínhamos VEE-nyah-mooss	vinham VEE-nyah~oo
pôr	punha POO-nyah	púnhamos POO-nyah-mooss	punham POO-nyah~oo

Everything else is regular. This includes verbs that are very irregular in the simple past:

- **ir** is regular: **ia** EE-ah, **íamos**, **iam**
- **ver** is regular: **via** VEE-ah
- **fazer** is regular: **fazia** fah-ZEE-ah
- **dizer** is regular: **dizia** djee-ZEE-ah
- **poder**: **podia**; **querer**: **queria**; **saber**: **sabia**; **estar**: **estava** ehs-TAH-vah

> TIP
>
> Learn first the forms you will use for describing: **era**, **tinha**, **estava**, **ia**, **fazia**. They give you almost every description of the past. If you know these five, you can already say *it was late*, *I was ten*, *I was tired*, *I was going to*, *it was cold*.

11.4 What the imperfect does

Five uses cover nearly everything. Each one follows from the idea of the background.

1 **Describe people, things, time and weather in the past**

The imperfect paints the scene.

- **Era tarde e fazia frio.** (It was late and it was cold.)
- **A casa era pequena e tinha um quintal enorme.** (The house was small and had a huge backyard.)
- **Eu tinha dez anos.** (I was ten years old.) Age uses **ter**, as in Lesson 2.
- **Ela era muito simpática.** (She was very nice.)
- **Eram quatro horas.** (It was four o'clock.) Notice that the plural **eram** matches **horas**, as **são** does in the present.

2 Talk about habits and repeated actions in the past

Whatever you did regularly, you did in the imperfect. English often uses *used to* or *would*.

- **Todo domingo a gente almoçava na casa da minha avó.** (Every Sunday we had lunch at my grandmother's house.)
- **Eu jogava futebol com os meus primos.** (I used to play football with my cousins.)
- **Naquela época, a gente não tinha celular.** (In those days we did not have mobile phones.)

You can also use **costumar** kohs-too-MAR (to usually do, to be in the habit of) in the imperfect, followed by an infinitive: **Eu costumava acordar cedo** (I used to wake up early).

3 Say what was going on when something happened

The imperfect, or **estar** in the imperfect + gerund (Lesson 9), tells what was in progress. A short event interrupts it, and that event is in the simple past.

- **Eu estava saindo quando o telefone tocou.** (I was leaving when the phone rang.)
- **Ela dormia quando você chegou.** (She was asleep when you arrived.)
- **Estava chovendo quando saímos.** (It was raining when we left.)

Both **eu saía** and **eu estava saindo** are possible for the first part. The **estar** version is more common in everyday speech to say *in progress at that moment*.

4 Report what someone said or thought

In reported speech, the tense moves back, as in English, and the imperfect is the natural choice.

- **Ela disse que estava cansada.** (She said she was tired.)
- **Ele falou que ia chegar tarde.** (He said he was going to be late.)
- **Eu achava que você morava em São Paulo.** (I thought you lived in São Paulo.)

5 Be polite or soften a request

The imperfect of some verbs is used in the present to sound gentler. **Eu queria um café** means *I'd like a coffee*, not "I wanted". **Você podia me ajudar?** is *could you help me?* This use returns in Lesson 13.

"He was" and "he was with": estava and estava com

Feelings and physical states are background, so they use the imperfect, and Portuguese has two structures for them.

STRUCTURE	EXAMPLE	MEANING
estar + adjective	**Ele estava cansado.**	He was tired.
estar com + noun	**Ele estava com fome.**	He was hungry.
	Eu estava com sono.	I was sleepy.
	Nós estávamos com frio.	We were cold.
	Ela estava com medo.	She was afraid.
	Eu estava com dor de cabeça.	I had a headache.

The same words in other tenses show the contrast:

TENSE	EXAMPLE	WHAT IT SAYS
present	**Estou com fome.**	I am hungry (now)
imperfect	**Eu estava com fome.**	I was hungry (state in the past)
simple past	**Eu fiquei com fome.**	I became hungry (the change, the event)

With feelings, English says *I was afraid*, and that is always a state. Portuguese needs to know whether you mean "I was afraid" (**estava com medo**) or "I got scared" (**fiquei com medo**). Seu Antônio said **estava com medo** because he was describing his condition when he fell. If something had frightened him suddenly, he would have said **fiquei com medo**.

Brazilians also say **ter fome**, **ter sono**, **ter medo**, but **estar com** is the most common in conversation, so use it.

11.5 Choosing between the two pasts

Here is the method. For every verb in the past, ask one question.

1 **Is this a step in the story, or the setting?**

- A **step in the story** (something happened, changed the situation, and is complete): simple past. *First I woke up. Then the phone rang. Then I went out.*
- The **setting** (a state, a habit, a description, something that was in progress): imperfect. *It was raining. I was tired. I used to work there.*

2 **Use the time words as a clue, not as a rule**

Time words help you, but the point of view decides.

USUALLY THE IMPERFECT	USUALLY THE SIMPLE PAST
sempre	ontem
todo dia, toda semana	de repente
às vezes	uma vez, duas vezes
naquela época, antigamente (in the old days)	na sexta-feira, em 2019
quando eu era criança	por dois anos, o dia todo (a closed period)
enquanto (while)	então, depois

3 **Put the two together in one sentence**

A story alternates: one thing in progress, then an event.

- **Eu morava no Rio quando conheci a Clara.** (I was living in Rio when I met Clara.)
- **Estava calor, então a gente foi à praia.** (It was hot, so we went to the beach.)
- **Eu andava pela rua quando vi um acidente.** (I was walking down the street when I saw an accident.)

The same verb, two meanings

The same verb in the two tenses can give two different sentences. This is where you see the choice most clearly.

IMPERFECT	SIMPLE PAST
Eu morava no Rio. I lived in Rio (a situation, the period is open)	**Eu morei no Rio por dois anos.** I lived in Rio for two years (a closed period)
Ela estudava inglês. She was studying / used to study English	**Ela estudou inglês e passou no exame.** She studied English and passed the exam
Chovia. It was raining (background)	**Choveu.** It rained (the event: "it rained yesterday")
Eu tinha uma bicicleta. I had a bike (a possession)	**Eu tive uma ideia.** I had an idea (a moment)

Four verbs change their meaning

Here the choice is not nuance: it is a different translation. Learn these four pairs by heart.

VERB	IMPERFECT	SIMPLE PAST
saber	**Eu sabia a verdade.** I knew the truth.	**Eu soube da notícia ontem.** I found out the news yesterday.
conhecer	**Eu conhecia a Marina.** I knew Marina.	**Eu conheci a Marina no Rio.** I met Marina in Rio.
querer	**Eu queria ir.** I wanted to go. (a wish; maybe I did not)	**Eu quis ir.** I made up my mind to go. **Eu não quis ir.** I refused to go.
poder	**Eu podia ir.** I was able to go / I could go. (it was possible)	**Eu pude ir.** I managed to go. **Eu não pude ir.** I could not go (and did not).

A very common combination is **Eu queria ir, mas não pude** (I wanted to go, but I could not): the wish in the imperfect, the result in the simple past.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **Do not use the simple past for a description just because the thing is finished.** English speakers say *The house was small* and think "it is past, finished", so they use the simple past: ~~A casa foi pequena~~. Portuguese uses the simple past only when the sentence tells a **complete event**. A description is a state, so: **A casa era pequena**.

11.6 For recognition: the past before the past

Sometimes you need to say that something had already happened before another past event: *When I arrived, Clara had already left.* English uses *had left.* Portuguese has a one-word form for it (the **mais-que-perfeito**, saíra), but it is used only in literary writing. In speech, Brazilians use the imperfect of **ter** + the past participle:

PERSON	TER (IMPERFECT)	PARTICIPLE
eu, ele, ela, você	tinha	falado, comido, aberto
nós	tínhamos	
eles	tinham	

- **Quando eu cheguei, a Clara já tinha saído.** (When I arrived, Clara had already left.)
- **Eu já tinha visto esse filme.** (I had already seen that film.)
- **Eles não tinham comido nada.** (They had not eaten anything.)

The participle is built from the stem + **-ado** for **-ar** verbs and **-ido** for **-er** and **-ir** verbs: **falado**, **comido**, **saído**. A few common verbs are irregular:

INFINITIVE	PARTICIPLE
fazer	feito FAY-too
dizer	dito DJEE-too
ver	visto VEES-too
escrever	escrito ehs-KREE-too
abrir	aberto ah-BEHR-too
pôr	posto POHS-too
vir	vindo VEE~-doo

At this level, you only need to **recognize tinha + participle**. If you cannot use it yet, two simple pasts and **já** will get your meaning across.

11.7 Telling a story: a model

A story needs both. This is how a short anecdote looks. Read it aloud and underline the verbs in the imperfect (setting) and in the simple past (events).

> Era uma sexta-feira à noite e eu estava voltando do trabalho. Chovia muito e eu não tinha guarda-chuva. De repente, um ônibus passou e molhou toda a minha roupa. Eu fiquei com muita raiva, mas depois comecei a rir. Quando cheguei em casa, a Clara me viu e perguntou: "O que aconteceu?" Eu respondi: "Nada, só fui tomar um banho de graça!"

Translation: *It was a Friday night and I was coming back from work. It was raining hard and I did not have an umbrella. Suddenly, a bus went by and soaked all my clothes. I got really angry, but then I started to laugh. When I got home, Clara saw me and asked: "What happened?" I answered: "Nothing, I just took a free shower!"*

The scene is set with **era**, **estava voltando**, **chovia**, **não tinha**. The events follow in order: **passou**, **molhou**, **fiquei**, **comecei**, **cheguei**, **viu**, **perguntou**, **respondi**, **fui**. Notice **fiquei com raiva** ("I got angry"), a change of state, and **aconteceu**, the simple past in a question about an event.

New words: **molhar** moh-LYAR (to wet), **a roupa** ah HOH-pah (clothes), **a raiva** ah HIE-vah (anger), **rir** heer (to laugh), **acontecer** ah-koh~-teh-SER (to happen), **de graça** djee GRAH-sah (for free).

A starter for stories

Era uma vez EH-rah OO-mah vehss is "once upon a time", and it is followed by the imperfect. In a casual anecdote, the starters are **Uma vez eu…** (once I…) and **Outro dia eu…** (the other day I…).

11.8 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~A casa foi pequena.~~	**A casa era pequena.**	a description is a state, so the imperfect
~~Quando eu fui criança, eu…~~	**Quando eu era criança, eu…**	"when I was a child" describes a period of life
~~Todo verão eu fui à praia.~~	**Todo verão eu ia à praia.**	a repeated habit in the past
~~Eu estava dez anos.~~	**Eu tinha dez anos.**	age uses **ter**
~~Ele fazia um bolo ontem e saiu.~~	**Ele fez um bolo ontem e saiu.**	completed events in a chain need the simple past
~~Eu sabi a resposta.~~	**Eu sabia a resposta.**	**-er** imperfect ends in **-ia**
~~Nós falavamos.~~	**Nós falávamos.**	the **nós** form carries an accent
~~Eu conhecia a Marina no Rio. (meaning: I met her there)~~	**Eu conheci a Marina no Rio.**	"met" is the simple past of **conhecer**

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu não podia ir à festa ontem. (meaning: I tried and could not)~~	**Eu não pude ir à festa ontem.**	a specific attempt with a specific result: simple past
~~Eu estava com medo quando o cachorro latiu. (meaning: I got a fright)~~	**Fiquei com medo quando o cachorro latiu.**	a sudden change is an event
~~Quando ele chegou, eu cozinhei. (meaning: I was cooking)~~	**Quando ele chegou, eu estava cozinhando.**	something in progress when the other event happened

11.9 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: THE FORMS

Write the imperfect.

1. falar, eu

2. comer, nós

3. abrir, eles

4. ser, você

5. ter, nós

6. ir, a gente

7. vir, eu

8. fazer, ele

9. ver, eu

PRACTICE · PART B: IMPERFECT OR SIMPLE PAST?

Choose the form that fits the story.

1. Quando eu (a) era (b) fui criança, morava no interior.

2. De repente, o telefone (a) tocava (b) tocou.

3. Todo domingo a gente (a) almoçou (b) almoçava na casa da minha avó.

4. Ontem à noite eu (a) saía (b) saí com a Clara.

5. Eu (a) tinha (b) tive dez anos quando a gente se mudou.

6. Quando eu cheguei, ele já (a) dormia (b) dormiu. (He was already asleep.)

7. Na semana passada eu (a) fazia (b) fiz um curso de culinária.

PRACTICE · PART C: VERBS THAT CHANGE MEANING

Choose or translate.

1. Eu soube da notícia ontem. (a) I knew it. (b) I found out.

2. **Eu conhecia a Marina desde criança.** (a) I met her. (b) I knew her.

3. **Eu não quis ir.** (a) I wanted to go but could not. (b) I refused to go.

4. Translate: *I wanted to go, but I could not.*

5. Translate: *I did not know that.*

PRACTICE · PART D: ESTAVA, ESTAVA COM

Complete.

1. **Ontem ela ___ cansada.**

2. **Eu ___ com fome quando você ligou.**

3. **Eles ___ com sono.**

4. **Fiquei com medo** means: (a) I was afraid, a state. (b) I became afraid, an event.

PRACTICE · PART E: CORRECT AND TELL

1. Correct: **Quando eu era criança, eu fui à praia todo verão.**

2. Correct: **Eu tinha uma ideia de repente.**

3. Rewrite without the progressive: **Eu estava dormindo quando você ligou.**

4. Report what she said: **Ela disse: "Estou cansada." → Ela disse que ___.**

5. Write five sentences about your childhood. Use at least three imperfect verbs and one event in the simple past.

6. Complete with **tinha** + participle: **Quando cheguei, a Clara já ___ (sair).**

ANSWER KEY

1. **falava**.
2. **comíamos**: the accent on **í**.
3. **abriam**.
4. **era**.
5. **tínhamos**.
6. **ia**: **ir** is regular in the imperfect.
7. **vinha**.
8. **fazia**.
9. **via**.
10. (a) **era**: "when I was a child" is a state.
11. (b) **tocou**: a sudden event.
12. (b) **almoçava**: "every Sunday" is a habit.
13. (b) **saí**: one outing last night.
14. (a) **tinha**: age is a state.
15. (a) **dormia**: he was already asleep. **Dormiu** would mean he fell asleep.
16. (b) **fiz**: one course, completed.
17. (b).
18. (b).
19. (b).
20. **Eu queria ir, mas não pude.**
21. **Eu não sabia disso.** (Or **Eu não sabia.**)
22. **estava**.
23. **estava**.
24. **estavam**.
25. (b).
26. **Quando eu era criança, eu ia à praia todo verão.**
27. **Eu tive uma ideia de repente.**
28. **Eu dormia quando você ligou.**
29. **Ela disse que estava cansada.**
30. Check that the habits and descriptions are in the imperfect and the single event is in the simple past. A model: **Quando eu era criança, morava numa cidade pequena. A gente tinha um cachorro. Todo dia eu brincava na rua. Um dia, eu caí da bicicleta.**
31. **tinha saído**.

11.10 Return

Before you go on, answer from earlier lessons, without looking:

1. How do you say *I got up at seven* in the simple past? (Lesson 10; you can use **levantar** with or without **me**, Lesson 9)
2. Give three forms of the irregular past of **fazer**. (Lesson 10)
3. How do you say *I am hungry* in the present? (Lesson 5)

Model answers: 1. **Eu me levantei às sete.** / **Levantei às sete.** 2. **fiz, fez, fizeram**. 3. **Estou com fome.** / **Tenho fome.**

Come back to Part B after one day, three days, a week and two weeks, and say each sentence aloud.

11.11 Pocket summary: Lesson 11

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Forms:** -ar → -ava; -er, -ir → -ia. Nós: falávamos, comíamos. Eu = você = ele: say the pronoun when it matters.
- **Only four irregular verbs:** era, tinha, vinha, punha. Ir (ia), ver (via), fazer (fazia), dizer (dizia) are regular.
- **Uses:** description (era tarde, tinha dez anos); habit (todo dia eu acordava); in progress (estava saindo); reported speech (disse que ia); politeness (queria um café).
- **Feelings:** estava cansado, estava com fome. A change: fiquei com fome.
- **Choose:** event in the story → simple past; setting, habit, state → imperfect.
- **Four verbs change meaning:** sabia / soube, conhecia / conheci, queria / quis, podia / pude.
- **Past before past (recognition):** tinha + participle: já tinha saído.
- **Starters:** Era uma vez..., Quando eu era criança..., Naquela época...

11.12 What comes next

You can now describe and narrate. In Lesson 12 you learn the small words that make Portuguese sound natural: me, te, o, a and the way Brazilians place them. Ela me viu, eu te ligo, vi ele, me ajuda? are heard in every conversation.

LESSON 12

Object pronouns and where Brazilians put them

By the end of this lesson you can say “he called me”, “I will call you”, “I saw him” and “I gave it to her” the way Brazilians say them, put the little pronouns in the right place, ask “can you help me?”, and recognize the written forms you will meet in books, e-mails and signs.

12.1 A scene you will live

Saturday afternoon. You and Clara are organizing a small party and you are texting and talking at the same time.

> **Clara:** Emma, você viu o Rafael? **Emma:** Vi ele ontem. Ele me ligou, mas eu não atendi. **Clara:** Me ajuda aqui? Eu preciso de alguém pra me dar uma mão. **Emma:** Claro. Eu te ligo mais tarde. Você já chamou a Marina? **Clara:** Chamei ela, sim. Ela me falou que vai trazer o bolo. Vou te mandar a lista.

Translation: *Emma, did you see Rafael? / I saw him yesterday. He called me, but I did not answer. / Can you help me here? I need someone to give me a hand. / Of course. I will call you later. Have you already invited Marina? / I did, yes. She told me she is going to bring the cake. I will send you the list.*

Every sentence contains a small pronoun, and every one of them stands in a place where English would not put it: **ele me ligou**, **me ajuda**, **pra me dar**, **eu te ligo**, **ela me falou**, **vou te mandar**. In one case there is a pronoun that is not small at all: **vi ele**, **chamei ela**. This lesson explains the pattern, so that you can do it automatically.

New words from the scene:

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
atender	ah-teh~-DER	to answer (a phone, a door); to serve (a customer)
ajudar	ah-zhoo-DAR	to help
a mão	ah mow~	the hand
chamar	shah-MAR	to call; to invite (informal)
falar	fah-LAR	to speak, to tell
trazer	trah-ZER	to bring
mandar	mah~-DAR	to send
a lista	ah LEES-tah	the list

12.2 The trap: English puts “it” and “him” after the verb, Portuguese puts “me” and “you” before it

In English, the object stays behind the verb whatever it is: *He called me. I saw him. She gave it to us.* In Portuguese, the object pronouns of the first and second person go **before** the verb: **Ele me ligou**, **Eu te vi**, **Ela nos deu**. This is not a trick of poetry: it is how the language sounds all day.

Two other differences hit English speakers hard.

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE	WHAT IS DIFFERENT
I saw him / her / them.	**Vi ele.** / **Vi ela.** / **Vi eles.**	in speech, the object for *him, her, them* is often the subject pronoun, placed after the verb
Did you buy the bread? Yes, I bought it.	**Você comprou o pão? — Comprei.**	“it” often disappears: the verb is enough
Give me the keys.	**Me dá as chaves.**	the pronoun starts the sentence in speech
to me, for me	**pra mim**	after a preposition, “me” is **mim**

None of this is “bad Portuguese”. It is the spoken standard of educated Brazilians. Writing and formal speech have a more traditional set of forms, and you will learn them in this lesson too. They are not the ones you need first.

12.3 The pronouns: direct and indirect objects

What is a direct and an indirect object?

A **direct object** answers “whom? what?” without a preposition: *I saw (whom?) him*; **Vi o Rafael**. An **indirect object** answers “to whom? for whom?” and in Portuguese usually takes **a** or **para**: *I gave a book (to whom?) to her*; **Dei um livro à Clara**.

For the first person and the second person (tu), the same pronoun is used for both jobs.

PERSON	DIRECT AND INDIRECT	EXAMPLE
me	**me**	**Ele me viu.** (direct) / **Ele me deu um livro.** (indirect)
you (informal)	**te**	**Eu te vi.** / **Eu te dei um livro.**
us	**nos** (formal) / **a gente** (spoken)	**Ele nos viu.** / **Ele viu a gente.**

The third person (him, her, them) and the formal “you” are different, and the written norm and the spoken norm differ strongly. This is where the real choices are.

The big table

MEANING	WRITTEN, FORMAL	SPOKEN, EVERYDAY
me	**me**	**me**
you (informal, one person)	**te** (for **tu**); **o**, **a**, **lhe** (for **você**)	**te** or **você**
him, direct	**o**	**ele**
her, direct	**a**	**ela**
them, direct	**os**, **as**	**eles**, **elas**
to him / to her	**lhe**	**pra ele**, **pra ela**

MEANING	WRITTEN, FORMAL	SPOKEN, EVERYDAY
to them	lhes	pra eles, pra elas
us	nos	a gente
you (plural)	os, as, lhes	vocês

WATCH OUT

Te and você in the same speech. Strictly speaking, **te** belongs to **tu** and **o/a/lhe** belong to **você**. In everyday speech, in the south-east and in much of the country, people use **você** as the subject and **te** as the object, in the same sentence: **Você sabe que eu te amo**. Prescriptive grammar prefers consistency, but speakers of all backgrounds mix them, and you should too: **Eu te ligo** to a **você** friend is natural, and **lhe** is for formal writing and some formal service situations.

12.4 Where the pronoun goes in Brazilian speech

The rule is simple: **the pronoun goes before the verb it belongs to.**

1 **One verb: put the pronoun right before it**

- **Ele me ligou.** (He called me.)
- **Eu te vejo amanhã.** (I will see you tomorrow.)
- **Ela nos convidou.** (formal) / **Ela convidou a gente.** (She invited us.)
- **Você me conhece?** (Do you know me?)

2 **With a negative, put {{não}} first**

- **Ele não me ligou.** (He did not call me.)
- **Eu não te vi.** (I did not see you.)

3 **With two verbs, put the pronoun before the second one**

This is the pattern for **ir** + infinitive (Lesson 9), for **poder**, **querer**, **precisar** + infinitive (Lesson 7), and for the progressive.

- **Vou te ligar mais tarde.** (I will call you later.)
- **Quero te ver.** (I want to see you.)
- **Você pode me ajudar?** (Can you help me?)
- **Preciso te falar uma coisa.** (I need to tell you something.)
- **Estou te esperando.** (I am waiting for you.)
- **Ele tinha me avisado.** (He had warned me.)

4 **Start the sentence with the pronoun if you like**

In a conversation you will hear commands and requests that begin with the pronoun:

- **Me ajuda!** (Help me!)
- **Me dá um minuto.** (Give me a minute.)
- **Me liga depois.** (Call me later.)
- **Te vejo amanhã.** (See you tomorrow.)

Writing and formal speech in Brazil avoid starting a sentence with an unstressed pronoun. A formal text would say **Ajude-me**, **Dê-me** and **Ligue-me depois**, with the pronoun **after** the verb and joined to it by a hyphen. That is also the usual position in European Portuguese: **Disse-me**, **Vi-o**, **Telefono-te**.

HOW IT COMPARES

BRAZILIAN SPEECH	WRITING, FORMAL, EUROPEAN
Me ajuda!	**Ajude-me!**
Eu te vejo amanhã.	**Vejo-te amanhã.** (Portugal)
Ele me disse que sim.	**Disse-me que sim.** (Portugal)
Vou te ligar.	**Vou ligar-te.** / **Vou ligar-lhe.**

You need to **recognize** the hyphenated forms because you will see them on signs and in books, and you will hear a few of them in fixed phrases, even in Brazil:

- **Sente-se, por favor.** (Please sit down.)
- **Sinta-se em casa.** (Make yourself at home.)
- **Divirta-se!** (Have fun!)
- **Prazer em conhecê-lo.** / **Prazer em conhecê-la.** (Pleased to meet you; formal, to a man or a woman.)

12.5 Him, her, them: "vi ele" and "eu o vi"

This is the point where Brazilian Portuguese is most different from the textbooks, so let us be precise.

The traditional rule says that for a direct object in the third person you use **o**, **a**, **os**, **as**: **Eu o vi**, **Conheço-a**, **Chamei-os**. The subject pronouns **ele**, **ela**, **eles**, **elas** are the subject forms and should not be objects.

In everyday Brazilian speech, people say **Vi ele**, **Conheço ela**, **Chamei eles**, **Ajudei ela**. These are natural spoken forms, used by speakers of all social and educational levels. They are very frequent, and the traditional **o/a** forms sound formal or written. In formal writing, in an exam, or in a business e-mail, the traditional forms are expected.

1 Choose according to where you are

- **Chatting with friends, at home, in the street:** Vi ele ontem. Conheci ela no Rio. Chamei eles pra festa.
- **Writing a formal e-mail, a cover letter, an exam:** Eu o vi ontem. Conheci-a no Rio. Convidei-os para a festa.

2 **Remember the third way: drop the pronoun**

Brazilians often say nothing at all. If the object is obvious, the verb is enough. This is the most natural option, and it is also the one that avoids the whole question.

QUESTION	NATURAL ANSWER
Você viu o Rafael?	Vi. / Vi, sim.
Você comprou o pão?	Comprei.
Você gostou do filme?	Gostei. / Gostei muito.
Você leu o e-mail?	Li. / Ainda não li.
Você pegou as chaves?	Peguei.

English needs "it" (*I bought it*). Portuguese does not. If you say **Comprei ele** for a thing like bread, a Brazilian will understand, but it sounds odd; for things, drop the pronoun or repeat the noun: **Comprei o pão.**

3 **Keep {{ele}} and {{ela}} for people**

The spoken object pronoun is natural for people (**vi ele**). For things, use the verb alone or the noun.

12.6 To him, to her, to them: "dei pra ele"

For the indirect object in the third person, written Portuguese has **lhe** (singular) and **lhes** (plural): **Dei-lhe um livro**, **Disse-lhes a verdade**. These are very formal in Brazil. In speech, use **pra** + the pronoun:

FORMAL	EVERYDAY
Dei-lhe um presente.	Dei um presente pra ele. / Dei um presente pra ela.
Disse-lhes a verdade.	Falei a verdade pra eles.
Enviamos-lhe o contrato.	Mandei o contrato pra ele.

This works for any verb whose person receives the action: **dar** (to give), **dizer** (to say), **falar** (to tell), **mandar** and **enviar** (to send), **mostrar** (to show), **emprestar** (to lend), **entregar** (to hand over), **oferecer** (to offer), **perguntar** (to ask), **responder** (to answer), **escrever** (to write), **contar** (to tell a story), **pedir** (to ask for).

With the first person and with **te**, the pronoun comes before the verb as usual: **Ela me deu**, **Eu te mandei**, **Ele me falou**, **Ele te mostrou**.

Verbs with a person as direct object

Don't be confused by English. These verbs take a **direct** object in Portuguese:

VERB	EXAMPLE
ver	Eu te vi ontem.
conhecer	Conheço ela.
chamar	Chamei ele.
convidar	Vou te convidar.
ajudar	Posso te ajudar?
esperar	Estou te esperando.

VERB	EXAMPLE
buscar	**Te busco às cinco.** (I'll pick you up at five.)
amar	**Eu te amo.**

Notice **ajudar**: in English *help* takes a direct object too, so this is easy. In shops and call centers you may hear **Posso lhe ajudar?** even though grammars prefer **ajudá-lo**. Between friends, say **Posso te ajudar?**

> TIP
>
> For "call someone on the phone", Brazilians use **ligar para** or just a pronoun: **Vou ligar pra ele** or **Vou ligar pra você**. With **te**, the pronoun is enough: **Te ligo depois**. With **me**: **Ele me ligou**.

Recognizing -lo, -la in writing

When a written text puts **o** or **a** after an infinitive, you will see it fused to the verb: the final **-r** drops and the pronoun becomes **lo** or **la**, joined by a hyphen, with an accent on the vowel if needed.

WRITTEN	SPOKEN EQUIVALENT	MEANING
Vou vê-lo amanhã.	**Vou ver ele amanhã.**	I will see him tomorrow.
Quero conhecê-la.	**Quero conhecer ela.**	I want to meet her.
Posso ajudá-lo?	**Posso te ajudar?**	Can I help you?
Preciso fazê-lo hoje.	**Preciso fazer isso hoje.**	I need to do it today.

You do not need to produce these forms, and many Brazilians do not produce them in speech either. But you will meet them in contracts, instructions, news and literature, so read them as "the verb plus the person or thing it acts on".

Same idea, four registers

Here is one meaning, *I'll send it to you*, said in four ways. Seeing them side by side shows you how the system works.

REGISTER	SENTENCE
Spoken, friends	**Vou te mandar.** / **Te mando já.**
Spoken, neutral	**Vou mandar pra você.**
Formal written (Brazil)	**Vou enviar-lhe o documento.**
European Portuguese	**Vou enviar-te o documento.** / **Envio-lhe já.**

In conversation the first two are enough. A learner who chooses **Vou te mandar** will sound like a Brazilian in São Paulo, in Rio or in Belo Horizonte, and will be understood in every region.

12.7 After a preposition: mim and eu

After a preposition, the pronoun for "me" is **mim** `mee~`, not **me** and not **eu**. For the other persons the form is the same as the subject pronoun.

PERSON	AFTER A PREPOSITION	EXAMPLE
me	**mim**	**pra mim**, **de mim**, **sem mim**, **por mim**

PERSON	AFTER A PREPOSITION	EXAMPLE
you (informal)	**você** (or **ti** for **tu**)	**pra você**, **com você**
him / her	**ele** / **ela**	**pra ele**, **sem ela**
us	**nós** / **a gente**	**pra gente**, **sem a gente**
them	**eles** / **elas**	**com eles**

The preposition **com** fuses with the pronouns **mim**, **ti** and **nós**:

WITH…	FORM	GUIDE	EXAMPLE
me	**comigo**	koh-MEE-goo	**Vem comigo.** (Come with me.)
you (tu)	**contigo**	koh~-TCHEE-goo	**Quero falar contigo.**
you (você)	**com você**		**Quero falar com você.**
us	**conosco** / **com a gente**	koh-NOHS-koo	**Vem com a gente.** (Come with us.)

Para mim or para eu?

This is a classic Brazilian spelling and usage question, and the rule is clean.

- If the preposition is followed by **a pronoun alone**, use **mim**: **Isso é difícil para mim. Este presente é para mim.**
- If the preposition is followed by **a pronoun + a verb**, the pronoun is the **subject** of that verb, so use **eu**: **Trouxe um livro para eu ler. Isso é para eu fazer. Ele abriu a porta para eu entrar.**

You will hear many Brazilians say **para mim fazer** in conversation, but it is a mistake in the formal standard, and teachers correct it. Learn it the right way: **para eu fazer**.

12.8 What to say when you ask for something

Requests are where these pronouns work hardest. These are the sentences you will say every day.

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE OF THE NEW PART	MEANING
Me ajuda?		Can you help me? (informal, short)
Você pode me ajudar?		Can you help me?
Me dá um minuto.		Give me a minute.
Me passa o sal?		Can you pass me the salt?
Me empresta a caneta?	mee eh~-PREHS-tah ah kah-NEH-tah	Can you lend me the pen?
Me manda uma mensagem.	mee MAH~-dah OO-mah meh~-SAH-zheh~ee	Send me a message.
Me liga quando chegar.		Call me when you arrive.
Posso te ligar?		Can I call you?
Pode me dizer onde fica o banco?		Can you tell me where the bank is?

These imperatives come back in Lesson 13, where you will learn how to be more formal.

12.9 Putting it together

Read this exchange of messages aloud. Notice that each pronoun is placed before the verb it belongs to.

> **Clara:** Oi, Emma! Te liguei ontem, mas você não atendeu. **Emma:** Desculpa! Estava no ônibus e não ouvi o celular. Me liga agora? **Clara:** Posso te ligar daqui a pouco? Estou esperando o Rafael. **Emma:** Claro. Ele te ligou? **Clara:** Ligou, sim. Ele me disse que não vai poder vir. Eu avisei a Marina e ela me falou que vai trazer o bolo mesmo assim. **Emma:** Que bom! Eu te ajudo com a mesa. **Clara:** Obrigada! Vou te mandar a lista de compras.

Translation: *Hi, Emma! I called you yesterday, but you did not answer. / Sorry! I was on the bus and did not hear the phone. Can you call me now? / Can I call you in a little while? I am waiting for Rafael. / Of course. Did he call you? / He did, yes. He told me he will not be able to come. I told Marina and she told me she is going to bring the cake anyway. / Great! I will help you with the table. / Thanks! I will send you the shopping list.*

There is one spot to notice: **Te liguei** begins with the pronoun, as in spoken Brazilian, and the **-gar** spelling change from Lesson 10 appears in **liguei**. Notice also **avisei a Marina**: **avisar** takes the person as a direct object, like **ajudar**.

12.10 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu vou ligar te.~~	**Vou te ligar.**	the pronoun goes before the infinitive
~~Ele disse a mim.~~	**Ele me disse.**	the normal form is **me** before the verb; **a mim** is only for emphasis
~~Ele deu-me um livro. (in speech)~~	**Ele me deu um livro.**	in Brazilian speech the pronoun goes before the verb
~~Ela gosta de eu.~~	**Ela gosta de mim.**	after a preposition, "me" is **mim**
~~É para mim fazer.~~	**É para eu fazer.**	the pronoun is the subject of the verb that follows
~~Vem com mim.~~	**Vem comigo.**	**com** + **mim** fuse into **comigo**
~~Eu vi lhe ontem.~~	**Eu vi ele ontem.** / **Eu o vi ontem.**	**lhe** is the indirect object of a person, not a direct object
~~Dei ele um livro.~~	**Dei um livro pra ele.**	the third-person indirect object takes **pra**
~~Você comprou o pão? — Sim, comprei ele.~~	**Comprei.**	for things, drop the pronoun
~~Eu te amo você.~~	**Eu te amo.** / **Eu amo você.**	one pronoun is enough
~~Eu não conheço-a.~~	**Eu não a conheço.** / **Não conheço ela.**	even in the written style, the pronoun goes before the verb after **não**

12.11 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: PLACE THE PRONOUN

Rewrite the sentence with the pronoun in parentheses, in the spoken order.

1. **Ele ligou.** (me)

2. **Eu vejo amanhã.** (te)

3. **Você pode ajudar?** (me)

4. Vou ligar mais tarde. (te)

5. Ela está esperando. (me)

6. Ele não viu. (me)

7. Ela deu um presente. (me)

PRACTICE · PART B: DIRECT OBJECT IN THE THIRD PERSON

Replace the noun with the spoken pronoun, or drop the object when the question allows it.

1. Eu vi o Rafael.

2. Conheço a Marina.

3. Chamei os vizinhos.

4. Você comprou o pão? Answer: yes.

5. Você viu as chaves? Answer: no.

PRACTICE · PART C: TO HIM, TO HER, TO THEM

Change the indirect object to the everyday form with **pra**.

1. Dei um livro à Clara.

2. Mandei uma mensagem aos meus pais.

3. Ele mostrou a casa aos amigos.

4. Disse a verdade ao Rafael.

PRACTICE · PART D: MIM OR EU?

Complete.

1. Isso é difícil para ___.

2. Trouxe um livro para ___ ler.

3. Ela vai ___. (with me)

4. Sem ___ não vai ter festa.

5. Para ___, o melhor é ficar em casa.

PRACTICE · PART E: SAY IT

1. Translate: *Can you help me?*

2. Translate: *I will call you tomorrow.*

3. Translate: *She told me she was tired.*

4. Translate: *I saw them yesterday.* (in spoken Brazilian)

5. Correct: **Eu vi lhe ontem.**

6. Correct: **É para mim fazer.**

7. Write three short messages to a friend, using **me** in one and **te** in two.

ANSWER KEY

1. **Ele me ligou.**
2. **Eu te vejo amanhã.**
3. **Você pode me ajudar?**
4. **Vou te ligar mais tarde.**
5. **Ela está me esperando.**
6. **Ele não me viu.**
7. **Ela me deu um presente.**
8. **Vi ele.** (Formal: **Eu o vi.**)
9. **Conheço ela.** (Formal: **Conheço-a.**)
10. **Chamei eles.** (Formal: **Chamei-os.**)
11. **Comprei.**
12. **Não vi.**
13. **Dei um livro pra ela.**
14. **Mandei uma mensagem pra eles.**
15. **Ele mostrou a casa pra eles.**
16. **Disse a verdade pra ele.**
17. **mim**.
18. **eu**: **eu** is the subject of **ler**.
19. **comigo**: **Ela vai comigo.**
20. **mim**: **Sem mim não vai ter festa.**
21. **mim**: **Para mim, o melhor é ficar em casa.**
22. **Você pode me ajudar?** / **Me ajuda?**
23. **Eu te ligo amanhã.** / **Vou te ligar amanhã.**
24. **Ela me disse que estava cansada.** / **Ela me falou que estava cansada.**
25. **Vi eles ontem.** (Formal: **Eu os vi ontem.**)
26. **Eu vi ele ontem.** / **Eu o vi ontem.**
27. **É para eu fazer.**
28. Check that the pronoun comes before the verb. A model: **Me liga quando chegar. Te vejo amanhã. Vou te mandar a foto.**

12.12 Return

Before you go on, answer from earlier lessons, without looking:

1. What does **pra** stand for in speech? (Lesson 5)
2. Give the **eu** form of the simple past of **dar** and **ver**. (Lesson 10)
3. How do you say *her brother* so that it is not ambiguous? (Lesson 8)

Model answers: 1. **para**. 2. **dei, vi**. 3. **o irmão dela**.

Come back to Part A and Part E after one day, three days, a week and two weeks, and say each sentence aloud.

12.13 Pocket summary: Lesson 12

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Spoken placement:** the pronoun goes before the verb: **Ele me ligou**, **Eu te vejo**, **Não me viu**. With two verbs, before the second one: **Vou te ligar**, **Pode me ajudar?**, **Estou te esperando**.
- **Starting with the pronoun** is natural in speech: **Me ajuda! Me liga.** Writing and Portugal: **Ajude-me**, **Disse-me**, **Vi-o**.
- **Forms:** **me**, **te** (also for **você** in speech), **nos** (formal; spoken: **a gente**).
- **Him, her, them:** spoken **ele**, **ela**, **eles**, **elas**: **Vi ele**. Formal **o**, **a**, **os**, **as**: **Eu o vi**. Often best: drop it (**Vi.**). Things: no pronoun.
- **To him / her / them:** spoken **pra ele**, **pra ela**, **pra eles**; formal **lhe**, **lhes**.
- **After a preposition:** **mim** (**pra mim**, **sem mim**), **comigo**, **com você**, **com a gente**; but **para eu fazer**.
- **Fixed phrases with the pronoun after the verb:** **Sente-se**, **Sinta-se em casa**, **Divirta-se**, **Prazer em conhecê-lo/a**.

12.14 What comes next

In Lesson 13, the last one in this book, you put everything to use. You compare (**mais alto do que**), give instructions (**fale**, **vem cá**), ask politely (**poderia**, **queria**), choose between **por** and **para**, and join ideas with **que**. At the end there is a checkpoint, so that you can see what you can do in Portuguese now.

LESSON 13

Comparing, giving instructions, asking politely, por and para, and que

By the end of this lesson you can compare two things, give and understand a command or a direction, ask for something politely, choose between **por** and **para**, and join two ideas with **que**. At the end of the lesson you will find a checkpoint of twelve "I can…" statements for the whole book.

13.1 A scene you will live

On your last evening in Belo Horizonte you invite Clara to dinner. You arrive at a small restaurant on a street full of bars.

> **Garçom:** Boa noite! Querem sentar aqui dentro ou lá fora? **Emma:** Aqui dentro, por favor. Eu queria uma mesa pra dois. **Garçom:** Claro. Fiquem à vontade, podem sentar ali, na janela. **Emma:** Obrigada. Você poderia me recomendar um prato? **Garçom:** O peixe é melhor do que a carne hoje. É mais leve e é mais barato. É o prato que todo mundo pede. **Emma:** Então vou querer o peixe. Obrigada pela dica! **Garçom:** Imagina! Já trago o cardápio.

Translation: *Good evening! Would you like to sit inside or outside? / Inside, please. I'd like a table for two. / Of course. Make yourselves comfortable, you can sit over there, by the window. / Thank you. Could you recommend a dish? / The fish is better than the meat today. It is lighter and it is cheaper. It is the dish that everybody orders. / Then I'll have the fish. Thank you for the tip! / Don't mention it! I'll bring the menu right away.*

The scene contains the five tools of the lesson, all in a few lines. **Melhor do que** and **mais barato** compare. **Fiquem** is a command. **Eu queria** and **você poderia** are polite requests. **Pra dois** and **pela dica** are **para** and **por**. **O prato que todo mundo pede** uses the relative **que**.

New words from the scene:

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
o garçom	oo gar-SOH~	the waiter
lá fora	lah FAW-rah	outside
aqui dentro	ah-KEE DEH~-troo	inside
à vontade	ah voh~-TAH-djee	at ease, comfortable
recomendar	heh-koh-meh~-DAR	to recommend
o prato	oo PRAH-too	the dish, the plate

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
o peixe	oo PAY-shee	the fish
leve	LEH-vee	light
a dica	ah DJEE-kah	the tip, the hint
imagina	ee-mah-ZHEE-nah	don't mention it, no problem

13.2 Comparing

The trap: English changes the adjective, Portuguese adds a word

In English, short adjectives take *-er* (*cheaper, taller*) and long ones take *more* (*more expensive*). Portuguese has no *-er*. It puts **mais** (more) or **menos** (less) before **every** adjective, and then **do que** (than).

ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE
cheaper than	**mais barato do que**
taller than	**mais alto do que**
more expensive than	**mais caro do que**
less expensive than	**menos caro do que**

1 **Compare unequal things: {{mais}} / {{menos}} + adjective + {{do que}}**

- **O ônibus é mais barato do que o táxi.** (The bus is cheaper than the taxi.)
- **Belo Horizonte é menos quente do que Salvador.** (Belo Horizonte is less hot than Salvador.)
- **Minha irmã é mais velha do que eu.** (My sister is older than I am.)

The adjective agrees with the first noun, as usual: **A pizza é mais cara**, **Os pães são mais baratos**.

2 **Know that {{do que}} can be shortened to {{que}}**

In speech you will hear both **mais alto do que eu** and **mais alto que eu**. **Do que** is always correct and it is clearer, so use it. After it, use the **subject** pronoun: **do que eu**, not "do que mim".

3 **Compare equal things: {{tão}} + adjective + {{quanto}} (or {{como}})**

- **Ele é tão alto quanto o pai.** (He is as tall as his father.)
- **Aqui é tão caro quanto lá.** (It is as expensive here as there.)

4 **With nouns, use {{tanto}} and make it agree**

- **Tenho tanto trabalho quanto você.** (I have as much work as you.)
- **Ela tem tantos amigos quanto eu.** (She has as many friends as I do.)
- **Tem tanta gente quanto ontem.** (There are as many people as yesterday.)

5 **With numbers, use {{de}}, not {{que}}**

- **Vieram mais de vinte pessoas.** (More than twenty people came.)
- **Custa menos de cem reais.** (It costs less than a hundred reais.)

Four adjectives that do not use mais

Four common adjectives have their own comparative forms. Using **mais** with the first three is a mistake; **mais pequeno** exists, but in Brazil **menor** is the normal word. Learn them as pairs.

ADJECTIVE	COMPARATIVE	GUIDE	EXAMPLE
bom (good)	**melhor** (better)	meh-LYAWR	**Este café é melhor do que aquele.**
mau, ruim (bad)	**pior** (worse)	pyawr	**O tempo hoje está pior do que ontem.**
grande (big)	**maior** (bigger)	mah-YAWR	**A minha casa é maior do que a sua.**
pequeno (small)	**menor** (smaller)	meh-NAWR	**O quarto é menor do que a sala.**

Melhor and **pior** also work as adverbs: **Ela fala melhor do que eu** (She speaks better than I do); **Eu durmo pior no calor** (I sleep worse in the heat). For size, **maior** and **menor** are the usual words. For age, **mais velho** and **mais novo**: **Meu irmão é mais novo do que eu**.

WATCH OUT

Never say ~~mais bom~~, ~~mais ruim~~, ~~mais grande~~. Use **melhor**, **pior** and **maior**. One apparent exception: in speech you may hear **mais ruim**, but **pior** is the form to use and write.

The most: the superlative

Put the article before **mais** and use **de** (or **do**, **da**) for "in" or "of".

- **Esse é o prato mais caro do cardápio.** (This is the most expensive dish on the menu.)
- **A Clara é a pessoa mais simpática do prédio.** (Clara is the nicest person in the building.)
- **Estes são os melhores pães da cidade.** (These are the best breads in town.)
- **O pior dia foi segunda-feira.** (The worst day was Monday.)

Reinforcing the comparison

PORTUGUESE	MEANING
muito mais barato / **bem mais barato**	much cheaper
um pouco mais caro	a bit more expensive
cada vez mais	more and more
mais ou menos	so-so, approximately
Quanto mais eu estudo, mais eu aprendo.	The more I study, the more I learn.

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Ele é mais alto que de mim.~~	**Ele é mais alto do que eu.**	after **que** use the subject pronoun
~~Esse hotel é mais bom.~~	**Esse hotel é melhor.**	**melhor**, not **mais bom**
~~Tem mais que vinte pessoas.~~	**Tem mais de vinte pessoas.**	numbers take **de**
~~Ela é tão alta como mim.~~	**Ela é tão alta quanto eu.**	the subject pronoun, not **mim**
~~Tenho tanto amigos quanto você.~~	**Tenho tantos amigos quanto você.**	**tanto** agrees with its noun

13.3 Giving instructions: the imperative

The trap: English has one command form, Portuguese has two registers

English says *Open the door!* to anyone: a friend, a stranger, a child. Portuguese has the formal command, which is the form in grammars, on signs and in instructions, and the everyday command, which is the form you hear among

friends.

The formal command (você, vocês)

The command for **você** and **vocês** is built from the **eu** form of the present. Take the **eu** form, drop **-o**, and add the "opposite" vowel: **-e** for **-ar** verbs, **-a** for **-er** and **-ir** verbs. For **vocês**, add **-m**.

VERB	EU FORM	VOCÊ	VOCÊS	MEANING
falar	falo	fale FAH-lee	falem FAH-leh~ee	speak
comer	como	coma KOH-mah	comam KOH-mah~oo	eat
abrir	abro	abra AH-brah	abram AH-brah~oo	open
fazer	faço	faça FAH-sah	façam	do
dizer	digo	diga DJEE-gah	digam	say
ter	tenho	tenha TEH-nyah	tenham	have
vir	venho	venha VEH-nyah	venham	come
ver	vejo	veja VEH-zhah	vejam	see
trazer	trago	traga TRAH-gah	tragam	bring
sair	saio	saia SAH-yah	saiam	leave

The method gives all the irregulars of the **eu** form automatically (compare **faço** → **faça**). Five common verbs do not follow it (a sixth, **querer** → **queira**, is rare as a command). Learn them as they are.

VERB	VOCÊ	VOCÊS	GUIDE OF VOCÊ
ser	seja	sejam	SEH-zhah
estar	esteja	estejam	ehs-TEH-zhah
ir	vá	vão	vah
dar	dê	deem	deh
saber	saiba	saibam	SIE-bah

Verbs with a spelling pattern keep the sound: **ficar** → **fique** (FEE-kee), **pagar** → **pague** (PAH-gee), **chegar** → **chegue**, **começar** → **comece**.

Negative: put **não** before the same form: **Não fale**, **Não abra**, **Não se preocupe** (Don't worry).

With reflexive and object pronouns in the formal command, the pronoun traditionally follows the verb: **Sente-se**, **Divirta-se**, **Diga-me**. Negative commands put it before: **Não se preocupe**, **Não me diga**.

The everyday command

Among friends, in the street and at home, many Brazilians (especially in São Paulo and Rio) give commands with the plain present form of **você**, the same form as **ele**:

FORMAL, SIGNS, INSTRUCTIONS	EVERYDAY, FRIENDS
Fale mais devagar.	Fala mais devagar.
Venha cá.	Vem cá.
Espere um pouco.	Espera um pouco.

FORMAL, SIGNS, INSTRUCTIONS	EVERYDAY, FRIENDS
Me ligue depois.	**Me liga depois.**
Sente aqui.	**Senta aí.**
Pegue o ônibus.	**Pega o ônibus.**

You will hear both. Use the formal command (with **por favor**) with strangers, in shops, with older people and in writing. Understand the everyday command, and use it when you are with friends. Of the five irregular verbs above, **seja** is used in both registers, but among friends people say **Vai!** (not **Vá!**) and **Me dá…** (not **Me dê…**), and **Vem!** for **vir**.

> TIP
>
> **Vamos** + infinitive is a gentle command for "us": **Vamos comer?**, **Vamos sair?** The reply to a request is often **Claro!**, **Pode deixar!** (Leave it to me!), **Já vou!** (Coming!).

Signs and directions you will see

PORTUGUESE	GUIDE	MEANING
Puxe / **Empurre**	POO-shee / eh~-POO-hee	Pull / Push
Aguarde	ah-GWAR-djee	Wait
Não fume.		No smoking.
Pague na saída.		Pay at the exit.
Siga em frente.	SEE-gah eh~ee FREH~-tchee	Go straight ahead.
Vire à direita.	VEE-ree ah djee-RAY-tah	Turn right.
Vire à esquerda.	VEE-ree ah ehs-KER-dah	Turn left.
Atravesse a rua.	ah-trah-VEH-see ah HOO-ah	Cross the street.
É logo ali.	eh LAW-goo ah-LEE	It's right over there.

13.4 Asking politely

The trap: English has "please" and "could", Portuguese has a ladder of verb forms

In English, you can soften a request with *please* and *could*. In Portuguese, *por favor* is necessary but not sufficient. The verb form itself carries the politeness. Here is the ladder, from the most direct to the most careful.

LEVEL	PORTUGUESE	WHEN
1. Direct	**Quero um café.**	with a friend in a hurry, or with **por favor** in a bar
2. Informal request	**Me dá um café?** / **Me vê um café, por favor.**	in a café, a bakery, a bar
3. Neutral polite	**Eu queria um café, por favor.**	restaurants, shops: the standard
4. Polite question	**Pode me trazer um café?**	with the waiter
5. More polite	**Você poderia me trazer um café?**	with a stranger, an older person
6. Very formal	**Eu gostaria de um café.** / **Seria possível um café?**	hotels, offices, e-mails

1 Use {{queria}} for "I'd like"

Queria is the imperfect of **querer** (Lesson 11) used in the present to be polite. **Eu queria uma água** (I'd like a water). It is the most useful polite verb for a learner, because it works everywhere: **Eu queria saber o preço** (I'd like to know the price), **Queria um quarto para duas noites** (I'd like a room for two nights).

2 Use {{poderia}} for "could you"

Poderia is the conditional of **poder**. The conditional is formed by adding **-ia** endings to the **whole infinitive**: poder + ia.

VERB	EU, VOCÊ, ELE	NÓS	VOCÊS
poder	poderia poh-deh-REE-ah	poderíamos	poderiam
gostar	gostaria gohs-tah-REE-ah	gostaríamos	gostariam
dever	deveria deh-veh-REE-ah	deveríamos	deveriam
ser	seria seh-REE-ah	seríamos	seriam

At this level you need these four, which cover almost every polite sentence. A few common verbs have irregular conditionals (**fazer** → **faria**, **dizer** → **diria**, **trazer** → **traria**), but you can wait for them.

- **Você poderia repetir, por favor?** (Could you repeat that, please?)
- **Poderia me ajudar?** (Could you help me?)
- **O senhor poderia me dizer onde fica o banco?** (Could you tell me where the bank is, sir?)
- **Você deveria descansar um pouco.** (You should rest a little.)

3 Use {{gostaria de}} for formal "I'd like"

Gostaria takes **de**, like **gostar** (Lesson 8): **Gostaria de um quarto**, **Gostaria de falar com a gerente**, **Gostaríamos de reservar uma mesa**.

4 Soften with {{pode}}, {{dá pra}} or {{seria possível}}

- **Pode abrir a janela?** (Can you open the window?)
- **Dá pra abrir a janela?** (Is it possible to open the window?) A very common spoken form.
- **Seria possível trocar de mesa?** (Would it be possible to change tables?)

How to answer

TO SAY YES	TO SAY NO
Claro! / **Com certeza.**	**Desculpe, não posso.**
Pois não. (a clerk's "certainly")	**Infelizmente não dá.** (Unfortunately it's not possible.)
Pode deixar. / **Já trago.**	**Só um momento, por favor.** (Just a moment, please.)

Pois não poyss NOW~ has two meanings you should know. Said by a shop assistant at the start (**Pois não?**), it means "Yes? How can I help you?" Said as an answer to a request, it means "Certainly."

HOW IT COMPARES

IN ENGLISH	IN PORTUGUESE
I want a coffee. (blunt)	**Quero um café.** (blunt too: soften it)
I'd like a coffee, please.	**Eu queria um café, por favor.**

IN ENGLISH	IN PORTUGUESE
Could you…?	**Você poderia…?** / **Pode…?** / **Dá pra…?**
Would you mind…?	**Você se importaria de…?** (formal, recognition)

13.5 Por and para

The trap: English has "for" and "to", Portuguese has por and para with different jobs

English *for* can mean a goal, a recipient, a duration, a price, a reason. Portuguese divides those meanings between two words. The essential idea:

- **Para** looks **forward**: where you are going, what you want to achieve, who gets it.
- **Por** looks **at the road or the cause**: through where, because of what, in exchange for what, by which means.

USE PARA FOR…	EXAMPLE
destination	**Vou para São Paulo amanhã.**
purpose (+ infinitive)	**Estudo português para trabalhar no Brasil.**
recipient	**Este presente é para você.**
deadline	**Preciso do relatório para sexta-feira.**
intended use	**uma xícara para café**
opinion	**Para mim, o peixe é melhor.**
employer	**Ela trabalha para uma empresa grande.**

USE POR FOR…	EXAMPLE
cause, thanks	**Obrigada pela dica.**
through, along	**Passamos pelo centro.** / **Andei pela praia.**
duration	**Morei lá por dois anos.**
price, exchange	**Paguei vinte reais pelo livro.**
means	**Mandei por e-mail.** / **Falei pelo telefone.**
per, each	**dez reais por pessoa** / **duas vezes por semana**
fixed phrases	**por favor**, **por exemplo**, **por isso**, **por enquanto**

The contractions

Por fuses with the articles: **por** + **o** = **pelo**, **por** + **a** = **pela**, **por** + **os** = **pelos**, **por** + **as** = **pelas** (`PEH-loo` , `PEH-lah`). **Para** does not fuse in writing, but in speech it shrinks: **para** → **pra** and **para o** → **pro**, **para a** → **pra**: **Vou pro trabalho**, **Vou pra casa**. In writing, use **para**, **para o**, **para a**.

Pairs that show the difference

WITH PARA	WITH POR
Fiz isso para você. (I did it for you: as a gift, for you to have it)	**Fiz isso por você.** (I did it for you: for your sake, because of you)
Vou para o Rio. (I am going to Rio: destination)	**Passo pelo Rio.** (I go through Rio on the way)
Trabalho para o banco. (My employer is the bank)	**Trabalho pelo dinheiro.** (Money is why I work)

TIP

Test: if you can put "in order to" in the English sentence, use **para** + infinitive. If you can put "because of" or "through", use **por**. For a place you are going to, **para**; for a place you go through or along, **por**.

The four "porquês"

The question "why?" and the answer "because" are written differently, and Brazilians care about it.

WRITTEN	USED FOR	EXAMPLE
por que (two words)	the question	**Por que você estuda português?**
porque (one word)	the answer, "because"	**Porque vou morar no Rio.**
por quê (with an accent)	at the end of a sentence	**Você não vai? Por quê?**
porquê (one word, accent)	the noun, "the reason"	**Não entendi o porquê.**

13.6 Joining ideas: que

The trap: English can leave out "that", Portuguese never can

The book I read is a complete English phrase. The Portuguese is **o livro que eu li**: the relative pronoun **que** cannot be left out. And **que** translates *that*, *which* and *who* alike.

FUNCTION	ENGLISH	PORTUGUESE
for a thing	*the dish that everybody orders*	**o prato que todo mundo pede**
for a person	*the woman who lives here*	**a mulher que mora aqui**
the object	*the film (that) I saw*	**o filme que eu vi**
after a verb of thought or speech	*I think (that) he is tired*	**Eu acho que ele está cansado.**

1 **Use {{que}} to link a clause to a noun**

Take two sentences: **Eu conheço uma mulher. Ela trabalha na embaixada.** Join them: **Eu conheço uma mulher que trabalha na embaixada.** The word **que** replaces the repeated noun (**ela**). Do not repeat the pronoun: ~~**O livro que eu li ele**~~.

2 **Add a preposition before {{que}} when the verb needs one**

- **O lugar em que eu moro** (the place where I live), or simply **O lugar onde eu moro.**
- **A pessoa com quem eu falei** (the person I talked to), with **quem** for people after a preposition.
- **O filme de que eu gosto** (the film I like). In speech, many Brazilians say **O filme que eu gosto**; the written norm keeps **de que**.

3 **Use {{onde}} for places**

A cidade onde eu nasci é pequena. O restaurante onde jantamos fecha às onze.

Que, o que, quem

WORD	USE	EXAMPLE
que	relative: who, that, which; or conjunction after a verb	**O prato que eu pedi**; **Eu acho que sim**
o que	what	**Não sei o que ele disse.** / **Tudo o que eu tenho**

WORD	USE	EXAMPLE
o que	which (referring to a whole idea)	Ele chegou atrasado, o que me irritou.
quem	who(m), after a preposition or as “the one who”	Quem chegou primeiro foi ela. / a pessoa de quem eu falei
onde	where	A rua onde eu moro

Cujo (whose) exists, but it is formal, and you only need to recognize it: **o homem cujo filho é médico**. In speech people say **o homem que o filho é médico**.

13.7 Putting it together

Read this e-mail aloud. It uses all five tools.

> Oi, Clara! Cheguei bem em casa. A viagem foi mais longa do que eu pensava, mas o voo estava tão tranquilo quanto o ônibus de Belo Horizonte! Obrigada por tudo: pela hospedagem, pela comida e pelas dicas. O restaurante que você recomendou é o melhor da cidade, e nunca vou esquecer o peixe que comemos. Quando você puder, me manda uma mensagem. Se vier para cá, avise-me com antecedência: vou te levar para conhecer os lugares onde eu cresci. Um abraço, Emma.

Translation: *Hi, Clara! I got home safely. The trip was longer than I thought, but the flight was as calm as the bus in Belo Horizonte! Thank you for everything: for the hospitality, the food and the tips. The restaurant you recommended is the best in town, and I will never forget the fish we ate. When you can, send me a message. If you come here, let me know in advance: I will take you to see the places where I grew up. A hug, Emma.*

Two verbs in this e-mail, **puder** and **vier**, are in a form (the future subjunctive) that this book does not teach. Treat **Quando você puder** (when you can) and **Se vier** (if you come) as ready-made chunks. Now find the comparisons (**mais longa do que**, **tão tranquilo quanto**, **o melhor da cidade**), the command (**avise-me**, formal and written), the pronouns (**me manda**, **te levar**), **por** (**por tudo**, **pela hospedagem**, **pelas dicas**), **para** (**para cá**, **para conhecer**) and **que**/**onde** (**que você recomendou**, **que comemos**, **onde eu cresci**).

New words: **o voo** `oo VOH-oo` (the flight), **a hospedagem** `ah ohs-peh-DAH-zheh~ee` (the hospitality, lodging), **antecedência** `ah~-teh-seh-DEH~-see-ah` (advance notice), **crescer** `kreh-SER` (to grow up).

13.8 The mistakes English speakers make

TYPICAL MISTAKES

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Ele é mais alto do que mim.~~	Ele é mais alto do que eu.	after **do que** use the subject pronoun
~~Quero uma mesa. (to a waiter, as your first words)~~	Eu queria uma mesa, por favor.	**queria** is the polite “I’d like”; the blunt form sounds abrupt
~~Você poderia me ajuda?~~	Você poderia me ajudar?	after **poder** comes the infinitive

WRONG	RIGHT	WHY
~~Eu gostaria um quarto.~~	**Eu gostaria de um quarto.**	**gostar** and **gostaria** always take **de**
~~Fala mais devagar, por favor. (said to a stranger)~~	**Fale mais devagar, por favor.**	with strangers and older people, the formal command is safer
~~Obrigado para a ajuda.~~	**Obrigado pela ajuda.**	thanks use **por**
~~Estudo português por trabalhar no Brasil.~~	**Estudo português para trabalhar no Brasil.**	purpose uses **para** + infinitive
~~Vou por Salvador amanhã.~~	**Vou para Salvador amanhã.**	destination uses **para**
~~Paguei 20 reais para o livro.~~	**Paguei 20 reais pelo livro.**	price/exchange uses **por**
~~Por que? — Porque?~~	**Por quê? / Por que …? / Porque …**	four different words
~~O livro eu li é bom.~~	**O livro que eu li é bom.**	**que** cannot be left out
~~A mulher que ela mora aqui~~	**A mulher que mora aqui**	do not repeat the pronoun

13.9 Practice

PRACTICE · PART A: COMPARE

1. O ônibus é ___ barato ___ o táxi. (cheaper than)

2. Meu irmão é ___ alto ___ eu. (as tall as)

3. Esse restaurante é ___ do que aquele. (better)

4. O tempo hoje está ___ do que ontem. (worse)

5. Ela tem ___ amigos ___ eu. (as many … as)

6. Choose: **Vieram (a) mais que (b) mais de vinte pessoas.**

7. A Clara é a pessoa ___ simpática ___ prédio. (the nicest in the building)

8. Correct: **Esse sofá é mais bom do que aquele.**

PRACTICE · PART B: INSTRUCTIONS

Give the command for **você** unless stated otherwise.

1. **falar**

2. **comer**, for **vocês**

3. **abrir**, negative

4. **fazer**

5. **ser**

6. **ir**

7. Make it everyday speech with a friend: **Venha cá.**

8. Translate: *Turn left and go straight ahead.*

PRACTICE · PART C: POLITE REQUESTS

1. Order a coffee politely.

2. Ask a stranger to repeat something, using **poderia**.

3. At a hotel, ask for a room for two nights, using **gostaria**.

4. Order these requests from the most direct to the most polite: (a) **Quero a conta.** (b) **Poderia trazer a conta, por favor?** (c) **Me traz a conta?**

5. What does a shop assistant mean by **Pois não?**

PRACTICE · PART D: POR OR PARA?

1. **Esse presente é ___ você.**

2. **Obrigada ___ ajuda.** (por + a)

3. **Vou ___ São Paulo amanhã.**

4. **Paguei vinte reais ___ livro.** (por + o)

5. **Estudo português ___ trabalhar no Brasil.**

6. **Ela trabalha ___ uma empresa grande.**

7. **Vamos passar ___ centro.** (por + o)

8. **Pago mil reais ___ mês.**

9. **Mandei a mensagem ___ WhatsApp.** (por + o)

PRACTICE · PART E: JOIN AND DECIDE

1. Join: **O livro é bom. Eu li o livro.**

2. Join: **A mulher mora aqui. Ela é minha tia.**

3. **A cidade ___ eu nasci é pequena.** (onde / quem)

4. **A pessoa com ___ falei era simpática.** (que / quem)

5. Complete: **___ você estuda português? — ___ vou morar no Brasil.**

6. Write three sentences: one comparing two cities, one polite request, one command to a friend.

ANSWER KEY

1. **mais … do que**: **O ônibus é mais barato do que o táxi.**
2. **tão … quanto**: **Meu irmão é tão alto quanto eu.**
3. **melhor**.
4. **pior**.
5. **tantos … quanto**: **Ela tem tantos amigos quanto eu.**
6. (b) **mais de vinte pessoas**: numbers take **de**.
7. **mais … do**: **A Clara é a pessoa mais simpática do prédio.**
8. **Esse sofá é melhor do que aquele.**
9. **Fale.**
10. **Comam.**
11. **Não abra.**
12. **Faça.**
13. **Seja.**
14. **Vá.**
15. **Vem cá.**
16. **Vire à esquerda e siga em frente.**
17. **Eu queria um café, por favor.**
18. **Você poderia repetir, por favor?**
19. **Eu gostaria de um quarto para duas noites.**
20. (a), (c), (b): **Quero a conta** is the most direct; **Me traz a conta?** is informal; **Poderia trazer a conta, por favor?** is the most polite.
21. "Yes? How can I help you?" at the start of the service. It is not a refusal.
22. **para**: recipient.
23. **pela**: thanks.
24. **para**: destination.
25. **pelo**: price.
26. **para**: purpose, followed by an infinitive.
27. **para**: employer.
28. **pelo**: through.
29. **por**: per (month).
30. **pelo**: means.
31. **O livro que eu li é bom.**
32. **A mulher que mora aqui é minha tia.**
33. **onde**.
34. **quem**: a person after a preposition.
35. **Por que** … **Porque**.
36. Check that you used **mais … do que** (or **melhor**), that your request has **queria**, **poderia** or **gostaria**, and that the command has the correct form. A model: **O Rio é maior do que Belo Horizonte. Você poderia me ajudar, por favor? Vem cá!**

13.10 Return

Before you go on, answer from earlier lessons, without looking:

1. How do you say *I like coffee more than tea* (Lesson 8) with **gosto**?
2. How do you say *he called me yesterday*? (Lesson 12)
3. How do you say *when I was a child, we used to go to the beach*? (Lesson 11)

Model answers: 1. **Gosto mais de café do que de chá.** 2. **Ele me ligou ontem.** 3. **Quando eu era criança, a gente ia à praia.**

Come back to Part A, Part C and Part D after one day, three days, a week and two weeks.

13.11 Pocket summary: Lesson 13

POCKET SUMMARY

- **Compare:** mais/menos + adjective + do que: mais caro do que. Equal: tão … quanto, tanto(s)/tanta(s) … quanto. Numbers: mais de, menos de.
- **Irregular:** melhor, pior, maior, menor. Never mais bom.
- **Superlative:** o mais caro do cardápio, os melhores da cidade.
- **Imperative (você/vocês):** from the eu form, drop -o, add -e/-em for -ar or -a/-am for -er/-ir. Irregular: seja, esteja, vá, dê, saiba. Negative: não + the same form. Friends: Fala! Vem! Me liga!
- **Polite ladder:** Quero → Eu queria → Você poderia…? → Gostaria de… / Seria possível…? Plus Pode…?, Dá pra…?.
- **Para:** destination, purpose (+ infinitive), recipient, deadline, opinion. **Por:** cause, through, duration, price, means, per. pelo, pela; spoken pro, pra.
- **Porquês:** por que (question), porque (because), por quê (end), porquê (the reason).
- **Que:** links clauses, never omitted: o livro que eu li. With a preposition: em que / onde, com quem. O que: what, and "which" for a whole idea.

13.12 A2 checkpoint

You have reached the end of the book. This checklist shows what you should be able to do in Portuguese now. Take it slowly, with a pen. For each statement, test yourself out loud or in writing. Tick a statement only when you can do it **without looking at the lesson**.

1. **Sounds (Lesson 1).** I can read any Portuguese word aloud with the right stress, a nasal vowel (pão), the *tch* and *dj* sounds (dia, noite), and the "h" sound of the initial *r* (rua), and spell my name with the Portuguese letter names. *Test:* read the paragraph in Lesson 1.13 aloud, then spell your full name.
2. **Who I am (Lesson 2).** I can say who I am, where I am from, my nationality and my job with ser, use eu, você, a gente, nós, vocês, eles correctly, and make adjectives agree. *Test:* introduce yourself and a friend in six sentences.
3. **Things (Lesson 3).** I can choose o, a, os, as, um, uma correctly, guess gender from the ending, make plurals, and use no, na, do, da. *Test:* name ten objects in your room with the right article.
4. **Habits and questions (Lesson 4).** I can use regular -ar, -er and -ir verbs in the present, make negatives with não, and ask with quem, o que, onde, quando, como. *Test:* write five things you do on Saturday and five questions to a friend.
5. **Being, having and existing (Lesson 5).** I can choose between ser and estar, say where things are, and say that something exists with tem or há. *Test:* describe your bedroom in six sentences.
6. **Numbers and time (Lesson 6).** I can say numbers up to a thousand, tell the time, say a date and ask and give a price. *Test:* say today's date, the time, and the price of a coffee.
7. **Wanting and being able (Lesson 7).** I can use ir, ter, fazer, poder, querer, saber, vir, dizer, ver in the present, and distinguish saber from conhecer. *Test:* ask three polite questions with poder and say three things you want to do.
8. **Mine, yours, this one (Lesson 8).** I can say whose something is with meu, seu, dele, dela, point with esse, aquele, aqui, ali, and say what I like and prefer with gostar de and preferir. *Test:* talk for thirty seconds about your family and what you like.
9. **My day and my plans (Lesson 9).** I can describe my routine with reflexive verbs, say what I am going to do with ir + infinitive, and say what I am doing with estar + gerund. *Test:* describe a normal day, tomorrow's plan and what you are doing now.
10. **The past (Lessons 10 and 11).** I can tell what happened with the simple past (fui, fiz, vi, comi), describe how things were with the imperfect (era, tinha, morava) and choose between them. *Test:* tell a ten-sentence story about last weekend, with at least three descriptions.
11. **Small words (Lesson 12).** I can use me and te before the verb, say vi ele and dei pra ela as Brazilians do, use mim, comigo and para eu fazer, and ask Você pode me ajudar? *Test:* write five messages to a friend with me or te.

12. **Asking, comparing, joining (Lesson 13).** I can compare things, give an instruction or a direction, make a request with **queria**, **poderia** or **gostaria**, choose **por** or **para**, and join ideas with **que**. *Test:* in a restaurant role-play, ask for a table, a recommendation and the bill.

How to read your result. If you can tick **ten to twelve**, you work comfortably at the A2 level and are ready to move on to the next book. If you tick **seven to nine**, go back to the lessons you did not tick and redo their practice before moving on. If you tick **fewer than seven**, do not worry: go back to the first lesson you did not tick and work forward one lesson per week, saying every exercise aloud. In every case, spend ten minutes a day listening to Brazilian Portuguese: podcasts, music, WhatsApp voice messages from your friends. The grammar in this book is the skeleton; the listening will give it flesh.

13.13 What comes next

This is the last lesson of the book. You started by learning to read **bom dia** aloud. You can now tell a story, ask for things politely, find your way around a Brazilian city, and make a friend feel that you are speaking their language. The next step is to use it every day: with Clara's cake, Seu Antônio's stories, a WhatsApp group, a short trip. At the A2 level you will make mistakes. That is not a problem. Brazilians are generous with learners, and every mistake you correct brings you closer to a natural voice.

Parabéns, e até logo!

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